

THE MORETTI CHRONICLES

ISLE OF  
*Pain*



C. J. L U C C I

# ISLE OF PAIN

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## A FEMDOM MAFIA ROMANCE

THE MORETTI CHRONICLES

BOOK 3

**C.J. LUCCI**



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*For all my babes who love a good “men whimpering” playlist on audio erotica apps. Thank the naughty gods for Quinn and dedicated Patreons.*



*And for those who found solace and healing in the arms of the one they didn't expect.*

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# CONTENTS

[Foreward & Trigger Warnings](#)

[Glossary](#)

[Playlist](#)

1. [Marie](#)
2. [Nico](#)
3. [Nico](#)
4. [Marie](#)
5. [Nico](#)
6. [Marie](#)
7. [Marie](#)
8. [Nico](#)
9. [Marie](#)
10. [Marie](#)
11. [Marie](#)
12. [Nico](#)
13. [Marie](#)
14. [Nico](#)
15. [Marie](#)
16. [Marie](#)
17. [Nico](#)
18. [Marie](#)
19. [Marie](#)
20. [Nico](#)
21. [Marie](#)
22. [Nico](#)
23. [Nico](#)
24. [Nico](#)
25. [Marie](#)
26. [Nico](#)
27. [Marie](#)
28. [Nico](#)
29. [Marie](#)

30. [Nico](#)
31. [Marie](#)
32. [Marie](#)
33. [Nico](#)
34. [Marie](#)
35. [Nico](#)
36. [Marie](#)
37. [Nico](#)
38. [Julian](#)
39. [Nico](#)
40. [Marie](#)
41. [Marie](#)
42. [Nico](#)
43. [Nico](#)
44. [Marie](#)

[TEN YEARS LATER](#)

[Acknowledgments](#)

[About the Author](#)

[Also by C.J. Lucci](#)

[\*OceanofPDF.com\*](#)

## FOREWARD & TRIGGER WARNINGS

**Please note that most of the story deals with alcoholism and cancer, which I know to be big triggers for many people. Please, prioritise your mental health.**



Dear readers,

Thank you so much for picking up ISLE OF PAIN.

This book is the perfect example of sweat, tears and blood to come into life. Their story is raw and I hope you'll fall in love with them as much as I have. Before you read it, know that this story isn't for the faint of heart. It touches upon uterine cancer and how it affects the people who survive their loved ones.

Part of this story happens on the imaginary island of Kalliste, heavily inspired by Corsica where my family originates from. The characters will be speaking a few words of **Corsican** language throughout the book, as well as Italian. Both languages are very similar but are *not* the same. The glossary provided on the next page will help to know the translation and correct spelling, depending on the language.

West Hill, the city in which most of the action takes place, is fictional but set in the UK.

TWs include: Fear of death, dying during pregnancy, pregnancy complications, cancer, purging mentions, OCD, BDSM, consent violations, boundary pushing, attempted rape, pedophilia (mentioned, not graphic, not related to any of the main characters), murder, needles, drugging, alcoholism, torture, medical procedures, neglect, death, grief, child abuse, emotional abuse, PTSD, stalking, domestic violence, suicidal ideas, gaslighting, physical abuse, gore, blood, forced hospitalisation mentions, spousal abuse mentions, assault mentions, trafficking mentions, fire, death by fire, rehab, adoption, graphic death/violence, enucleation (removal of eye as a torture “technique”), addiction recovery, vomit, hallucinations, self harm, strained family relations.

Kinks include: Humiliation, ownership, ruby (blood) play, breeding kink, marking, bratting, dom/sub, degradation, body worship, pegging, asphyxiation, collaring, almost caught, whips and restraints.

Some kink scenes are dramatised for storytelling purposes. This book should not be taken as a “how to”. If you’re interested in engaging in BDSM Lifestyle, read non-fiction books that are tailored to your needs.

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# GLOSSARY

## CORSICAN:

**Arcu di sera, tempu di spera** - Literally, “rainbow in the evening means good weather the next day”, meaning that after rain always comes the rainbow.

**Ciucciarella** - A nickname for a little girl, not to be used as a pet name between lovers

**Mammona** - grand-mother

**Patrimonio** - A grape variety, that only grows in the region on Patrimonio, in Corsica (usually, red wine)

**Picculina** - little one (for a girl), affectionate between family members or friends, can be used as a pet name

**U mu sole** - my sun, used a pet name

**Zia** - Aunt

## ITALIAN:

**Carina** - my dear

**Fratello** - brother

**Fratellino** - little brother

**Luna Mia** - my little moon

**Zio** - Uncle

# PLAYLIST

IT'S VERY EMO, AND I'M NOT EVEN SORRY ABOUT IT

MEDICATE ME - Rain City Drive, Dayseeker

MY IMMORTAL - Evanescence

SLEEPTALK - Dayseeker

LIKE A VILLAIN - Bad Omens

AFTER CARE - Nessa Barrett

GLITTER AND VIOLENCE - Nessa Barrett

THE APPARITION - Sleep Token

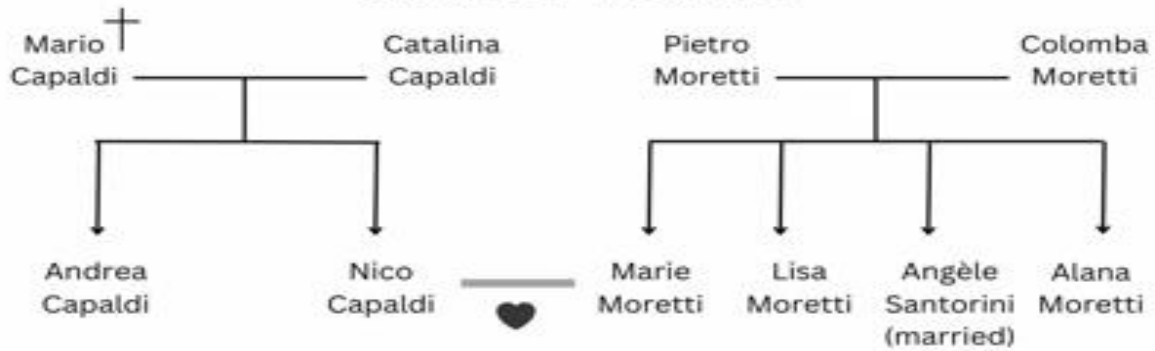
GONE OR STAYING - Sleep Theory

ROSES - Awaken I Am

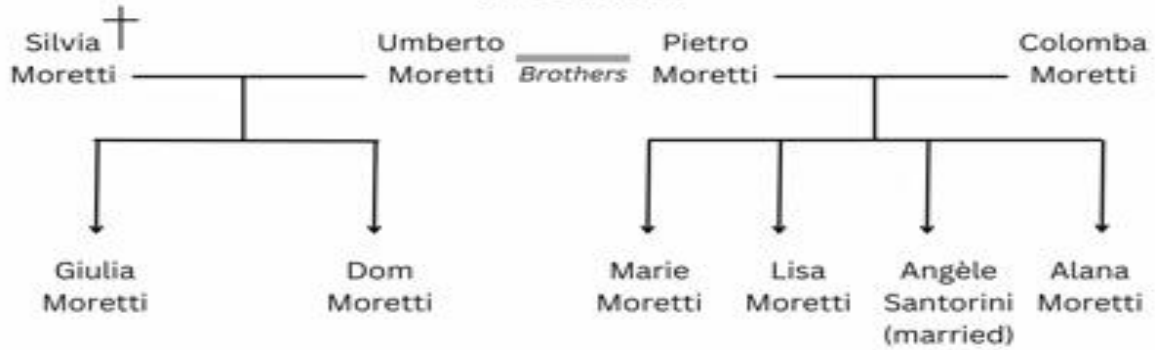
PRAYING - Isabel LaRosa

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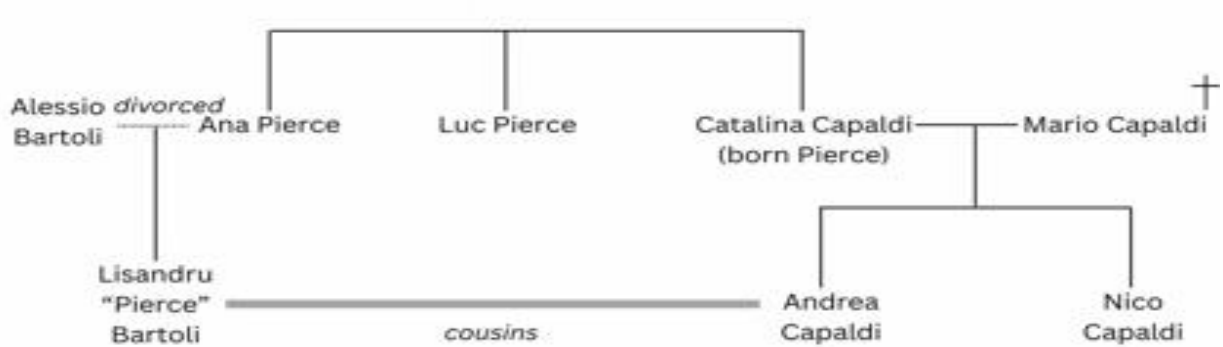
## CAPALDI - MORETTI



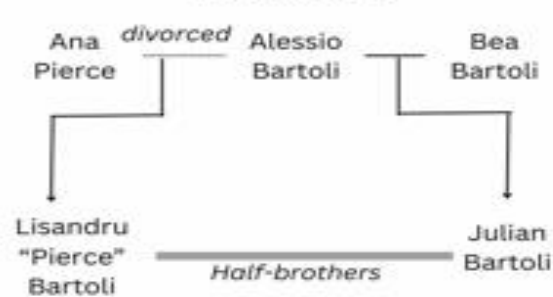
## MORETTI



## PIERCE - CAPALDI



## BARTOLI



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# MARIE

OMENS AND CHOICES



The day I find out my twin sister is pregnant is also the day I realise she might die.

Lisa missed her period and if there's one thing we're really good at, us Moretti twins, it's being perfectly on time and perfectly in sync. I clock her out after two days. We share a bathroom at our father's mansion, our bedrooms connecting through the double door space, and Lisa can be quite messy. The absence of blood on the porcelain bowl of the toilet alerts me immediately to her situation. That and the fact that she keeps sneaking around with her new security detail, Hugo. Poor guy is as good as dead now. Lisa knew our father would kill him if they ever got caught but she did it anyway. So did he, for that matter. Maybe Lana, our sister and new Head of the family, will do it. She's lenient, but not that much. If you take a job protecting the daughter of a retired mafia boss and sister of the *current* boss, you better know how to keep it in your pants. Hugo, I'm sure, never thought he'd get caught.

I can't blame Lisa though. She lives for the thrill and it's the only freedom we really have with being perfect little mafia princesses, born and bred for this life even if we're raised as if our family is squeaky clean. The thought makes me want to reach for what's inside my small black purse.

It's been too long, but I need to wait a little longer.

Where Lisa loses herself with unprotected sex with the man who's supposed to protect her—and maybe soon, motherhood—I have other

outlets.

I refrain and focus on the round clock hanging from the sterile white wall of the doctor's office waiting room. The hands of the clock tick loudly and I'm painfully aware that my heart is twice as fast. It pounds in my ears, and the back of my neck dampens with a light sheen of sweat despite the November air reaching inside the building. My long black hair sticks to my nape uncomfortably, but at least it hides any traces of my discomfort.

I could always go to the bathroom and get what I need. Lisa wouldn't notice, she's too busy chewing on her nails, buzzing with both fear and excitement.

Since we were three or four years-old, Lisa's always talked about having a big family, with four or more children, 'just like mamma'.

Our mother had four girls. Angèle is the oldest. Married to the media tycoon of Kalliste island, she lives for her husband and his ambitions, which serve the Morettis well. After all, the small Mediterranean island we live on might have its own government, but in reality, it belongs to my family. Alana—Lana—is the official head of the Morettis, and engaged to our business partner's son, Lisandru Bartoli. They love each other so much it's nauseating to be around them but after what she went through during her first marriage, I'm glad she found him.

And then, there's us. The two misfits. Twenty year-old, and no idea what we're doing.

At least I don't.

I have no clue what I want or who I am. Our family has always wanted to keep us safe so we've been raised away from any shady dealings and dangerous activities. What they did without realising it, is alienating us from the rest of them. I have everything I could ever want, yet everything scares me so much I have panic attacks. And I'm always alone. Alone with Lisa, but alone all the same. Forgotten and discarded, kept away as too precious, too fragile, too young.

Actually, I know exactly what I want *right now* and my skin prickles with the need for it.

Before I can make a move, the ob/gyn appears in the threshold of her office, wearing a white coat that does nothing to settle my nerves or Lisa's.

It took us far too long to come up with an excuse and have our security drive us here but thank God for basic men's aversion to anything related to

period and vulvas—except when it comes to sticking their dicks into them. They didn't want to hear why we needed to go, and our mother didn't pry.

We make our way into Dr Olmeto's office and Lisa clasps my hand in hers, the other one pulling at the threads of her ripped jeans. We've only ever counted on each other. I'd never let her go through anything alone. I squeeze her fingers and give her a reassuring smile. Her shoulders drop slightly and she releases a heavy sigh.

After the introduction, Dr Olmeto guides Lisa onto the examination table. The leather creaks as she lays down. She moves the oversized black sweater to reveal her flat pierced belly and I stand at her head, but keep her hand in mine.

"Alright Miss Moretti, take a deep breath and relax for me, please," she instructs.

Lisa giggles and it takes her a few minutes before she settles, her dark green eyes an exact replica of mine and shining with mischief. She looks at me and I know exactly where her mind went.

"Ew, gross, Lili," I whisper.

She beams a salacious smile. The moment helps diffuse the tension, and the ob/gyn can start her examination, her lips twitching with amusement.

As the doctor glides the transducer for the ultrasound on Lisa's lower belly, she frowns and remains silent.

The seconds tick by, but Dr Olmeto's face doesn't show the joy you'd expect from someone who's about to announce your sister is having a baby.

"Congratulations Miss Moretti. You're pregnant." Her voice sounds like a dull blade in the silent room. "I'll print the sonogram and come back in a moment."

She disappears behind her door. The ominous air suffocates us.

"Do you think there's something wrong with her?" Lisa asks, more fragile than I've ever seen her. Her radiant and glowing olive skin is sullen with unnatural grey under her eyes.

"Her?"

"Yeah, it's a girl. I know it."

"Lili, right now, it's a peanut and not even viable." I roll my eyes, but Lisa winces and I regret my words. I'd never tell her but I'm already jealous of what's growing inside her. Despite having everything I could ever ask for, a loving family and protection at all times, Lisa is the only person that never lies to me, never hides from me. She's the only person that feels like

she's mine. We understand each other without words. She knows when I need her quiet presence or her pink chaos. When I can live vicariously through her as she gets a piercing—which I never had the courage to do—or when I just want to lay my head on her lap while she reads.

We're deeply entwined. No one gets it. But it's fine because I have her, and she has me.

"I'm sorry, Lili," I tell her then kiss her cheek. "What I mean is that you don't know yet."

"I do, Mimi," she says, my nickname making me wince. She's the only one who uses it. She's the only one allowed to use it. It's horrendous. But nothing she does or says can ever be wrong.

Dr Olmeto comes back into the room and rolls a new echogram machine by Lisa's bedside.

"Miss Moretti, while doing the echo just now, there was some feedback on the screen that I'd like to check more precisely. This,—” She shows a prong with a blunt head that looks like a dildo but with a very thin body. "Is going to allow me to take better images of your vagina, cervix and uterus. Are you okay with that?"

With a nervous nod, Lisa agrees.

"You can remove your jeans and underwear behind this curtain."

Dr Olmeto motions to the small changing space with her hand and remains turned towards the screen of the beeping machine. I turn around as well as my sister removes her clothes then sits back on the examination table. A sheet is placed over her body and I keep myself angled towards the monitor to give her privacy.

When Dr Olmeto sets out to do her task, the images on this machine are way clearer than the other one but I'm still not sure what she's looking for.

She shows us the embryo on the screen and Lisa sobs, squeezing my hand. I find myself smiling at the screen. After all, maybe having a little extra piece of my sister is exactly what I need in my life.

I tilt my head to the side. It's so small.

"I also see a mass and I don't like the look of it. I'd like to do a biopsy, to make sure nothing's amiss," the doctor says.

She sends us home after collecting cells from Lisa's cervix and endometrial tissue, and prescribing me with the pill. Not that I'll make use of it but it makes me feel better. I'll have to make sure not to make myself sick. It hasn't happened in a while, and won't matter much if I vomit it into



the toilet since I'm a virgin and not planning to fuck anyone, but you never know.

Maybe I'll meet someone who isn't in the mafia and Lana will allow me to marry them. One can only dream of escaping their destiny.



THE FOLLOWING WEEK, December brings cold winds from the sea as we make our way back to Dr Olmeto's office. The white walls and stainless steel appliances give me the creeps. I unconsciously shake my right leg, bouncing on the ball of my foot, then trace my fingers over the shape inside the clutch I carry. I'll get to that soon, thankfully.

"Thank you for coming back, Miss Moretti. Have a seat," the doctor says, addressing my sister who sits next to me, the portrait of grunge rock fun with her leopard print legging, Dr Martens boots and an oversized flannel shirt draped over a plain white tee-shirt with a massive fuck in the middle. Where I decided to blend in and dress in a conventional black wool dress that accentuates the curves of my body subtly, she sticks out like a sore thumb in the middle of all of the posh high society Sant Armellu women, but she's still beaming with joy.

Being pregnant looks good on her, I guess.

"The biopsy results came in last night." Dr Olmeto takes a deep breath in and I brace for what's next.

I already know.

I didn't want to believe it.

I let myself get swept up by Lisa's joy, by covering for her so our family doesn't discover her secret until she's ready.

But deep down, I know.

I'm going to lose her.

"You have Stage Two uterine cancer."

Lisa slaps her hand over her mouth, a mournful sob escaping her.

I'm frozen. My limbs become numb as I listen to Dr Olmeto's professional voice. "About three percent of all people assigned female at birth that are diagnosed with uterine cancer have what's called a sarcoma.

It's a rare type of cancer that forms in the muscles or tissues of your uterus."

She shows us pictures on her desktop but all I can think about is how do we get rid of it.

"Is it operable?" I ask, hearing my own voice as if through a fishbowl.

"Yes, we can operate next week and remove your uterus, Lisa. Because you're in stage two and the cancer has spread, we'll also remove the cervix."

"No."

I look at my sister. Her eyes are full of tears that won't fall but her shoulders are set and she has this fierce aura that I know and love about her. Right now, I hate it with all that I am. I hate her resolve so much I want to shake her so she sees reason. I want to slap her, yell at her.

And I do nothing.

I just watch as Dr Olmeto explains the risk of going through with the pregnancy and her chance of survival after.

I finally find my voice. "Lili, you can't be serious."

"I'm very serious, Mimi. Having a child is all I've ever wanted," she argues. "I'm not giving her up. There's a ninety percent chance of survival."

"The first year! What about five years from now? How much then?" I yell and turn my gaze to the doctor who grimaces but answers, "Seventy-five percent".

"That's a twenty-five percent chance of dying. For what? An embryo? You can adopt. You can live."

I stand and pace back and forth in the tiny office space, crawling out of my skin. Anger rises in my veins and I have nowhere to fucking put it.

"I know, Mimi, but that's not what I want," my sister says, her voice way too compassionate, too placating. "This is my only chance to be pregnant. I'm taking it and I don't care what you think. I love you more than anything in this world, but this is for me." She turns to her ob/gyn. "I'll be in touch." Then she says to me, "Don't follow me, I can't be close to you right now."

I watch her back, her long black hair swaying side to side as she leaves.

I sit back down and press my hands to my eyes, hoping to pierce them until I reach my brain and get it out of my head. My heart breaks into shards that lay at my feet in a bloody display of pain and exhaustion.

Dr Olmeto hands me a card. “This is a colleague of mine. They’re a psychiatrist. Think about it.”

I take the card and nod, my vision blurred with tears. I have no plans of using it and throw it in the trash on my way out.

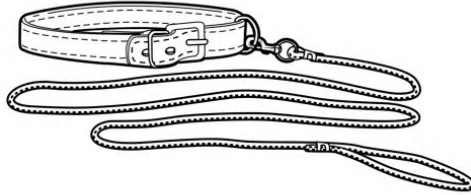
I don’t tell the good doctor that it doesn’t matter that Lisa lives right now. I can already see the sombre shadow surrounding her and I bet when I’ll reach for the bottle in my bag and find myself at the bottom of it later tonight, it’ll have magnified to encompass her entire being. I’m gonna lose her and all I can do is watch as she destroys herself for a life that isn’t even born.

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## NICO

TRUST YOUR INSTINCTS



The collar around my throat tightens as the dominatrix pulls on it to get me to follow her around Absolution, the club I own. My knees and palms scrape against the cool marble floor as I crawl on all fours, denim chafing where it meets the onyx surface. The sound of her heels in front of me echoes in my ears, a rhythmic *tac tac* on two beats.

I prefer the number three. Always have. Two can easily become one. Three is indivisible. Technically both two and three are prime numbers, but I don't like two. I can't explain it, it's a feeling in the fabric of who I am.

I usually enjoy this particular brand of humiliation—being paraded around on my knees—but this new play partner has not followed my demands when it comes to punishments and rewards.

She's new. And soft.

Dressed in nothing but black lace, her leather boots travel all the way up her thighs and indent her skin in what most would consider an enticing fashion. I think it looks tacky.

I give her the benefit of the doubt but deep down, I know our incompatibility.

This person doesn't want submission or control, she wants attention and that's one thing I'm not giving freely. Especially since my mind never shuts up and usually either replays the conversations of the day or the nightmares of the fire that consumed my father's life.

The only way to shut the window to my past is for the whip to lick my skin until I bleed. It's for my partner to take control of me until all I see is them.

*She* doesn't have what it takes, I can tell. My mind is already drawn to watch the feet of everyone else in the club. I'm not focused on her as I should be. As she should demand.

My profile is explicitly set to masochist. If you're not a sadist, don't even bother playing with me. I need pain before I need anything else. I certainly don't want strangers to touch me.

She did.

I almost safe-worded her when her hand glided against my scalp as I knelt at her feet, head bowed. I recoiled and stopped giving her my submission. My face must have said what I didn't.

It pissed her off and now she's dragging me across the hard unyielding floor of the club while soft red light dances from the silver metal sconces on the dark walls and illuminates the hungry stares of our audience.

That's all I wanted anyway. As we near the St Andrews' cross, my mouth salivates with anticipation.

I rejected her and she's going to take it out on my body.

Finally, the voices that remind me that my father died because of my carelessness will be silenced. There won't be societal pressure to be anything but the monstrous killer that I am.

To be punished for it is the only way that will actually save me.

We pass a few people on our way to the dais. Leering faces and bodies in different states of undress. Some kneel at the heels of their dominants, others are getting fucked but still turn their curious and lustful gaze to the spectacle about to happen. I recognise all of them including previous partners.

Damian, one of my favourites and my business partner, winks as I crawl but my eyes remain focused on my goal.

"Go on, sweet thing, get up." Even her voice grates on my nerves, nasal and high in pitch.

I roll my eyes at the pet name as I stand up and click my tongue. "I'm not sweet, *Mistress*," I say, her title coming out as an insult in my mouth.

Her ears turn red before her face does and she slaps me. I press my lips together to hold the smile that wants to take over my face.

I'm usually not a brat.

I like order and consistency and I have impeccable control of myself.

I'm pushing her to safe-word *me* so she can be replaced by someone else. Someone who can actually handle me. She doesn't. After I remove my jeans and boxers, she fastens my arms to the cross. My legs follow. I hold my breath, ants crawling up my skin at the perspective that she might cop a feel as she ties me up but thankfully, she doesn't.

My naked body is on display. All eyes turn to us and my cock hardens and leaks at the tip. My current mistress uses her thumb to gather the drop of pre-cum.

"Orange," I hiss, loud enough for everyone to hear and frown at the colour system we use to keep each other safe. Green for 'continue', orange for 'slow down', red for 'stop', a secondary safe-word everyone knows on the spot. I lower my voice, just for her, and add, "touching is a hard limit."

She smirks and brings her red-nailed thumb to her mouth. "With me, it won't be," she whispers.

The only reason I don't stop this charade here and there is the promise of the whip.

The dominatrix takes the riding crop from where it hangs on the silver display wall and without a warning, she brings it down to my right thigh with a resounding smack. I revel in it, goosebumps rising on my skin from where she hit.

I exhale heavily. This is what I need. This is my absolution. This is what will help.

Over and over, she brings the torture device on my flesh. My thighs heat with the burn of her blows, covered in angry red marks. But this is just an appetiser.

Soon, the sting almost disappears to give way to a fuzzy feeling that spreads from the place of the red marks down to my toes and up to my groin. But it's not enough. And she knows it.

With a smile, she replaces the crop with a braided leather flogger. Sleek black, it looks elegant and tantalising in her hands. But I only have eyes for the thirty tails, not the wielder.

"Count, slut," she spits, forcefully dragging my attention back to her as she whips the flogger on my thighs again, dangerously close to my cock and balls. Her aim is unfocused and unsteady, and I clench my jaw shut, refusing to give her what she wants most.

I moan when the whip swings across a place where the burn of the crop was already vivid. My partner moves up to my belly and sides. A true novice if I ever saw one. Or someone who wants to hurt for the sake of hurting, not give pleasure in an exchange of power we both chose.

“Orange,” I groan as the end of the tails swoosh against my crotch again, tingling but not hurting. Yet.

She pants, red with anger, her make-up starting to run where sweat gathers at her hairline. Dropping the tool to the floor, her blonde hair escapes my peripheral vision but I hear the ruffling in one of the drawers behind us.

The sombre classical music I couldn’t hear before gets louder as I refocus on the scene before me. Writhing bodies coated with fluids of all kinds move before me in a tableau I would usually indulge in with delight. But my companion hasn’t reappeared and she didn’t communicate her intentions.

My cock deflates and I turn my head to see her and stop the scene.

When I can’t find her near, I look forward again. My eyes lock with Damian, who’s frowning. His dark blue eyes are riveted to what’s happening behind me, concern etched on his clean-shaven face. Before they widen and he steps forward in a hurried movement, so unlike his very controlled self.

I understand why a second later when a blunt and lubricated object is pressed at my asshole from behind and under the cross. Cold sweat erupts on my skin and a shiver of disgust makes its way over my body, bile rising in my throat.

“Fire!” I spit my safe-word, startling the crowd, as Damian rushes to me.

“Stop her,” he orders the two security guards standing by. They charge forward, pushing screaming bodies out of their way.

Before the dildo can make its way inside me, the person who played pretend at being a domme is wrenched from the stage by the burly security men. Damian removes my bindings quickly and tries to usher me to the room next door, handing me my discarded clothes.

But all I see is my prey.

I stalk to her, naked as the day I was born, fuelled by rage and retribution. My hand connects with her throat as I push her against the wall,

and squeeze to cut her airways. Flames lick my skin where it connects to hers but I hold on for the sake of her pain.

She struggles against my hold, her nails scratching and drawing blood at my fist and forearm. I lift her enough so only the very tip of her toes reach the floor. Her face turns a pretty shade of purple. I cock my head to the side, enjoying the view of her struggle. When it's time to collect for Death, I love to hear the guilty cry and plead. She's no exception.

Damian and I created this club as a sanctuary for kinky souls and we pride ourselves on being a well-vetted and safe club. She taints that by simply breathing the same air we do.

Behind me, Damian asks Kyara, his wife and the third business partner in our venture, to handle the crowd. I barely hear the commotion anymore, focused only on making the liar in my hand pay. Her eyes roll in their socket as she struggles to breathe.

Damian presses a hand to my chest and I let her go. She slumps to the floor, heaving but alive. Not for long.

I suspect I'm not the only person she tried to rape.

I spit in her face. My voice is cold as death when I speak. "Don't let me see your face ever again."

She shivers and nods, tears streaming down her face. Why she cries when she's the one caught doing something she shouldn't have and receiving punishment for it is a mystery to me.

"Get her out of my sight," I tell the two guards then turn to walk to our office.

Damian follows, carrying my clothes and shoes. We don't talk. We don't need to.

I've known him for three years. He knows I don't need empty words or promises. Action speaks louder.

When we enter the lavish office, my feet warm on the soft Persian carpet. Damian hands me a robe and I put it on, then I take a seat on the modern indigo velvet sofa, my head falling back on an exhale. With the silence of the room, the marks on my skin come back to haunt me, reminding me that I wanted them so badly I closed my eyes to the presence of a predator in our midst.

I failed the club. I failed my partners. I failed the patrons.

I failed, again.

Like I'm destined to.



I hiss when a cold and watery substance is lathered onto my skin. My head whips up to see Damian rubbing ointment on my thighs. My lower belly contracts with each caring movement. I'm always so confused by my body's reaction to his kind ministrations. It makes me hot, but I'm also painfully aware of his attention on me, undivided. All-consuming.

He's the only one who's allowed to touch me and only during after-care. We've never had sex but he's an excellent Dominant, attune to my need for pain, with a deep sadistic streak. His wife is also his sub, but she doesn't like the pain like I do. I give him an outlet for his dark desires and in return, I receive the absolution I need. It's been working great for us. This was one of the only two other times someone else was allowed to play with me. The previous one had been Damian's trainee, and very good at respecting my boundaries. Maybe that's why I had hoped this one would too. But people always disappoint, in the end. I should have known better.

"Stop being such a baby, and let me care for you, Nico," he admonishes when I shuffle underneath his touch.

I'm not squirming because of the pain. It's the care he provides when he should be punishing me for being so reckless. I swallow hard and let him do what soothes him. I got hurt, even because of my own fault, and Damian is a giver by nature. I know he feels responsible since he vetted the person we just kicked out.

"I need her name, Damian."

It's an order and he knows it. He might be taking care of me now, but when his hands leave my body, I'll still be the angel of pain he can't stand. Damian doesn't know what I do for my brother Andrea, but he suspects. The Capaldi name has enough of a reputation. I certainly do.

I stand to put my clothes on then turn to him. Seated where I was, his head is down into his hands. He grips the strands too tight. He's gonna hurt himself if he continues.

I'm not inclined to remorse like he is. I prefer swift actions to counteract issues such as the one that arose tonight. A better vetting protocol. Removing problematic people. Permanently, if need be.

He utters the name I've been waiting for and I nod once then leave. His wife can comfort him. My phone is to my ear before I make it to my black Aston Martin Valhalla.

"What do you need?" Andrea asks.

"Find everything on Meg Anthony."

I hang up on my brother without ceremony. I've never understood people's need for useless chatter, greetings or goodbyes. They're inefficient communication, nothing but void words that occupy time and space needlessly.

The engine of my car roars to life when I turn the ignition, warmth and comfort spreading in my bloodstream as I speed through the streets of London. She can't be far.

I race with myself through the city, waiting on the information I'll need for tonight's mission. My personal vendetta. Though I doubt I will be avenging only myself.

Ten minutes later, the phone on the dashboard rings. Andrea's voice comes through.

"She's a piece of work, *fratellino*. Two restraining orders from male teenagers dating from three years ago. Used to work at Churchill High School in Camden until then. Couldn't find any other legal paperwork against her but..."

Giulia, my sister-in-law, finishes the sentence for him. "I found the notes of the kids' school therapist. She's a predator." Her usual chiming voice is low and cold, hate pouring from behind the phone.

I'm not surprised Andrea let her in on the research. She's just as good with uncovering secrets, and takes everything personally. Her loyalty to my brother has been hard earned and is still shaky most days, but she's an integral part to our small family unit. The three of us, I like the image.

"Thanks," I tell her.

"So, you've known Giulia for three months and *she* gets a thank you, when I've been your brother for twenty-six years and I get hung up on every time you need shit?" Andrea asks with both outrage and amusement.

I've learnt the best way to connect with people on a deeper level, especially family members and close friends, is through teasing. It's easier now with Giulia helping. They're both easy to rile up. All I need is to favour one or the other.

"She's nicer than you." I shrug though he can't see it. "And I like her better."

"You little shit!"

I smirk and hang up, shaking my head at my older brother's antics. Such a hot-blooded man. We couldn't be more different, and that's our strength.

My phone chimes with Meg's address and I make my way there in minutes, slaloming in between people who respect speed limits. Since my father taught me to only respect the laws that make sense, I've never driven like everyone else.

And I've killed more people than I can count. They all deserved it.

Now, I'm about to collect another wretched soul.

Many people think killing is an act of mania. A disgusting action born from a dark soul, with no purpose and no method. They couldn't be more wrong. Death is a methodical process. One I respect every step of.

She will die, without leaving a trace, like the cockroach she is.

I climb out of my car and up the stairs of the white three-story building she lives in, then knock on the door.

Wide eyes welcome me, but she opens the door for me. She's making this so easy, probably believing I came here to apologise. It's simple when people's beliefs and misconceptions play in my favour. I can use their own mind against them without lifting a finger.

Meg turns her back on me to pick a cup of tea up, and I strike. The syringe hidden in my right pocket enters the delicate skin of her neck, the drug I inject melting into her system in seconds. I always have a few handy in my car.

"What are you doing?" She screeches and struggles before she falls limp at my feet. Suxamethonium paralyses the body in thirty to sixty seconds. Using it makes my job easier when I need to subdue someone. I work smarter, not harder. Why would I fight anyone when I can knock them down with a drug so easily accessible on the market?

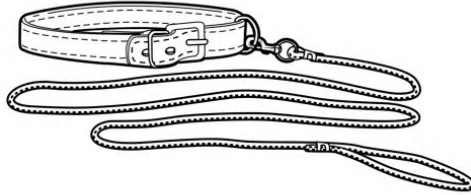
Under the cover of night, I set her up on the passenger's seat as if she were asleep. London is too big of a city to own every single cop. This isn't West Hill, my brother's territory. It's better if I avoid them altogether but if I ever come across the police, no one can ask me why I have an unconscious body in my truck. Besides, my trusted Valhalla doesn't have a trunk.

Swiftly, respecting the speed limits this time, I drive to my home in the forest surrounding West Hill, an hour away from London.

Tonight, Meg Anthony will take her last breath.

## NICO

DEATH IS A METHOD



When Meg is safely secured with her hands hanging from the ceiling and the rest of her body barely touching the floor of the barn I converted into my workshop, I walk to the small closet to the right of the sterile room. Pure white walls and the brightest white light create a clinical atmosphere worse than any hospital in the world. At least in hospitals, they try to make the space feel warm.

There is no denying death happens here and when my victims open their eyes to take in their surroundings, reactions vary from sobbing uncontrollably, thrashing, throwing up, or all three. I tilt my head as I wonder what Meg will do.

I don't have to wait as she rouses. When she realises where she is, bound and powerless, her eyes widen like saucers, then she thrashes against the chains holding her up and bellows in pain under the gag in her mouth as she dislocates a shoulder.

I click my tongue. I don't like it when they hurt themselves. Then they don't focus on the pain I'll carve on their bodies. I tap my right index finger three times on my right thigh, then my left. Three taps. Three rolls of my shoulders, and I turn around. The sounds of her distress are drowned out as my mind focuses on my next task. With deft fingers, I untie my black Converse high tops and remove them, sealing them into a waterproof bag and placing them on the lowest shelf of the metal closet in front of me. I unbutton my dark jeans and fold them neatly, then place them on the second

shelf from the bottom. My torn black loose tee goes out next and I take my time to put it on the third shelf. I keep my boxers on and don the plastic painter's suit I usually use for an occasion such as this.

I hate the material, how loud it crinkles with every movement. But I hate when the blood of victims touches my skin even more. It's viscous, and more importantly, alien. Outside of myself.

I complete my preparations with a pair of heavy duty rain boots, nitrile-free gloves, and a mask over my face that allows me to see clearly and doesn't obstruct my face for my victim. I want them to be the last image they see. A reaper all dressed in white, a sanitised vision of death. The image I paint, I know, is terrifying. I can see it in the reflections of the five mirrors displayed on all four walls of the room and the ceiling. They can't escape me. And if they try to close their eyes, I'll take their eyelids. I don't like to do it, but there isn't much I like about killing. It's just something I do to quell the obsessive thoughts of my father's death. That and the whip.

Every kill is a need in my blood. It starts slow like an itch. Then it spreads to my bones, to my muscles. I think about how I'll kill next and who it should be. There is an abundance of bad people who deserve the judgement I pass, so it's never been an issue for now. I've never wanted to kill someone who didn't deserve it.

But I don't kill for sport. I don't hunt my victims and play with my food. They do bad shit and I collect their souls. I feel better for it and justice is served. It's a win-win.

"Please Nico! Please, please, please. Don't kill me," Meg begs under her gag behind me, barely understandable, and I bring my attention to her. Even as she's ready to die, her eyes flash with hunger as I turn to her. I gave her what she wanted. I gave her my attention. Her body hasn't fully connected the dots and isn't preparing her for her impending doom. Yet.

I remove the plastic ball from her mouth.

"Why don't you tell me about Mr Wade and Mr Russel?" I ignore her and ask about the two teenagers she assaulted, who are in therapy because of her.

Her lips part with surprise and she shakes her head vigorously. "I don't know what you're talking about. Listen, I'm sorry, I shouldn't have touched you that way. I got carried away. I didn't know you didn't like it. I'm sorry."

She repeats the empty words a few times over. I'm unmoved.

“Tell me about Mr Wade and Mr Russel,” I repeat. My voice is calm and collected. My insides are at peace here in my space. All this white assaults the senses but to me, it’s like black. The two extremes are the only colours I enjoy. They calm my racing mind.

Catching up that I won’t be doing anything else but wait until she gives me what I want, Meg sputters, “They were my students.” I hum and nod, inviting her to continue.

My relaxed state lulls her into a false sense of safety.

“I loved them and then they turned on me. They meant the world to me and I thought we were meant to be. Their betrayal hurt me so much.” It’s unnecessary for me to point out that when a seventeen year-old tells on their forty-one year old teacher touching them inappropriately after school, it’s not a betrayal. “That’s why I wasn’t like myself at the club tonight. Heartbreak will make you do stupid things. I’m sorry. Please, let me go.” The last words end on a sob and I nod again. She sighs a breath of relief.

I turn to the display of tools on the other side of the clothes closet and take the duct tape. The tearing of a piece of it echoes in the room. The first note of the symphony I’ll create. I’m better at painting than I am at music but that first moment is precious. It holds weight and suspends us both in time.

Until I march to Meg, slap the duct tape over her mouth before she tries to scream, and slash her cheek with the knife she didn’t see coming. The cut is shallow but the sensation of warm liquid on her cheek registers and tears fall on Meg’s face, her eyes wild with fear. I cut her other cheek and then her jaw, completing my series of three. Before I’m too far gone into handing the sentence, I remove my gloves and pick up my phone, choosing the music for tonight’s play. Tchaikovsky’s Swan Lake ballet blasts from the sound system, drowning her cries for mercy.

With a new set of gloves on, I set to work on Meg. With precise movements that leave no place for approximation, I slide through her clothes until she’s fully naked. I don’t care to look at her body. I couldn’t be less interested.

Then, I cut at her carotid and femoral artery. The blood flows slowly but steadily.

Red slides along her torso and her leg until it drips onto the white concrete floor. The coat of waterproof paint and the slight incline on the floor helps the blood pour towards the drain at the back of the room.

I take a seat and bring my tools closer, the fresh canvas ready for another of my pieces. For a moment, I watch, riveted, as Meg's life-force flows from her veins onto my workshop's floor and away to the sewers. That's where it belongs. It doesn't take long. She dies miserably, her strength leaving her just slowly enough to be conscious of her upcoming death. All the while, I move my brushes along the canvas in shades of white, grey and black.

It's close to dawn when I'm done painting. With the rising sun, exhaustion lands over my shoulders. My eyelids are heavy and my muscles plead for sleep and rest.

One last step to my dance macabre.

I set the canvas aside to dry, unchain her body until it piles onto the floor like a mass of flesh and sinew despite the rigor mortis, and pick it up over my shoulders. The crematorium is a few steps away but I feel every single one as I carry the dead weight there and burn her body to ash.

When I come back to my workshop, I pick up my canvas and place it on an easel to dry in my drawing room, which is more of a storage unit for my art since I never really paint there. After cleaning up my tools and dousing the room in bleach, I remove the painter's suit and discard it, then I take my clothes and walk to my house, naked in the ice-cold November air.

Sleep that night is fitful and heavy. Until the usual nightmare.

## MARIE

SECRETS AND SHOTS



“He dumped me,” Lisa sighs with dramatic flourish as she launches herself on my bed, face down. Her maxi dress flows around her like a halo of wool and chiffon.

Twenty years of sisterhood, yet she still grows more theatrical. I’m pretty sure she’ll use her pregnancy as an excuse now to be even more dramatic. She’s gonna be insufferable. I roll my eyes but a little smile tilts the corners of my mouth up. She’s one of a kind, my sister.

Then my heart pinches as I remind myself that she’s got cancer and refuses to treat herself because the life inside her is more precious to her than her own.

“What do you mean he dumped you?” I ask, then glide my fingers through her long silky hair, soothing her with scalp scratches like we’ve done since we were old enough to have nails.

“I can’t find him, Mimi. Hugo left, I’m fucking sure of it. I texted him that I’m pregnant and—”

“You *texted* him?” I ask, mouth agape.

“What was I supposed to do? Ask him to drive me to a secluded place and then tell him? What if he killed me?”

“A little late to be worried about that, don’t you think? You’ve been alone with him all the fucking time, that’s why you’re pregnant.”

“That’s not the same,” she whines. “I’ve heard horror stories of girls telling their boyfriend they’re pregnant, only to get beaten up.”



I know she's not sad, just disappointed. It's the first time someone isn't doing her bidding and I'm sure she thought Hugo was eating in the palm of her hand. He was eating alright from what she told me.

Lisa moves her head to rest on my lap and I continue to soothe and cajole her. I was born two minutes before her and for some reason, I've taken the role of the older sister seriously. Considering we're the babies of the family and treated like ones more often than not, it's the only moment I really feel like an adult, like I can control something, even if it's just my sister's emotions by giving her what she needs.

"What are you going to do?"

Lisa doesn't answer for a long moment. I keep my attention focused on her breathing while my eyes drift to her bedroom through the open doors of the bathroom. While the walls are a soft eggshell, the rest reflects the contradiction of who we are. The high thread count sheets of her bed are black but the pillow cases are bright purple.

Her nightstand is full of stuff—keys, a strawberry chapstick, her retainer in its purple plastic box, a metallic purple bottle of water with a night sky design, a green notebook and its fluffy purple pen—and mine is devoid of any clutter. I use the drawers like a normal person, thank you very much. Yes, they have organisers in them but that's because it's easier to find my shit this way.

I love the familiarity of her clothes peeking out of her open wardrobe.

"I don't know. I'm scared," she finally says, her throat clogged with emotion.

"Of what?"

"Of dying."

I nod though she can't see me. I'm scared of her dying too. More than anything I've ever been afraid of before. More than when our sister Lana left for her loveless marriage and I watched her sparkle snuffed out by a vile man. More than when our mother was in the hospital for her kidney stones. More than when Daddy was shot.

But I can't tell her that. I've always been her rock and that's not going to stop today.

"Whatever you decide, I'm here, Lili," I tell her softly.

"I know, but I'm scared anyway."

"You want it." It's not a question. She already said it at the doctor's office.

“I want *her*,” she says with renewed fervour.

“Okay.” Determination pours out of me and Lisa tilts her head up to look at me. Her eyes shine with hope and love. I’d do anything for her.

“Okay?”

“How do you want to approach this?”

Lisa sits up. “I don’t want to tell anyone until the last moment. For both situations.”

“Lisa! You won’t be able to hide a pregnancy forever!” I whisper-yell. I’m sure there aren’t any microphones in our bedroom but what she’s asking is down-right stupid, and impossible.

God, I need a fucking drink. Or three. The clawing sensation is sudden and takes over all the other sensations. I can almost taste whiskey on my tongue. Smokey and warm exactly how I like it. I’ll have to wait until Lisa falls asleep to retrieve it from its hidden place under the sink in our bathroom. My sister loves a mess so much she never checks what’s inside all the filing boxes I use all around our space. The number of alcohol bottles hidden in there would raise even her brow.

“I don’t want everyone to hover over me,” she explains.

I can understand that. We’ve been kept far from the mafia life our family is leading to the point where we’re just in a golden prison. Lana is always pestering us with university choices and our future, hoping to ship us as far away from this life as she can. Our parents aren’t much better.

Lisa has found her little rebellion in the arms of her bodyguard, and I at the bottom of a whiskey bottle. It never quenches the thirst for more and the bone-deep sensation of not belonging anywhere, but the temporary relief has become a part of my routine. I can’t go a single day without a drink.

Who am I kidding? I can’t go without a hit of the warm liquid burning my throat every four hours or so. It relaxes me, gives me a modicum of control over how I feel, because at least it’s my choice.

I know that I have everything anyone could ask for. A loving family, a sister I adore, money and opportunities. But I’ve never been welcome anywhere. At least that’s how it always felt. Rejection and isolation have been constant for as long as I can remember.

When Lisa and I went to school, kids wouldn’t play with us because of the reputation of our father and the danger of associating with the Moretti name. As we grew up, our parents and sisters kept us far away from the business side of the family, all their meetings happening behind closed

doors in hushed tones. Lisa has been taking this isolation much better than I have.

I'd rather be numb with alcohol than feeling how unwanted and disconnected I am from the people who are supposed to love me most.

"Girls?" our mother's voice travels from the hallway as she makes our way to our bedroom. "There you are." She frowns when she sees Lisa sprawled on top of my legs.

"Lili, what's wrong?" she asks.

"Period pain," my sister answers without missing a beat and I bite my lips not to laugh. *Of all the excuses she could have used...*

Our mother comes to sit on the bed next to us. Her dark green eyes, the same colour as ours, shine with love but the slight grey undertone under her eyes betrays the late hour, as well as her silk golden pyjama.

"Your sister called. Giulia's coming for Christmas with her new husband and his brother."

"And she couldn't tell us herself?" I ask, petulant and a little hurt. Lana's at the head of the family now but I hoped she'd still take time for us. After her ordeal this summer, and her meeting her soulmate, she's been busy and I don't dare ask for more of her attention. But I want it all the same.

"She did, *picculina*. You're not answering your phone."

Sure enough, I have three missed calls when I look at my phone. I've left it on silent again. My cheeks heat with embarrassment, both at being caught not answering the phone and at being mad at my sister while she already gave me what I want. Suddenly, that drink becomes a necessity. I need to forget how much of a wretched person I am, how needy and unfair. How desperate and unkind.

"I'll call her back," I tell my mother who smiles softly at me and swipes a lock of raven hair behind my ear.

"Do it tomorrow, *picculina*. It's late. And when Andrea and Nico get here, be nice. They're family now."

It's hard to forget that my cousin Giulia's husband, Andrea, and his brother, Nico, are also my sister's husband's cousin. Yeah, the mafia can be fucked up sometimes, marrying within a small pool of families, but they took the cake. And I didn't forget that Andrea forced Giulia to marry him in exchange for rescuing my sister Lana from a human trafficker.

“I mean it, baby. Don’t be mean to the Capaldis,” my mother insists while she closes the door behind her.

I roll my eyes and Lisa chuckles softly. “I bet you a grand you’re gonna be mean to either one within two minutes of them arriving at the mansion.”

“Shut up!” I laugh and push her away from me, getting to the bathroom to get ready for bed. And drink from the miniature whiskey bottle I got under the sink. The 12-year maturation Scotch isn’t my favourite in taste but its format is perfect to hide everywhere. I drink the 50 mL bottle in one gulp, then brush my teeth and use mouthwash to hide the scent.

When Lisa gets to the bathroom for her twelve steps skincare routine, I get another bottle from my nightstand and drink that one too, chewing on gum before my twin appears on the threshold of the bathroom.

“I never understand how you can chew gum just before you sleep,” she says, then gets under the covers next to me. We might have separate beds and bedrooms but most nights, we sleep in the same bed, at least part of the night. We don’t care if it makes us weird. None of us can get decent sleep without the other. It’s always been this way.

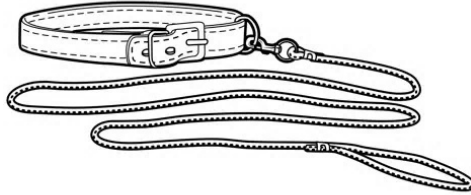
A nice buzz warms me up by the time she gets into bed. My muscles have relaxed, and I take a full breath in then out, leaning into the sensation of my body being held by cotton candy. Falling asleep with alcohol in my system always feels both right and wrong at the same time. It’s unnatural, but it’s also when I fully feel like myself. Under the cover of darkness, I don’t have to hide how much I hate myself or pretend that I’m a quiet person, not the wretched one with a secret addiction.

Even if I’m the only one who knows. Maybe it’s enough.

Come morning, I’ll remember it’s not.

## NICO

OBSESSION HAS A NAME



I spend the whole jet ride in the little room at the back of the plane, because there's a ninety percent chance my brother is going to fuck his wife on the couch at the front and I don't need to be witnessing that.

I'm happy for him. And for Giulia. She truly found her place within our family unit and completes my brother. They're a force to be reckoned with, unstoppable when they don't bicker, though I've come to understand it's their own form of foreplay.

We land on Kalliste on December 26th, Lana Moretti and Lisandru Pierce Bartoli welcoming us on their territory. My cousin Pierce and Andrea have been working on repairing their broken relationship in the past few months.

I never had a relationship with him to begin with. I understand he's family but to me, he's as much a stranger as the rest of the Moretti family is. And I don't trust strangers.

When Lana and her fiancé reach their hands for me to shake, I just give them a curt nod.

The ride to the Moretti mansion is beautiful. More than I expected.

Travelling is always a source of anxiety. Not knowing my surroundings, who to trust and how to speak the local language are barriers to experience the world fully but within the confines of the town car, I watch as we pass lush hills patched with snow on my right and the azure sea on my left.

The contrast of the landscape is breathtaking and even with the upcoming storm turning the sky an opaque anthracite colour, I can't help but admire the scenery. It's very different from my house in West Hill. I don't know how I feel about that.

Located behind a high ornate metal door and overlooking the Mediterranean Sea with a garden of olive and fig trees that must cover the place with cooling shade in the summer, the mansion is as sumptuous as the panorama outside.

As we step inside, the silence of winter is replaced with loud chatter and I almost flinch. Years of hiding my emotions help me remain still.

Giulia takes my hand and gives it a quick squeeze. "I'm sorry. I should have told you that we Morettis are a very loud bunch."

"I should have known just by knowing you," I answer with a smirk. She's the loudest person I know. I didn't like it at first, but now that I know who she is at her core, a passionate defender of her family who loves hard, it makes my insides feel warm to know she's here with us.

Before we make it more than a few steps into the living room, a storm of taffetas collide with Giulia and I tense. The pink-cheeked black-haired girl with a nose piercing squeezes my sister-in-law, but I don't even see her anymore.

Because I see double, except her twin doesn't have a piercing and looks like the prettiest fairy. Her night-blue dress embroidered with silver thread embraces her lush body perfectly, giving away all the secrets of her curvy form. The light reflects on her long dark hair, loose on her shoulders and I cant my head to the side, overcome with the need to glide my fingers through them. I fit both hands into the pockets of my oversized jeans to fend off the curious compulsion, then run my tongue over my lip piercing three times back and forth.

Even I know it's not customary or welcomed for strangers to touch other strangers' hair. It looks so soft and silky, though.

"This is my cousin Marie and that, talking Andrea's ear off, is Lisa," Giulia chuckles, introducing the two people who sandwiched her in a hug that would make any normal person uncomfortable.

**Marie.**

I repeat her name in my head, rolling the sound on my tongue. I like that it's pronounced "ma-ree" and not "mae-ree". It makes her less common.

Just like her face. Even if the carbon copy exists next to her, I see all the differences.

The birthmark at the bottom right corner of her mouth, a micro scar right above the left eyebrow, the way her lids are slightly hooded over her eyes and how her bottom lip is plumper than on her sister's face. The green in her eyes has a deeper shade toward the irises, particularly on the right eye, like her genetics couldn't decide which Pantone to choose from.

I wonder if she knows.

Before I can observe and take more notes of what makes her unique, she speaks a shy "Nice to meet you," then she scurries away into the busy living-room.



THAT NIGHT, the Christmas dinner is a feast of delicious homemade foods, prepared by the Moretti matriarch and her crew, red wine from the Bartoli vineyards flowing freely in each glass.

I enjoy it more than I thought I would.

Yes, they're loud and the inebriation doesn't help them control their volume. But they're happy to be with each other and the joy and love is infectious. My muscles relax as the wine flows in my bloodstream and food fills my stomach.

Yet, I never let Marie leave my sight.

For every glass of wine I drink, she downs three. She's on her seventh and I don't touch my third. By all counts, she had two whole bottles by herself, but she doesn't sway and her eyes still seem clear, her attention drifting from family member to family member, a slight frown on her face whenever she looks at her sister Lisa. Who I noticed did not drink at all, though she did pretend to put her lips in her glass.

She also didn't touch any cold cuts or raw fish and seashells.

Must be pregnant and not wanting the attention. No one seems to notice, too absorbed on other topics.

When Marie finally turns her eyes to me, our gazes collide and I feel warm all over for an entirely different reason than alcohol. Her cheeks take

on a peachy hue. It's lovely.

I don't know what compels me to follow her when she excuses herself and walks to the library at the back of the house. She doesn't hear me. I watch as she pours herself a glass of what must be whiskey from the crystal decanter resting on a vintage cart.

The place is tastefully decorated with a thick dark green rug and a modern beige sofa in the middle of the room, surrounded by shelves of books and priceless art hanging from the walls. A bit pompous but it works with the rest of the house. She looks out of place, though. Almost too raw.

She turns and startles when she sees me, a hand going to her chest, the other clutching the glass.

"Gosh, you scared me. What are you doing here?"

I shrug.

Truthfully, I don't know.

Marie shuffles from one foot to the other, biting her plush bottom lip. Her eyes are everywhere but on me. I want them on me.

"Care to share?" I signal to her glass with my chin.

She turns her back to me and takes another crystal glass, pouring a generous amount of Scotch before she hands it over to me.

Her lips wrap around her glass and she swallows the amber liquid, drinking half the glass in one gulp. Her deep green eyes remind me of the forest behind my house.

I've had enough alcohol for the night but I want to prolong this peaceful moment with her. Away from the loud crowd that is her family, she led me to a place of respite and quiet, even without knowing it, and I appreciate the silence between us.

I allow my eyes to drop down her body leisurely. We're so close I can see the goosebumps rising on her flawless olive skin. It's all mesmerising. Her heart beats a wild rhythm at her neck. "Why are you nervous?" I ask, genuinely curious.

She swallows thickly and I can almost hear the sound of her throat working over her dry mouth.

"I don't know you. I'm not in the habit of being alone with strangers," she offers.

Her honesty satisfies me. It's hard to find real answers in people. Most want to portray themselves the best way to get you to give them what they want. She just answered truthfully because I asked. That's precious.



I take a step back to let her breathe, then sit on the sofa, watching her intently as she towers over me from my new position. She's even more perfect from this new vantage point.

Her shoulders immediately drop and her eyes darken. Since social cues can be hard for me, I've made it my mission to study body language and become a master at it. Marie likes this new situation where she's the one on top.

For someone who's had a whole bottle of wine and is drinking whiskey right after, she seems in full possession of her mind. She approaches me slowly, as though I'm the wild creature and she the one who's trying to domesticate it. Maybe that's true enough.

Her head tilts to the side and she regards me behind lowered thick lashes. Her tongue picks through her lips to wet them. All I can do is follow the sight.

She lifts a hand, tentatively bringing it to my face and I tense, but she doesn't touch me. At least not at first.

Like controlled by a puppeteer, she slowly traces the contours of my face, a breath away from my skin. It sets me alight, but contrary to all the times before, it's a warm fire, a good fire that smells like whiskey and something deeply feminine, like peaches. It makes me want to inhale deeply but I hold my breath, waiting for Marie to decide what she'll do next.

I have enough time to back out, yet I don't. Her thumb lightly presses on the ring on the middle of my lower lip, flipping it gently side to side. A shiver rakes down my spine. She's still towering over me, standing in between my spread thighs, ready to take away her warmth when she decides, leaving me to patiently await a sign or a command. It's exhilarating and she has no idea. Her eyes shine under the low light of the room, her skin flushed with the alcohol.

She swallows thickly but doesn't remove her hand.

I do something I've never dreamt of doing before. I press my tongue piercing against her thumb and guide it inside my mouth.

Her sharp intake of breath makes me want to groan but I hold it in, eyes riveted to where hers devour the sight of my mouth parting open for her.

With a tremble, she glides her thumb deeper into my mouth, feeling the metal under the digit.

I close my lips around her finger and suck. Marie's lips part on a gasp but she doesn't move. I don't want her too. Her eyes finally meet mine,

confusion reflected at me in the dark green depths.

I grip my own thighs tightly with one hand and the whiskey glass with the other. I can't touch her. But how I wish I could. I'd lazily discover if her skin is as soft as it looks, if a particular spot makes her heart thump harder at her pulse point. I'd be bold and use my mouth, my tongue. I'd spend days mapping out all the ridges and hills of her luscious curves. I'd—

A glass shatters in the background, followed by both applause and reprimands from the matriarch to whoever was clumsy enough to break the crystal and Marie jumps back.

"I'm... I'm sorry." She stumbles over her words before she turns on her heels and disappears into the corridors without another word, abandoning her glass on the coffee table.

My fingers flex against my glass, the tattooed letters forming the word 'death' on each of them shifting, knuckles white with the exertion and control not to break it. I shake my head to dispel the strange event and discard the whiskey, abandoning it next to hers.

Before I can walk and make it over the threshold of the library, I turn around and pick up her half-drunk glass, downing the liquid, my lips lining over the stain of her maroon lipstick.

## MARIE

GIVING ORDERS TASTES BETTER THAN WHISKEY



**M**y skin buzzes with the thrill of touching Nico's lips, the power that surged through my limbs as I felt his tongue under my finger. My heart is in my throat as I flee to my room.

I've been drunk since I was sixteen years old. A bottle of cabernet sauvignon—maybe two—and half a glass of whiskey aren't a good excuse for my behaviour. No, I can only blame myself and the deep amber eyes of Nico Capaldi. How the silver hoop on his bottom lip and the metal on his brow enticed me to get closer. How his wet pink lips drew me to him more than any alcohol I've ever wanted to drink. When he looked up at me with ease, he emanated a darkness I wanted to drown in.

If this is what Lisa felt when she sneaked around with her bodyguard, I understand the appeal. I'd give up alcohol forever to feel this exhilaration again. At least, I think I'd try.

But as always, I've made everything awkward. Him, his brother and my cousin Giulia are staying four more days and I need to escape him. I can't bear to look like a fool. I already feel like one everyday of my ridiculous useless life. I don't need the reminder when I look upon his gorgeous rugged face with high cheekbones and perfect shaved jaw that could cut glass.

And all the piercings. They look like freedom and compliment his face so perfectly.

I pretend that I'm sick so I don't have to face him for the next two days.

Mammona keeps sending soup and her delicious food to my room but it tastes ashen on my tongue. With my forced quarantine, I'm left to stay in a room that's devoid of the one thing I can't go without.

With Christmas and the festivities in the Moretti household, I was looking forward to not having to hide my little problem. Everyone drinks too much on the holidays. So I didn't refill my hidden places with the miniatures I enjoy so much.

On the first day, my skin prickles with awareness and a pounding headache. I can ignore it by sleeping the day away. It actually looks like I'm sick so that's perfect for Lisa to leave me alone.

Now, I'm on day two of no alcohol. But I devised a plan. Our family is composed of night owls, and crime doesn't stop because it's Christmas. At night, everyone's gone to the clubs we own or do whatever it is they do. I wouldn't know since I'm not privy to this type of information.

It's the perfect time to strike.

Lisa sleeps soundly next to me, her soft snores filling the silent room. On featherlight feet, I get out of bed and open our door, closing it gently behind me. I oil the hinges regularly for this exact purpose. Me and motor oil are best friends, if one can believe it. All the doors in our homes are silent. And by now, I know where the creaky floorboards are. I avoid them all as I make my way down the stairs to the ground floor in the dark.

Out of the secondary kitchen, located at the very back of the room, there's an old wooden door that leads to a wine cellar. The temperature drops when I step into the metal staircase and I shiver. The air smells of damp earth. The electricity in the light bulb emits a low buzz and a faint yellow glow meant to avoid any disturbance to the ageing process. My senses are ecstatic because this smell, this light, this cold settling on my skin, it means I'll get what I need really soon. My body vibrates with need and my heart rate picks up as I walk deeper into the subterranean room.

Wine before bed isn't my preference. The sugar in it can fuck up my mood the next morning, but this will have to do. And it's no hardship to drink a delicious vintage *Patrimonio*.

On the back wall are shelves of the best wine Kalliste has to offer. A few spots are empty and I pick a bottle up from one of the lower shelves, hoping it won't be missed. No one checks the collection down here anyway.

I take a closer look at the label, face downcast, and glide my free hand over the label to remove any dust collecting on the bottle. A small smile

pulls up my lips.

“I’ve never seen anyone look at a bottle of wine so lovingly,” a voice that makes me shiver for a very different reason says behind me.

I startle and turn around, clutching the bottle in front of my chest as if I need to protect it from my attacker. A familiar silhouette leans against the door frame, a leg crossed over the other and hands nonchalantly in the pockets of black jeans.

How is he not in pyjamas at this hour? Does he even wear pyjamas? I blush at where my mind went. It’s innocent enough but also, *not*.

This artificial light shouldn’t be complimenting anyone. Yet, Nico looks like a Death God coming to collect another soul. The shadows across his face have his eyes look a little sunken, the undertone of his skin a little grey. But instead of unnatural, it gives him an extra aura of assurance. I want it for myself.

Then I realise I’ve been gawking for too long and my surprise turns to embarrassment, then to anger. I’ve had this ritual for years and no one ever dared to question me or step into my space. He’s been here three days and he thinks he can barge onto my private place of safety? *Who the fuck does he think he is?*

“What are you doing here?” I bark, but he doesn’t flinch. No, the bastard just shrugs.

“I saw you walking down the stairs. I was about to have a walk outside but following you seemed more interesting. Why are you picking up wine at two in the morning, Marie?”

He’s so bold that my mouth drops open.

“That’s not of your fucking business, *Nico*.” I emphasise on his name, hoping to convey how much I hate him in my space right now and need him gone, but it has the opposite effect.

Nico straightens and takes a step inside the cellar.

My eyes widen and my cheeks flush. It’s one thing to have someone I barely know witness my sins, and another entirely to have them so close to pick me apart while I do them.

I lift a hand up, and order, “Stop.”

Immediately, Nico stops in the middle of the room. He lifts his hands from his pockets and lets his arms rest on each side of his body, as though poised to obey my next command.

“You have no right to be here,” I whisper, my throat constricting around my vocal cords.

“Why not?” he asks, tilting his head to the side like he can’t fathom why this moment will bring me shame for years to come.

I press my lips tighter together to refrain from crying or lashing out. Or both.

“Is it because you don’t want me to wander around your home, or because you don’t want me to know you’re an alcoholic?”

I gasp. “You did not just accuse me of that!” I blurt out, offended. But not because he’s wrong. No. For once in my life, someone finally sees me. And I hate that they do. I hate this version of myself that has no control over her impulses. I hate this me that needs hard liquor every day to escape myself and every night to fall asleep. I don’t want him to see me. But his amber eyes, that could remind me of honey but look like the most luxurious whiskey to me, bore into mine. They don’t miss any details of my sins.

The silence stretches between us.

Nico remains still.

I can’t hold the tension occupying the space with us any longer. “If you tell a single soul, I’ll kill you, Nico Capaldi.”

He snorts and my ire grows. I approach him, my shoulder back, the bottle still in my hands, like it could be my weapon. Looking at him down my nose even as he towers over me, I lift a hand to his face but stay a hair shy of his cheek. Somehow, the absence of touch is more powerful than the heat of his skin against the pad of my fingers. I caress the promise between us. A thrill creeps up my spine when he doesn’t move, as if a puppet in my hands.

“Tell a soul and I’ll become what everyone is afraid I could be,” I vow.

“And what is that, Marie?” He can’t seem to stop saying my name.

“A Moretti.”

## MARIE

HOW DO YOU GRIEVE FOR SOMETHING THAT HASN'T HAPPENED YET?



The wet and capricious March air has replaced the smell of snow when we learn that Lisa is indeed expecting a baby girl.

“I told you so,” she exclaims and sticks her tongue out like we’re five, holding the sonogram against her chest. In her own way, she’s already holding her.

The morning sickness has been hard to disguise and she’s starting to show. Actually that’s not true. Her body is fully accommodating the baby inside her and it’s an absolute miracle no one has noticed.

It’s a testament to how little we matter in this family.

Lana and our father are busy planning a war with The Moscow Bratva. I heard them talk the other day as I was doing my late night run to dispose of empty glass bottles, in the middle of the night like a thief. The head of the Bratva, Misha Petrov, abducted Lana’s bodyguard, Igor, back in September last year and disappeared. But his enterprise is still thriving and Lana said he’s in the skin business. She wants to take him down and I wholeheartedly support her crusade against this monster.

I merely wished I were included in the decisions that impact our family. But as always, Lisa and I are kept in the dark, barely spoken to as of late. A new bodyguard has replaced Hugo at Lisa’s side and I don’t know how long we’ll be able to keep the charade up.

After the echography, Dr Olmeto sends us to her colleague and Lisa’s oncologist, Dr Martel.

My throat dries as we push the button that automatically opens the door but I steel my spine.

After her examination, the verdict is the same as it was a month ago. “The cancer hasn’t progressed. It’s stable, but we do need to perform a full hysterectomy when we go through the c-section during birth. Can I bring you the paperwork?”

Her voice is clinical, devoid of humanity and Lisa flinches as the reminder of the surgery that awaits her when her baby girl will come into this world. She told me at our previous appointment that she was devastated she couldn’t go through a natural birth but the doctor insisted that it’s too dangerous for both the mother and the child and that this course of action was her best chance at life. Her best chance at being the parent she wants to be to the little avocado in her belly.

Grief is a funny thing. How do you grieve for something that hasn’t happened yet? Because I already know I’m going to lose her. Every time we come here is simply a harsh reminder. I don’t know how I know and every time we arrive home, I try to convince myself that I’m being paranoid and silly, or too intoxicated to think clearly. But the knowledge is bone deep. It’s an inner knowing I can’t explain. A sensation deep in my gut that one day I’ll wake up and my twin won’t be here anymore. Not because we will have both moved on and found a life for ourselves.

It will be because her corpse is ashes scattered in the wind.

When we get home, Lisa takes the stairs two at a time—she still can—and locks herself into her room. She doesn’t come down for dinner that evening. Nor the next day.

On the third day, I knock softly on her door and she opens, falling into my arms and whispering how scared she is, once more. I’ve lost count how many times she’s said it these past few months but I hold onto her and squeeze her body to mine, lending her what little is left of my strength. I let her go reluctantly so she can change into a fresh pair of pyjamas.

Our mother chooses this very moment to barge inside our bedroom without knocking. “*Picculina*, you have to eat, or see a doctor,” she says before gasping loudly.

The tray of food clatters to the floor. The carrot soup spreads all over the soft pink carpet in a mess of orange and greens, the cutlery ending up under the bed. Wide-eyed, Colomba Moretti watches her daughter’s body



with a mix of awe, confusion and pain. Lisa's body, which is on display in her underwear as she pulls on the soft cotton pyjama pants.

"What... What is this?" our mother asks as she gestures to my sister and I step in front of her protectively.

"Ever heard of knocking?"

"Marie Louisa Annabelle Moretti, don't give me that fucking look!"

My mother never swears. She's dainty and the perfect image of a mafia wife with dark long straight hair always perfectly coiffed and a wardrobe that would have made Jackie Kennedy jealous. Right now, her eyes are wild and promise retribution.

I look behind my shoulder. Lisa is fully dressed and gives me a curt nod, cheeks flushed with embarrassment.

I step aside.

My mother's eyes move from Lisa's belly to her face and back down again. "You're pregnant?" she asks as if it wasn't obvious.

Lisa nods, her throat working over words, her voice, usually so loud in the house reduced to nothing.

Tears spring from the corner of my mother's eyes and her lips turn down, a slight tremor animating them before she takes a deep inhale.

She doesn't speak and time stretches. We're floating between this reality and the next. And it will change everything. No matter what we did, our parents protected us. They always have. This is a major shift within the family. By keeping Lisa's pregnancy a secret, we broke their trust but it's nothing compared to the other secret we harbour.

The thought of revealing Lisa's truths makes me want to vomit and I need something to keep it down. I excuse myself to our bathroom and pull two mini bottles of vodka from underneath the sink. I down them one after the other without thought. My throat burns and my eyes water with the strength of the liquor making my organs lit on fire. When it settles in my stomach, I still feel nauseous but I know I'll feel better in a moment. That reassurance gives me the courage to face the situation outside.

When I come out, Lisa and my mother are locked in a tight embrace, like none of them want to let go first. I didn't spray my mouth with menthol so I don't join even though my muscles burn with envy. I'm not jealous of my sister but I wish my mother would embrace me this tight, would make me feel like everything is going to be okay.

"Are you okay?" I ask Lisa in a hushed tone as they separate.

“Yeah. Please don’t tell Daddy,” she tells my mother, pleading with her hands encompassing our mother’s frail ones.

“I can’t do that, baby. I have to tell him.”

“But he’ll kill Hugo!”

“What’s going on?” Lana’s voice raises from the corridor a few seconds before she comes in, the open door an invitation to step in. “What are you—”

She doesn’t finish her sentence, her eyes widening to saucers as she takes in Lisa’s belly under the cotton bra she now wears to bed. She likes to have her growing stomach uncovered while she sleeps so she can always touch the place where she grows her child. It’s endearing. And now, a fucking nightmare.

“I’m going to kill him myself,” Lana seethes, already connecting the dots as to who is partially responsible for what is right in front of her.

“No, Lana, please,” Lisa pleads, almost dropping to her knees but I stop her and hold her back to my front, trying to give her comfort. “The stress isn’t good for her,” I whisper in her ear and she quiets down, still breathing heavily but trying to regulate with deep intake of breaths.

“He signed his death warrant the moment he abandoned his post. I didn’t go after him because I have bigger fish to fry but now that I know why he did? He better count his hours.”

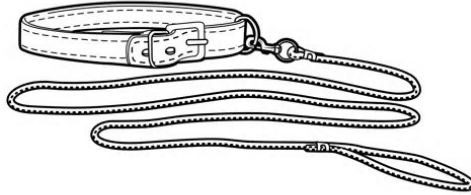
She leaves, lifting her phone to her ear, probably calling her husband and Head of Security. Lisandru has a knack for finding people. Hugo’s funeral will be soon.

Our mother kisses Lisa’s tear-stained cheek and leaves, closing the door behind her.

I’m left alone with my grieving sister, whom I can’t even grieve for yet.

## NICO

MISS MARIE



The heat of the Spring sun is stifling as I watch Alana Moretti and my cousin, Lisandru Pierce Bartoli, get married in the garden of the Moretti home, overlooking the astounding turquoise sea. The backdrop is like a movie with *Dolce Vita* written all over it.

Yet, all I can think about is how droplets of sweat trickle down my back and chest uncomfortably under the shirt I wear for the event. I had to wash it a good five times so the fabric wouldn't itch and make me want to murder someone whenever I'd touch it.

My face feels warm and the rays of sun burn my retina. I might be Italian but I was born and raised in the UK. This heat so early in the season is *not* enjoyable. Heat in general doesn't have my preference. The dampness of a rainy day does.

At least I'm glad we're in a place I've been to before. I can stand and watch from the sidelines, blending in with the hundreds of bodyguards spread across the expansive estate and observing every invitee with the focus of a hawk.

The number of rows of white-silk covered seats is not a divider of three. Even the invitee count isn't. I grit my teeth and hold the grimace that wants to take over my face as I keep watch. The whole elite of every major criminal organisations' representatives in Europe is here. This is our Davos Summit. A joyous union of two important bloodlines. And a stepping stone to the brewing war with Moscow.

Aleksei Dobrev, the Head of the London Bratva and ally of my family for a decade, sits in the fourth row, stiff as a board next to his step-sister Irina, who never leaves his side. On her other side is Dante Ventura and that gives me pause.

The Russian and the Sicilians have been at war for generations over territory disputes in London. The development is—I know—all thanks to Lana who's gathering her army to strike against our common enemy, Misha Petrov. It's striking nonetheless.

Lana Moretti must be a chess player. She's not only orchestrating the future of Kalliste and the European organised crime system, she's setting plans into motion that will span lifetimes. All with the oldest mean at her disposal. Marriage. I wouldn't be surprised if Dante Ventura and Irina Dobrev are tying the knot soon.

My attention gets swept away from the group looking at the two lovebirds exchanging vows when a head of dark locks turns to my direction, and eyes as green as the deepest forest ensnare mine.

Marie is the only one looking back instead of forward.

I tilt my chin to the couple in front of her to signal for her to watch them. The second seems to never end before she turns back. I don't give a single fuck about what the officiant is saying. All I do is watch Marie's shoulders, olive skin devoid of ink on display. I know she can feel my eyes on her and the thrill it shoots through my veins is like a drug in my system.

Since Christmas, I have been unable to stop thinking about her. Without a good reason, I didn't contact her though I kept watching her by hacking into the security system of the Moretti household. Since my cousin is the one responsible for it, I'm sure he knows but I don't give a shit. I had to see her.

It fed a new need instead of satiating it.

After the ceremony, everyone either surrounds Lana and her new husband, or Lisa, who seems to have finally decided to show her pregnant belly in a skin-tight knee-length pink dress. I don't even have to search for Marie. I always know where she stands somehow, like I'm a magnet and she's my centre. She smiles at the people talking to her but it's frozen in place and her eyes are sad. Her wine-red off the shoulders dress looks gorgeous on her. I see how men look at her. I take note of lecherous gazes sent her way and mentally write their names on the bullets of my gun, hidden under my jacket.

Before dinner is served, Lana and Lisandru motion for our group—Ventura, the Dobrevs, Julian Bartoli, Andrea, Giulia and I—to follow into the Moretti home. We walk in terse silence into the patriarch's office. Even bubbly Giulia doesn't say a word. The relationships between us all have been cordial at best; this isn't a celebratory moment between a group of friends. It's a secret pact to take out a common enemy and set a new king onto the Bratva throne.

I'm the last to enter the room decorated with dark wood panels and a lavish beige rug. And I immediately feel her presence before Lana tries to close the door to her face. My shoulders tense up and I hold in a snarl.

"Go back to the cocktail party, Mimi," Lana says in a placating tone to her younger sister.

"Don't call me that," Marie snaps and Lana huffs like she's offended. I take note not to call Marie that and focus on the conversations even as I take in the way Julian, Lisandru's half-brother, grins for no reason, already intoxicated, and Dobrev puts himself between our family and Irina, who does not seem pleased by his demonstration of care.

"I want to know what's going on," Marie demands.

The shift in Lana's demeanour is immediate and bears no discussion. It's not the older sister standing in front of Marie anymore, it's the Head of the Moretti, and she won't be challenged.

I grind my teeth. I don't know why Marie isn't part of this discussion. She should know what will impact her family. How we intend to go after Misha Petrov, get Lana's friend—and Julian's husband—Igor back. She should know the peril everyone in this room is in. We're not only going after another family. We're going after an Empire that spans across generations and countries. Contrary to most underground systems in Europe, the Bratva has one king and minions in all powerful ports. The rest of us are pretty independent even though Ventura still reports into the Cosa Nostra for major affairs.

"We're not talking about this right now, Marie. Go back to the party," Lana says, unmovable.

"You're shutting me out," Marie protests, pain and resentment dripping through her tone.

"I'm protecting you!" Her sister counters. "And this is not a negotiation. Go back to the party before I have you removed."

From where I stand, I bear witness to Marie's pain, her eyes shutting down, the green turning thunderous. She sets her jaw and turns without a word, walking away in a cloud of rejection. I know what she'll turn to now and the thought makes me want to go after her. But duty calls. As an angel of doom, I simply answer.

Lana sighs as she closes the door. "I'm sorry about my sister."

"Maybe you should include her," Julian chimes with a smirk. Lana rolls her eyes at him, the gesture a tell of their years of friendship. Putting an end to the sex trafficking ring that's taking over Europe through Petrov's enterprise is a noble cause but for both of them, it's personal. I admire their devotion with curiosity.

I love my brother. I would do anything for him, for Giulia and my mother. I'm deeply intrigued by Marie, but I'm also not sure how to integrate everyone else within my circle of trust. There's too many of them. So I'll treat this as any other mission I have. With precision and attention. Like it's my job, because it is.

Nine people form a circle in the well-lit office. The Dobrev-Ventura trio, Lana and the Bartoli brothers, and my brother, his wife and I. That settles me. I tap my right leg with my index finger three times, roll my tongue in front of my teeth, and repeat the process twice more.

A little more settled, I ask, "So, what's it gonna be?"

"I didn't even know you talked," Ventura comments dismissively and I shrug, telling him the truth. "Only for people who matter."

"Aw, Nico. Don't go soft on me," he teases. At least I think that's a tease. I've only met him once in my life for a contract he hired me for a few years ago. A nasty piece of shit stole his grandma's diamond bracelet and I think it was a sentimental piece for Dante, so I tracked down the target, got the bobble back and buried the thief in my backyard. Alive. As per Ventura's request. The asshole watched in glee. He's a weird one.

"Wouldn't dream of it," I deadpan.

"That's the spirit!"

He's about to clap his hand on my shoulder when Giulia steps in and slaps his hand away like he's a naughty boy who needs to behave. "Enough pleasantries. We got work to do, boys."

I could kiss her right now. I don't want to kill our new found ally in a daze-y rage.

“Misha hasn’t been seen since Lana’s abduction.” Lisandru’s deep baritone fills the room and brings everyone to attention.

“And Igor was sighted last in Amsterdam a few weeks ago,” Andrea finishes and Julian perks up. The cloud of alcohol in his blue eyes clears until all that remains is murderous focus and quiet rage. His dishevelled blond locks fall over his forehead as he leans forward.

“Where is he now?” he asks.

“We don’t know,” my brother answers. “I’ve lost track of him. It’s like he knew we were on his tail, letting us know of his whereabouts enough to throw a bone but not enough to raise suspicion within his own clan.”

“You think that’s what he’s doing?” Giulia asks.

“I don’t know. You all know him better than I do.”

Giulia looks up to Lana and then to Julian, a deep frown on her freckled face. I wait in the shadows for all the information I will need. I’m not a recovery person. I’m the one you send after a target. I’m here because I’ll take care of Misha Petrov or his subordinates.

“He’s not giving us indications of his whereabouts. Igor doesn’t give a shit about himself. He knows we’re looking and he’s showing us where to find the goods,” Julian grimaces at the last word. He means the people Petrov deals in.

“So, when are we flying to Amsterdam?” Dante asks like he’s a kid at a birthday party and I sneer. His enthusiasm for danger isn’t something I relate to. And nor do Irina or Aleksei Dobrev if their annoyed faces are anything to go by.

The next hour is spent forming a plan to help the people held at the Petrov facility that must exist in the Venice of the North. Julian insists on going, which leads to an argument with his brother and Lana. Everyone already knows Igor is long gone but the hope Julian clings to permeates the air. In the end, he wins. Bickering continues as Dobrev promises to send the local Bratva on the ground but Dante demands to be Julian’s wingman.

My presence isn’t required anymore. I don’t have a role in this specific operation.

I don’t say goodbye when I leave the lavish office and walk in search of the only person I want to see right now.

My steps guide me to the Moretti library. Marie has discarded her high heels and sits with her legs underneath her on the big chesterfield lounge

seat. She's drinking whiskey, her chin propped on her fist. I don't make any attempt to conceal my presence as I step inside.

"You always know where to find me, don't you?"

She doesn't look up. Her eyes are riveted to the outside world. She's always looking out, locked in her pretty cage, locked out of important conversations, with no control over her family's legacy.

It's not a question but I answer anyway.

"Yes." No need for me to lie. I want her to know how much I think about her, look for her in crowds even when I know she isn't there. She's been kept in the dark by her own family all her life. I want to bring her light.

"Are you going to tell me to stop drinking?"

I frown. "Do you want me to tell you to stop drinking?"

She scoffs and it's self-deprecating. Her bloodshot eyes turn my way and I swallow. Even in this state, her attention hits me. Like that next sip of alcohol she takes, I drink it up.

"If anyone knew, that's what they'd tell me." Her chin wobbles before she clenches her teeth and gives me a closed-lipped smile, then downs her drink. Her hand trembles as she pours herself another. The decanter is empty when she puts it on the window sill behind her. "Why aren't you telling me to stop?"

"You're old enough to make your own choices, Marie." She gasps softly, but I don't understand why. "Do you want to stop drinking?"

"I will," she says, resolute, shoulders back. "But not yet."

We remain silent as I sit in front of her, elbows on my knees. My eyes catalogue all the things that make her *her*. And all the things I didn't think I'd ever take pleasure in noticing. Like how the dress has ridden up her thighs and I get a peek of beautiful stretch marks and white underwear.

She moves to walk away. I can't let her do that. Before I can compute what I'm doing, I stop her with a hand on her wrist. The contact makes my skin prickle with awareness and warmth but it's short-lived. She slaps my fingers away sharply. "Did I give you permission to touch me?" she scolds. Years of training have me hold the excitement coursing through my veins like a shot of whiskey, but I can't fight the shiver that runs down my spine. She has a fierce and dominant side. I want nothing more than to see more of it. Surrender at her feet, give her the control she must crave.



“No, Miss Marie,” I say, the words like a prayer on my tongue. The monicker tastes like the sweetest fruit. “I won’t do it again.”

She nods and doesn’t move, once again looking up at me from her standing position above my sitting one. That’s exactly where I always want to be when in her presence.

“I read once that smokers still have the urge to use their fingers as they did when they brought the cigarettes to their mouth. And that familiar gesture is hard to beat,” I tell her.

She shakes her head. It makes the sun move across her hair to show the deep blue hue of her black strands. “Why are you telling me this?”

“In case you have the urge to lift a glass to your lips. Call me, then.”

Ever since I saw her, I hacked into her phone and put my number there. I knew there would be a time when she’d need it. No one but Lisa sees her. And Lisa is about to see only her child.

“I don’t know you, Nico.”

I shrug. “You will.”

“I don’t have your number,” she counters.

“You do.”

“How—” She doesn’t even finish her sentence, just scoffs and shakes her head as understanding dawns on her. My brother Andrea is the best hacker in Europe, and Marie’s own brother-in-law is the Head of Security of the Moretti Empire. We can achieve a lot.

“I’ll think about it,” she says then she leaves. Before she passes the threshold, she turns. Her sadness is breathtaking. Even half drunk, Marie Moretti is the most beautiful person I’ve ever met. “Thank you, Nico. It means a lot.”

How offering to be an ear to her pain can mean a lot seems odd to me. She has three sisters, a family house constantly full of life. Yet, she must be the most lonely person to rely on a stranger for comfort. I won’t be a stranger for long.

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# MARIE

LOSS



We're walking along the hill overlooking the Sea on a warm July morning when Lisa doubles over and cries out. She places a hand on her lower belly and I know I'm about to meet my niece. Adrenaline surges through my system and keeps me from throwing up with anxiety.

"Fuck. We need to get you to the hospital," I tell her as I slide under her arm to support her.

"She's not supposed to come for another two weeks, Mimi." Lisa cries out again, another contraction hitting her with force. "She's supposed to be a Leo, not a Cancer."

"Lili, I swear to God, no one cares about her star sign. Only that she's healthy, and you too."

I flag our protection detail so he can help me carry Lisa to the car. I text the family group chat before refocusing on Lisa who loses her waters on the leather back seat of her new Mercedes. Her forehead is damp with sweat and she breathes heavily. I don't know what to do but I watched enough videos to know that we need to regulate her breathing.

"Follow my lead, Lili. In through the nose, slowly." She imitates me. "And out through the mouth. You're doing great. Keep going. How long before we reach the hospital?" I ask our driver.

"ETA in six minutes, Miss Moretti."

My heart beats so fast in my chest I could faint, but all that matters is my sister and my niece. I can't think about the bad feeling I have. I can't.

"Hold on, Lili. We're almost there."

Right then, another contraction racks her body and her face contorts with pain, another cry torn from her throat. "Faster!" I yell, panicked and scared.

When we reach the hospital, our driver carries Lisa into the emergency section. Nurses reach us and with calm, practiced movements, set Lisa on a wheelchair before taking her away. I stomp behind them. "I'm coming with her."

An older nurse with grey hair and a face that says 'don't fuck with me' looks me up and down before giving her orders. "Take the patient to the waiting room. You," she addresses me. "I need your name, the name of the patient and for you to calm down."

I swallow and nod as we walk behind my sister who's obviously in pain. The urge to take her hand and comfort her sings in my blood. But right now, she needs me to keep my head on straight. "Marie Moretti. This is my sister, Lisa Moretti. She's thirty-eight weeks pregnant and a patient of Dr Olmeto. Her first contraction started about twelve minutes ago."

"How spread are they?"

I close my eyes and try to count but I can't focus. "I don't know," I say, fear clogging my throat.

"It's okay, Miss Moretti. There could be a long time before the baby comes. We'll monitor her. All you have to do now is be there for her and don't interrupt my team," the nurse says kindly but firmly. I nod and clench my hands together. My nails indent the skin of my palms. I have no clue what to do with myself.

Before the nurse can go inside the room they set my sister into, I stop her with a hand on her forearm. "She has stage two uterine cancer. Dr Olmeto planned for a hysterectomy right after the c-section."

She tries to control it but her face turns sombre. "We'll get everything ready."

A team of people help Lisa remove her clothes and get into a hospital gown before they set her up on the bed. Bleach and lemon cleaner infiltrates my nostrils, the white walls assaulting my vision. The beeps of machines in this room and next to us feel and sound like the antechamber of death. Ants crawl up my limbs and I have to repress a full body shiver.

Over the course of the next hour, there's nothing I can do but watch as my sister's contractions make her howl in pain and thrash. Dr Olmeto has been called and will be here soon for the C-section, but in the meantime, we wait. My ribs are too tight for me to breathe. I sit down and rub my thighs mindlessly. Then I pick at my hands.

"Stop it, Mimi," my sister says weakly, her hair sticking to her damp forehead.

"Stop what?"

"Worrying."

"I can't help it," I tell her as I stand up and come to her, gliding a lock of hair behind her ear.

"Ember and I will be fine," she says with a smile like all is well in the world. But *nothing* is well in the fucking world. I need a fucking drink, I'm scared shitless for my sister's life and now, I'm scared for my niece's life too. Worst-case scenarios run rampant in my head and I'm on the verge of a mental breakdown. The only reason I hold it together smiles at me softly.

"Ember?" I ask, focusing on Lisa.

She nods and I laugh, tears blurring my vision. It's raw and far from joyful. "It's a beautiful name," I say and place a hand to Lisa's belly. "I can't wait to meet you," I whisper softly to it and I swear she kicks into my hand.

Lana, Lisandru, and my parents trickle into the room, joy written all over their face as they come to kiss Lisa's cheeks. My sister Angèle and her husband are the last to arrive. We've never been close. She's been married for five years now. Lisa and I were just shy of fifteen when she left and she's fifteen years older than us. I'm glad she showed up though. The entire family is in the room. It makes me happy for Lisa that everyone showed up for her even as loneliness rears its ugly head. It's like I'm watching through a glass. The picture they paint is one of family bliss. Yet all I feel is emptiness, my head looking for my purse where what I need lies inside.

Shit. I forgot to pack a bag so I don't have it with me. Thank God, I have my phone in my jean pocket so at least I have something to do while I feel like this. Maybe that's why I open a new message thread and type.

ME

Lisa is about to give birth.

HE TOLD me to call when I felt like I needed a drink. I need a drink and I can't have it. My hands and mind need another outlet, another distraction. Everyone is crowding my sister and talking animatedly. I'm forgotten in a corner, waiting anxiously for his response.

NICO CAPALDI

How do you feel about it?

FOR THE FIRST time since we found out, someone is asking about me instead of Lisa and the baby. That shouldn't make me feel good. It's selfish and despicable to want attention when Lisa is the one who should get it. But still my cheeks heat and I type.

ME

Terrified. She has cancer. No one knows.

NICO CAPALDI

I'm sorry.

I DON'T KNOW what else to do or say so I close the message app and refocus on Lisa.

A nurse comes in and starts to take the bed with her.

Lisa turns to me and extends her hand. "I want you with me."

The nurse grumbles but let me follow as we move through corridors with automatic doors and into an operation room. If I thought the room we were in was cold, it was the warmest one I've ever been in compared to this one, with tiles from floor to ceiling, an aggressive white light overhead and a metal tray with tools I don't know the name of. Dr Olmeto is here and invites me to put on a medical gown, a face mask, gloves and shoes protection.

Lisa holds my hand. "I love you, Mimi."

"I love you, too."

"Promise me you'll take care of Ember if anything happens to me." She squeezes my hands and her face scrunches with concern.

"Nothing will happen to you." I already know it's a lie but it feels good on my tongue.

"Promise me," Lisa demands urgently and I vow to protect her daughter no matter what.

Dr Olmeto places a mask on Lisa's face and the gas puts her to sleep in second. I stay close while she delivers Ember.

Something's wrong.

"Why isn't she crying?" I ask as someone takes Ember away and out of sight.

The monitor next to Lisa's head starts to beep and my attention is split. "What's happening?" I yell.

I can't hear Ember. The noise of the machine gets louder and takes over my whole brain. I close my eyes. When I reopen them, my vision is blurry and my heart is pumping too fast. I heave and pant. A hand lands on my shoulder and I'm moved away from my sister but I resist.

"Tell me what's going on!" My voice sounds so far away, broken and my throat tastes like ash.

I don't know who, Dr Olmeto or maybe a nurse, but I'm taken away from the room as I cry and yell for someone to tell me what is happening.

When I'm out of the room, I land on my knees. Strong arms drag me away as I push against their strength to reach my soul mate, my sister, my everything.

My sister Alana's face comes into view and she takes my face into her hands. "Get yourself together, Marie. Lisa needs you to focus."

Lisa needs me, end of story, but I don't say it.

A bottle of water is brought to my lips and though my throat is raw and I want to scream in pain, I swallow greedily until I'm calm enough to blink the tears away.

"What happened?" Lana asks.

I shake my head. "I don't know. I don't know." I repeat the words over and over until I collapse into my sister's arms. She holds me against her and soothes my hair.

Time slows and warps.

I must lose consciousness at some point because when I come back to myself, a cold sweat staining my armpits and making me shiver, my family whispers around me, looking at me like I'm on the verge of another breakdown. I am, but I swallow and wait. The need for the burn of alcohol is so potent it almost seems like I'm sweating whiskey.

I stand and go to the bathroom down the corridor, tearing at the gown and face mask with shaky hands. I text Nico again.

ME

Something is wrong with Lisa.

HIS RESPONSE IS fast and not what I expected. Anyone would give words of reassurance. He doesn't. And I appreciate it more than he will ever know.

NICO CAPALDI

Whatever happens, she loves you and you her.

I'M SO FUCKING tired of crying but tears leak again on my cheeks. When I wash my hands and look into the mirror, my face is puffy and red. I avert my gaze and go back to the waiting room. Dr Olmeto's back is to me and my family looks on with their eyes wide. My mother is crying in my father's arms. Lana's knuckles are white with how much she clenches them.

"No." The word is a guillotine in my mouth. "No, no, no, no."

Dr Olmeto turns to me, her face torn with pain. "I'm sorry," she says but I don't hear.

All I hear is my scream.

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## MARIE

IT SHOULD HAVE BEEN ME



“Lisa had a sarcoma, a rare cancer type that made the pregnancy risky,” I think I hear Dr Olmeto say to my family but it’s all unreal. I’m awake but I’m not here. More is said until a piercing scream reaches my ears.

My mother.

The wail is pain itself.

From the corner of my eyes, a silhouette approaches with decisive steps and I’m hauled up. I didn’t even realise I was still down on my knees. My vision is blurry but my sister’s voice is clear. She shakes me violently and I let her.

“You knew? You fucking knew?!” Angèle screeches in my face before she’s wrenched away by Lana.

“Calm the fuck down, this isn’t helping.”

“She fucking knew Lisa was sick and she didn’t tell us.” Then she addresses me. I should care but I don’t because nothing fucking matters now. “You disgust me. I can’t stand to look at you.”

I think she leaves, but I don’t know. My cheeks are wet with tears, my guts roil with nausea and self-hate stronger than what my sister could ever throw at me.

Voices around me aren’t forming words. My eyes can’t discern people and shapes. Fluorescent lights dance on the edges of my vision. I don’t fucking deserve to pass out.



It should have been me.  
And now everyone knows we lost the wrong twin.  
It should have been me.

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# MARIE

GRIEF



A baby cries.  
It gets louder.

I don't understand where it's coming from. My body refuses to move for a second, then I manage to open my eyes. My lashes stick together, mascara caking at the corner. I'm in my bed, in the same clothes I was in earlier today. My tongue is thick in my mouth and if I could tear my eyes out to calm the raging headache, I would.

The cries intensify and it's like they're in my brain. I turn to my side and press myself up, going to Ember's crib where she's yelling at the top of her lungs. The clock on my nightstand indicates 4:30.

"I fed you three and a half hours ago, Bibi." No one told me a three day old baby eats every three or four hours. If I'm lucky. But Ember refuses to take the bottle from anyone but me. It's like she chose me. It hurts as much as it soothes.

I take her in my arms and stick my pinkie into her mouth. Her greedy mouth immediately starts sucking but I know I only have five minutes before she figures out no milk is coming out and into her small belly. On silent steps, I make my way down the stairs and into the kitchen where I prepare what I need to feed her.

Then I sit on the Chesterfield chair in my dad's office, the door closed behind me. While she drinks, Ember looks at me with wide eyes. They're a pure green, exactly like my sister. Like me. My throat clogs but tears won't

come. I've shed enough to last me a lifetime. I'm dry. I wish I could cry. Then maybe the pain like a stab wound that festers in my chest would disappear. I hold a three-day old life in my hands and all I want is to die.

When she's done, Ember falls back asleep on my chest. I listen closely to her tiny breaths, her fast heartbeat under the hand I placed on her back almost a lullaby. But sleep doesn't come for me. It's been three days since Lisa passed and I've barely slept four hours a night. I miss my sister. I miss alcohol though I don't want to, but sweat drips down my spine at all hours of the day and my muscles tingle with need throughout the night. My hands have started to tremble and that damn headache won't leave me in peace.

I avoid mirrors. I know what I must look like. The ghost of my sister.

The sun rises on the horizon and a soft knock echoes through the wooden door of the office. "It's almost time," my mother says behind me as she approaches. Her hand on my shoulder is heavy like an anvil. "How is she?"

"Hungry every three or four hours. But healthy otherwise." I hand her her grand-daughter who still sleeps soundly.

"Lisa was a hungry baby when she was a newborn," she says and I grimace, then she swallows thickly. My mother's coping mechanism is the need to talk as much as she can about Lisa but I'd rather never hear her name again. How she bears to talk to me after I kept Lisa's illness a secret is beyond my comprehension. I don't know if she forgave me or can't stand to lose two daughters, maybe.

I know my mother won't ask about me. For three days, I've watched the members of my family sidestep me, avoid me. I think they're afraid of what I will answer. They leave me be. They let me grieve on my own while they talk in hushed tones behind my back. Nothing new but somehow worse. And I deserve it.

"You need to get ready, Mimi," my mother says.

"Don't call me that," I spew at her.

"Marie, I—"

I raise a hand to cut her off and walk to the decanter on the vintage alcohol cart, pouring myself a heavy dose of whiskey and swallowing it in one go. The sweet burn in my throat is familiar and I almost moan, relief spreading in my system. My sister Lana enters and eyes me with judgement behind her eyes. "Don't," I challenge.

"It's a bit early, isn't it?"

“I think I’m allowed to drink on my sister’s funeral day.”

“She was my sister, too.”

“But she wasn’t your twin. She wasn’t your everything.”

She looks like I slapped her, pain etched into every corner of her delicate face. I hate who I’m becoming even more than who I was before Lisa died. Didn’t think that was possible.

I hold my arms to my mother. “Give her to me.”

She hesitates and I see red. I understand her concerns. I just drank a big gulp of alcohol but to me, it’s too little. It will barely take the edge of when I’m in front of the grave and I have to watch as they lower a white casket into the ground. “Give her to me,” I repeat, an edge of violence on my tongue.

Rationally, I understand that my mother is trying to protect Ember. But I’m not rational. I’m heartbroken and ready to jump from the Sant Armellu Cliffs. Maybe it’s best that Ember stays with my mother.

“Go get changed, Marie. We’ll be here with Ember,” Lana says with authority.

I clench my jaw but ultimately, I obey.

It takes me longer to put on the black dress that was Lisa’s favourite while she was pregnant. I was three sizes bigger than my sister so it actually fits me quite well. It’s tight at the chest and flows right underneath, ending directly above my knees. The round pouffy shoulders give it an elegant finish. I don’t bother with makeup, taking Lisa’s heart-shaped black sunglasses instead.

When I make my way to the office again, Angèle and her husband are there as well as my father and Lisandru. They greet me—except Angèle—but once again, no one asks how I am as they turn their attention back to Ember who blinks at them as she’s passed from arm to arm. I want to gouge their eyes out. It should be me holding her but I made an obvious mistake. For the first time in a while, I regret that glass of whiskey.

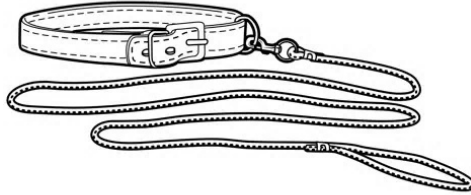
The air in the room is putrid with pain. I’m surprised no one seems to smell it.

Finally, Ember is placed into my arms again and I take a deep inhale against her head. She smells like pure joy and baby formula instead of everyone’s grief. Standing up, I brace for the next few hours.

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# NICO

WALKING DEATH



If I ever thought Marie was sad before, it had nothing on today. Her black sunglasses cannot hide the shade of grey her natural olive skin has turned into, or how her hair looks dull in the tight ponytail. But it's more than the physical markers, visible to anyone with eyes.

She carried herself with caution, now it's like death walks alongside her, its scythe above her slender neck. She doesn't want to be here, to be of this world. Heaviness lingers around her. In the way she walks, in the way she stands.

I look and look, hypnotised to be so close to death. Yes, it's in front of me in the white casket. Yes, I touch it every time I end a life with my hands. But living death, I've never seen. My targets are always alive and kicking, until they're not.

Marie Moretti looks like pain and death wrapped in a seductive black shroud.

I want this for myself. I want to have it, to study it, to consume it.

My thoughts remain focused on her as the ceremony begins and Lisa's baby fusses and cries. Giulia sniffles next to me, my brother's arms around her for comfort and support. As I listen closely, everyone sobs. Their mournful sounds seem to mount to a crescendo and a cold shiver rakes down my spine. I crack my neck and try to listen to the priest but I still hear them. My breath itches as someone in the row before us blows their nose loudly. Giulia made us sit on the last row despite her being the cousin of the

departed. She knew if I wanted to escape, no one would see it from where we're located. Instead, I take the small plastic box from my jeans pocket and slide the earplugs into my ears.

Silence descends on me and I breathe easier.

I want to be there for Marie. She's the only one who doesn't look like she's crying. She holds the baby tight to her chest but from where I sit, I only see her back.

Ensnared in my semi-silence, I wait for the ceremony to end and the people to disperse. Everyone goes to Pietro and Colomba Moretti, Lisa and Marie's parents, and give their condolences. Their faces are grave, but they're putting on a brave facade for this part of the ritual. I remove the earplugs and make my way there as well. I don't speak. No words can comfort them. Instead I hold their gaze a second longer. I can't make myself hold their hands. I'm not sure if that's what I should do, but Colomba smiles kindly at me. It's short and strained but I think I did the right thing.

Marie stares at the grave the diggers lowered the casket into. She doesn't turn to the line of people who want to share her pain. I wonder if she wants to share it. Or if she's greedy with it.

When most people have left, her mother lands a hand on her shoulder and she flinches, the bundle in her arms displeased and crying. Her cries aren't like the sobs of the crowd crying for Lisa. They're soft. Delicate. There is a system to them. She wants something out of Marie or maybe Colomba. Sustenance or sleep. I'm not sure what it is but it doesn't feel like it's a bottomless pit of grief.

Marie hands the baby to her mother who walks away with a concerned look to her daughter.

I light a cigarette and approach, standing on her right. I remain silent as we both look down at our feet. The sun shines above us with heat, yet the disturbed earth smells at incoming rain. I wouldn't be surprised if a summer storm hit the island tomorrow.

Marie takes my right hand and links our fingers together without a glance. My eyes widen and I hold my breath as long as I can. Her skin is touching mine. Her palm is against mine. She's squeezing like it's the only thing helping her stay standing. When I can't hold it anymore, I release a heavy breath and immediately pull on the cigarette, letting the nicotine fill my lungs. My eyes blink fast and my throat works against the ball lodge

inside. But I'm still holding her, too. She doesn't move. I take the time to study how it feels to touch her.

Her fingers are squeezing and touching the back of my hand. Tentatively, I do the same and press the pad of my fingers against the back of her hand, too. It makes the squeeze tighter. I feel her heart throb through our linked hands. That's... I don't know how to describe it. I like it. The more I let the sensation consume me, the more it spreads to my whole hand.

"You should stop smoking. It's bad for you," Marie whispers.

"Maybe I like what's bad for me."

She doesn't look up at me and simply shrugs. "That's okay. I do, too."

I take another drag of the cigarette and extinguish it under my shoe, holding on to the butt with two fingers. I wouldn't want to taint the soil of Lisa's resting place.

Time passes. I wouldn't know how long if it weren't for the trajectory of the sun changing ever so slowly above us. The shade of the chestnut trees shield us from most of its rays but the afternoon is well on its way by now.

Noises come from behind us and we both turn to see Lana and Angèle standing close by, deep in hushed discussion. They must have determined that it's time for Marie to move on.

"I live in the middle of the forest," I tell Marie, whose gaze is back towards the ground.

She raises her head up before slowly looking up at me. "And I live on a hill, what's your point, Nico?"

"The only house close by is a mile away, and it's Andrea and Giulia's." She's not getting what I'm saying. I'm used to being more direct. "I don't ask questions. Or not stupid ones, anyway," I say.

Her lips part, her shock palpable. "Are you asking me to move in with you?"

I shrug and she lets a small laugh of disbelief. It's barely a scoff but it lights up her entire face. I can't look away even as I see Colomba approach in the corner of my eyes. Marie bristles and her expression sobers.

"You know what? I might take you up on it. But don't hold your breath."

"But that's one of my favourite things."

Another short laugh, this one more timid. It's music to my ears, like the melody of a soft piano. Her cheeks take a pink hue that seem to chase away the grey. It's not much but I want to see more of it.

“I can’t leave her,” she says with a mournful look towards her sister’s grave.

“If you’re talking about the baby, she can come with you. If you’re talking about your sister, she isn’t going anywhere.”

“Nico,” she gasps. “You can’t say that, that’s rude.”

I tilt my head to the side and frown. “Why? It’s the truth.”

“Yes, but... You can’t talk about the dead with such disrespect.” She seems angry now and somehow, that’s even better than when she blushed. Her entire body is turned to me as if she’d tackle me. I don’t understand what she means by disrespect so I remain silent.

“Marie? You’ve been here a while,” Colomba tells her as she tiptoes toward her daughter.

Marie clenches her jaw but nods dutifully. “Coming, mamma.”

They both make to leave but before she can be too far, I clasp her wrist with the same hand that already touched her. Without meaning to, my thumb presses against her pulse point and her heart beats against the digit. It’s exhilarating. I haven’t touched anyone so willingly. Ever. My heart beats in my ears and my mouth dries but I tell her what I need to, what I’m desperate for her to hear. “Think about it.”

She swallows and leaves the cemetery.



## MARIE

ESCAPE IS MY COPING MECHANISM



**I**t's 1 am when cries wake me from my stupor, yet again. My head pounds but I've grown accustomed to it in the past six weeks. If it's not from excess, it's from the lack of what I need. And it's rarely from excess anymore. I'm too scared to hurt Ember, to not hear as she cries for help.

I haven't touched liquid oblivion in three days and my skin itches. But Ember has had colic and I haven't been able to refill my room with supplies, nor count on my mother to watch her as I pretend to need sleep but drink myself into a semi-coma.

The room is always filled with my dead sister's presence, with no way out, her purple shit and colourful clothing everywhere. I'm short of breath, suffocating as I pick up my baby and fasten the soft blue sling around my back and hers. I carry Ember down the stairs to the kitchen. I'm sure my mother is awake by now and will fill the room with her questions and choking motherly love. But it will be all for her. Not for me. Maybe it's the punishment I deserve for keeping the secret that killed my sister.

No one has commented on the fact that I've lost twenty pounds in the past six weeks or that a sickly blueish colour stains my under-eyes permanently. I'm not sure I want them to. I don't know what I want except a goddam drink.

I rock Ember into my arms, bouncing on my feet as I prepare her late night bottle.

*Three, two, one.*

"I can take her if you need to sleep, *picculina*," my mum says behind me, approaching on soft feet. Her slippers slide lazily against the wooden floor. When she's next to me, she places a hand behind my daughter's head and kisses her forehead. She stops crying for a brief moment before redoubling her effort to wake my father, too.

"I got it," I answer without looking at the green eyes that still hold life and love while mine have dimmed with each passing day since my sister's funeral.

I've avoided everyone since that day and it hasn't been easy considering I live at home and everyone's always up in my business. Or I should say, my daughter's business.

I don't know when I started considering Ember as my daughter rather than my niece. Maybe the very first moment she was placed in my arms while tears were still fresh on my cheeks. Maybe the first time she cooed at me, or when she grabbed my finger as if asking that I never let go.

"Are you sure she's okay?" my mother asks and my shoulders bunch up, jaw clenching with the force of not telling her to fuck off. "She's been crying a lot."

"Yes, I'm sure. I told you she has colics. It doesn't magically go away in one day." My tone carries an edge of anger and if my father were here, he would have already smacked me for speaking to my mother like that. I barely feel the shame as the microwave beeps and I take the bottle, feeding it to Ember who gulps at it in greedy pulls.

"I know, but maybe we should get a second opinion," my mother counters with even more softness.

I want to scream.

All my family has done since that day is doubt my ability to mother Ember as I'm dealing with newly found motherhood and grieving for my soulmate.

The first time they suggested I wasn't the best suited option for my own daughter was three days after the funeral when the attorney read the documents saying she was indeed mine by law. I can't erase Lana's deep frown from my mind, nor the silence that followed the documents' reading.

I've barely ever been left alone with her since then.

"I know what's best for Ember," I say coldly before turning my back on my mother.

*Like you knew what was best for Lisa.* My mother doesn't say it but the absence of words doesn't make it less true.

I sit on the sofa in the living room. It swallows me into a warm embrace as I settle my back against the soft beige fabric and focus my attention on the bundle in my arms.

Ember's wide green eyes are set on me, as they always are. It's like she can see through my soul. But compared to all the other members of my family, she doesn't find me lacking.

Right on cue, my mother sits next to me and places a hand on my knee. "About that. Have you thought about your options, like we talked about last week?"

What she really mean to ask is if I have thought about giving my daughter up to her or Lana, who doesn't even want kids, so that I can study and "live my life", whatever the fuck that means. There's nothing else for me but Ember. She's my life now. But the last time I said that to Colomba Moretti, she cried and pleaded that a twenty-year-old shouldn't be stuck with a baby that's not even theirs. Because no one thinks she's mine, no matter what the law says. And that makes me want to drown in a bottle of whisky until I die.

The only reason I don't do exactly that pushes the bottle away with her tiny, chubby hands.

I hold her close and inhale her soft baby scent, helping her digest and swaying her in my arms as I wait for her to fall back asleep.

"There's nothing to talk about, mamma. I'm a mother now and that's all that matters."

"It doesn't have to be, *picculina*. You could go to university. Find what you want to do in life, meet someone you love."

If I had any laughter left in me, she'd hear a deep belly laugh. I'm not interested in dating. Never have been. Though when she mentions someone to love, a sinister face and tattooed hands flash across my mind. I shut that shit down quickly and look my mother straight in the eyes. "I'm not going to marry or go to university, so you can all stop hovering over me. I'll be gone soon enough and you can all forget about me. I have the trust fund Dad set up for me and Lisa, I can raise her well."

"Baby..." my mother starts but I get up.

"Enough!" My voice rises above its regular pitch. "I'm done entertaining this silly notion that I will be anything but Ember's mother. Get

it out of your heads, because it sure as hell isn't in mine."

I stomp back upstairs and close the bedroom door behind me. When I turn back to look at the place I call home, all that screams my sister's name assaults my vision. Colours everywhere, post-it notes I haven't touched, and her journal. If I stay one more night, I'll explode.

Ember sleeps soundly in my arms.

On a whim, I take my phone and text the only person who's never judged me even if he had every reason to. I don't know what Nico's deal is, but he's steadfast and the most non-judgmental person I've ever met. And he offered to host me all those weeks ago.

ME

I need a place to stay.

INSTEAD OF A RESPONSE, I receive coordinates. A few seconds later, my phone pings with a text.

NICO

Give this to your pilot. See you soon.

NO NONSENSE. Just a solution. The pressure in my chest eases and for the first time in months, my lips tip upwards. It feels alien on my face but I don't dislike the feeling.

After placing Ember into her cot, I pull a suitcase from under the bed and pack our stuff. It only takes me half an hour. I don't think I'll stay long, only enough to get some fresh air. Even the hills of Sant Armellu have started to smell like decay and despair. I just need a break from everyone. Maybe even from myself.

After leaving a note to my parents on the kitchen counter, texting Giulia that I'll be at her house in a few hours and calling a taxi, I climb up the stairs to the private jet that will take me off this godforsaken island. For being jostled around, Ember sleeps peacefully in her baby carrier. I envy her as my feet tap the floor of the airplane cabin with nerves. I've never flown anywhere. I've never left the island. Whatever awaits me on the other side of this flight can't be worse than the hell I've been living at home, lost to my grief, playing my mistakes on repeat. I take a deep breath and drown a flute of champagne to take the edge off. The tart taste bursts on my tongue

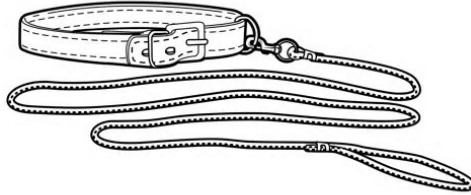
and my eyes close in delight. It's the only drink I allow myself while alone with Ember. I need to be ready for what comes next.

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## NICO

I DON'T LIKE CHANGE, BUT MAYBE IF IT'S MARIE-SHAPED, I WILL



The sense of excitement that follows Marie's text can only be compared to when I'm about to be whipped from within an inch of my life by someone who knows how to dole out pain properly. My heart rate picks up, my five senses are on high alert, ready for this change in situation. Anticipation swims in my bloodstream stronger than any drug.

It's been nine months since I first laid eyes on Marie Moretti and there hasn't been a day since when I didn't watch her through the cameras of her home, wishing I could observe her and her sadness from a closer angle. But she's barely been outside in her garden since Lisa's funeral and the distance that put between me and my newest obsession has been difficult to say the least.

I follow the dot of her private jet on my phone and see the moment she lands. I'm already waiting at the small landing base used for private flying an hour outside of West Hill.

The door on the flank of the jet opens and an airport worker slides stairs towards it. Then she appears.

Jet black hair that swooshes in the late summer air, big sunglasses hiding her face even though it's only 7 am. The baby carrier strapped to her chest over a long black dress hides half of her body but it gives her an aura of authority. Like a goddess made flesh, she descends the steps. When both her feet are on solid ground, she lifts her head up and sees me, stopping short. I take it as a good sign to approach.

“Hello, Marie.”

“Hi, Nico.” She hesitates. “You didn’t have to come all the way here.” Her flustered tone makes me frown. Did she believe I’d send a chauffeur and not welcome her here?

“Of course, I did. I invited you here, Marie.”

I can’t stop saying her name. It tastes so luxurious in my mouth. No other name has ever had that effect on me. It’s both soothing and exhilarating.

The early morning sun catches on her sunglasses and behind the dark tint, a tear seems lodged at the corner of her eye. My jaw clenches. I don’t know much about why she chose to come here now but that reaction is enough to send me into a murderous rage. “Why are you crying?” I ask abruptly.

She wipes the lone tear and shrugs. “Dry air inside the aircraft, probably.”

A low growl rises from inside my chest. “I don’t like it when you lie to me, Marie.” Then, I turn and motion her to follow me to the car. I had to borrow Giulia’s Mini Cooper because there was no way I could have installed a baby seat into my Valhalla and I wasn’t about to drive Marie and Ember around without proper precautions.

Marie gasps behind me and I turn to watch her lift her sunglasses to reveal sunken eyes and ashen skin that slowly turns a pretty shade of pink on her high cheekbones. The urge to touch her and feel the heat under the pad of my fingers is so sudden, I have to close my eyes and take a breath.

“You got her a seat?” Marie asks barely above a whisper.

I nod and just stand there, waiting for her next move.

“Nico got you a seat, Bibi,” she coos as she caresses the baby’s head of thin dark hair. “She was asleep most of the flight so I’m a bit scared to wake her up and have her be all fussy and distraught.” Slowly, she unclasps the carrier at the shoulders and takes Ember into her arms. I don’t notice how my body gravitates closer to both of them, eager to be in their proximity.

I’ve never seen a baby so up close before.

I must have said that out loud because Marie’s smile is blinding as she looks up at me and asks if I want to hold Ember. I take a step back, a small shiver descending on my body and reminding me that we’re on the tarmac and we should get moving.

“Maybe later. I don’t want to drop her on the asphalt.”

I don't miss how Marie pinches her lips together as though she's straining not to laugh. It makes my throat dry and my heart clench strangely in my chest.

Once Ember is secured in her seat at the back, Marie rounds the car and sits next to me on the passenger seat. Her dark dress rides up below her ankles. I've seen so many women naked and writhing at the club, the small expanse of skin should not make me clench the steering wheel so hard. I don't understand anything when it comes to her, but I want more of these feelings and weird sensations.

The ride to my place is silent. My eyes dart between the road, the woman next to me and my rearview mirror where piercing green eyes meet mine every time I look. Ember hasn't moved or fallen back asleep. It seems she patiently waits for me to bring my gaze back to her. Seeing her safe and relaxed in the back seat of the car warms me up. But unlike the sweltering heat of summer or when I have nightmares about that fateful night, it's glowing and enjoyable.

When I turn on the dirt road that leads to my house, Marie's lips part open. Lush green trees surround the property and in the middle of all that green, the fields of Scottish bluebells bring pops of dark blue that expands as far as the eyes can see. They've been in bloom since May and will remain there until the first temperature drops at the beginning of Fall.

"Nico," Marie says in awe in her husky voice. "This is so beautiful."

I preen under her attention even if the comment is about the woodland.

I park the car in front of my house, an old farmhouse renovated with dark metal and wide glass walls everywhere. If there ever was a fire in my house, it wouldn't burn down. Even the small terrace at the back, looking over the forest, has been doused in fire repellent.

As we get out of the car, Marie takes a few seconds standing and looking around in bewilderment before she walks to take Ember into her arms. "Is this where you live all year?" she asks.

"Yes. I like the quiet." I point towards a path in between the trees. "Through this path is Andrea and Giulia's house. It's a good fifteen minutes by foot. By car, you'd have to come out the same way we came in and take the next left into another dirt road."

Ember's cries fill the space between us so suddenly I almost jump back.

"I need to get inside and feed her," Marie says with a bashful tip of her lips.



I take the small suitcase from the boot, deciding not to mention that she packed light. She doesn't need to know that I have every intention of having her here with me indefinitely. Until this very second, I wasn't sure that's what I wanted. But seeing Marie in my kitchen, with Ember in one arm and the other taking formula and a bottle from the innocuous tote bag she carried, ready to prepare what she needs for the baby, I want to see this tableau every day.

Jumping into action, I heat up some water in the kettle. As though we've done this before, Marie instructs me to pour formula into the bottle then half hot and half cold water before I mix it up.

"Thank you," she says before letting a few drops land on her wrist. I file that tidbit of information for later and watch as she sits into my couch and feeds a wailing Ember. Marie's body relaxes and her eyes become droopy. She's at ease here. The room is silent save for Ember's gulps.

"You need to sleep," I tell Marie.

Her eyes are locked onto Ember's face but her chin trembles slightly. I edge closer, ready to catch her if she falls.

"I know, but I can't." Her voice breaks. I want to jump to the couch next to her and hold her. Hold them. But I've never touched someone so intensely and I'm scared it might be too much all at once. I'm rooted in place, needing to go to her but not knowing how. I've never wanted to be normal before, but right now, I wish I could just hold this girl who's about to cry and promise I'd never let go. Instead I interlace my hands together and wait. Space is the only thing I can give her.

She rewards my silence with more pieces of her. "I've never slept alone. Ever since... Now, whenever I'm alone in my bed, I can't fall asleep. The only time I can close my eyes are in between moments. On the couch. In front of the TV. And it's never restful. I'm so tired, Nico." A sob rakes her body but she holds it in.

I move to sit next to her. "I can feed her. And you can sleep here. I'll stay next to you."

A deprecating scoff leaves her lips but her green eyes plead for me to follow through with my offer. "You surely have other things to do."

"No. I don't. If you show me how to hold her, then you can sleep, Marie."

I'm feigning nonchalance. Inside, I'm freaking out.

Where do I put my hands? How do I make sure I don't drop her? What if she doesn't like that it's me carrying her. What if she doesn't like other people touching her, like I do? What if I don't?

I open my arms, ready to receive the little bundle wrapped in Marie's arms. Hesitantly and carefully, Marie pops the bottle out of Ember's mouth. Threatening wails reach my ears and I smile. I like how predictable Ember is. She's hungry so she'll cry until she's fed. Got it.

"I'm gonna put her right here." She deposits Ember in my arms, the back of her little head fitting perfectly in the crook of my elbow. "Here, support her with your other arm underneath her back and bottom." I make a nest with my arms and Ember turns toward my chest, her little fists clenched and resting against the hard plains of my body. I doubt I'm very comfortable. Not like Marie.

"What if I drop her?" I ask, uncertainty tasting like ash in my mouth.

"You won't. You're seated and she's half asleep. Once you start feeding her, she won't be moving much until she's done. Are you comfortable?"

"Yes. She's just so small and fragile. I've always seen it but never this close. Are you sure she's fine? Is she even breathing?" I'm rambling. I never ramble. I prefer to say as little as possible, never wasting my breath with useless words. But I can't seem to stop worrying. Is this what it's like to be a parent? I'm gonna be sick.

"Make sure to hold the back of her head when you move." Marie's voice cuts through the haze of concern and doubt. "I'm only going to rest my eyes anyway so I'll hear if she's unhappy. You need to make her burp afterwards. If the gas is stuck in her belly, she'll cry and she'll be in pain."

"Okay." I nod and hold the bottle to her tiny mouth. It's hard to decide if I should look at Ember as she watches me from her soulful eyes or at Marie and how the rise and fall of her chest is already slowing down to a stable and slow rhythm. I do both for a long time. Until Ember falls asleep in my arms and a deep calm settles over my shoulders. Maybe because she's so innocent, but it's easy holding Ember. I don't feel like I need to flay my skin from my muscles and bones or that I could get sick if my fingers touch her.

Ember looks so at peace and pure. Her little yellow clothes contrast with my dark tee-shirt and dark jeans, accentuating all the differences between us. The more I look at her, the more I get irrationally angry at anyone who would want to hurt her and any other being like her, so small and

defenceless. I press her against me a little tighter and she releases a little snore. My head drops down on its own and I inhale in her dark curls of hair.

I'm not sure what I was expecting but she doesn't smell like Marie. It's sweet but also reminds me of fresh laundry and warm bread. Whatever it is, it's comforting and makes me want to never put her down.

Marie is curled up on the side of the couch, her dark hair falling gently over her face. The sun has come up by now but doesn't disturb her sleep.

No intrusive thought of how my father died and how responsible I am plagues me. I keep watch over the two new people in my home like a guard dog on duty and everything in my head settles. I usually have to work harder for that to happen. I dread when I'll sleep tonight because that's when memories will be back to the surface and now that Marie and Ember are here, I don't want them to see.

I get up, Ember in my arms, and glide the strand behind Marie's ear with two fingers, barely caressing the apple of her cheek. She lets out the tiniest moan. My hand freezes over her.

Holding my breath, I lower down my fingers to her cheek again. Featherlight, I slide them down towards the column of her neck. The same sound escapes her lips. It's the prettiest sound I've ever heard. I let my hand hover over her shoulder before I reluctantly take a step back. I place Ember into the bed I got her in the small open alcove behind the couch. She sleeps soundly so I leave her there, knowing I'm only a few feet away if she needs me.

Sitting in front of Marie again, I relax into my seat and luxuriate in the sight in front of me. Both Marie and Ember sleep soundly, safe in my home. Nothing has ever felt this good.

## MARIE

HOW NOT TO FALL WHEN YOUR ROOMMATE SAYS “USE ME”



I wake with a start, head pounding reminding me that I haven't touched the precious liquid that annihilates me as much as it gives me life in way longer than I'd like. For once, my lips don't stick together and my throat isn't parched so I guess small wins and all that. I turn my head left and right and suddenly, the past few hours come rushing. I'm not home and I can't see my daughter. The house is shrouded in semi-obscurity. I must have slept all day. I straighten on the sofa and look for Ember but she's nowhere to be found.

"She's fed, sleeping soundly in the alcove behind us. She probably needs to be changed but I don't know how to do that. And I'm not sure you want me to," a voice like sin says next to me and I deflate, swallowing around the lump in my throat. No one in my family has ever dared stay and watch over me and Ember for a full night.

In the low light, I didn't see Nico but he's here. A vigilante sitting on his lounge chair like it's a throne. The setting sun reflects on his pupils, almost giving him the allure of a beast hidden in the forest, ready to hunt. His dark clothes blend in his surroundings but his posture is relaxed against the back of the chair. I tilt my head to the side and take my time to observe him as he flicks on a vintage lamp by his side. High cheekbones, piercings on his lower lip, short cropped hair and a myriad of tattoos on his arms and hands. He's magnificent when he's ready to pounce, but seeing him at ease is soothing.

“What time is it?” I ask just to break the silence becoming heavy between us.

“7 pm.”

Fuck, I *did* sleep all day. I don’t know when was the last time I slept that long and that deeply. At least not since the funeral. I haven’t been able to fully rest all alone in my bedroom. The door was always open to Lisa’s space as if my soul was waiting for her to show up. But she never did.

“I need to feed Ember again. And do some groceries for what she’ll need.”

I get up and walk to the kitchen counter to rummage through my bag and take a pen to make a list. I don’t know if they have the same products here than we have on Kalliste but my cheeky baby only likes one brand of formula and I want to make sure I don’t forget anything. I also only have like three diapers in my small suitcase. “Thank you for letting me stay here for a few days,” I add behind my shoulder, not looking at the man whose unwavering attention slowly starts to awaken feelings I’ve never had before.

Nico stands and prowls to me with graceful movements, stopping shy of a foot in front of me next to his dark kitchen counter. “I sent Giulia to get the same formula as the one you had in your bag, and there are diapers in the alcove. I wasn’t sure which size you’d need so I got three different ones. I also looked up online what you would need for her and for yourself so there is a lot of stuff between there and your room. Baby wipes, tampons and pads, also in different sizes—”

He continues to list more items he bought for me and I feel my cheeks warm with heat. He stays a foot away from me and I wish I could close the distance and hug him. His kindness is a little too much right now. My lips tremble with emotion. “You didn’t have to do all this, Nico.”

“Of course, I did. I want to take care of you.”

The declaration isn’t something to write home about. It’s pure honesty and almost brutal, warming me from the inside out, throat to stomach. With the way my family has handled me in the past six weeks, it breaks my resolve. A sob escapes me before I can hold it in.

“Why are you crying?” Nico immediately asks, concern raising his pitch.

“Because you’re being very kind. And very honest.”

“And that’s a bad thing?”

“No,” I laugh softly. “It’s a very good thing. I’m just not used to it.”

There’s barely any light in the room but I don’t miss his frown when I look up into his dark brown eyes.

“My family hasn’t been very honest with me lately. Or ever for that matter. And I wasn’t either. I never told them about Lisa’s cancer.” His jaw ticks but he stays quiet. The fact that he doesn’t try to tell me how much they care for me and I must not interpret their love correctly is enough to make me cry harder. “I don’t think anyone knows what to do with me or how to deal with my shit.”

“There’s nothing *to do* with you, Marie. You’re a human being experiencing a very unique kind of grief. You’re not to be *dealt with*.”

Nico steps into my space. We’re so close I can almost feel the rise and fall of his chest like it’s my own breath filling up my lungs. “You don’t have to do or be anyone but yourself here.”

“Thank you.”

I remain silent and lose myself in his eyes, resolve and authentic care written all across his striking features. I make the mistake of dropping my gaze to his lip in time to see him flick his piercing with the tip of his tongue three times. Heat rises in my body until it drops lower. The sensation is new and heady. It reminds me of how it feels when whiskey spreads inside my bloodstream, except the heat usually stays in my stomach and now, it pours lower still and settles at the apex of my thighs. I want to press them together but I clench the pen in my hand instead and turn my attention back to my list. I write down a few items even though I’m sure I’ll find them in the guest bedroom.

“Can you show me where Ember is?” I ask Nico and he takes me to the semi-closed space behind the sofa where a baby bed is set up against the wall, my daughter sleeping soundly, wrapped in a soft grey blanket.

“Did you wrap her?” I ask incredulously.

Nico nods. “I watched tutorials. They say it’s the safest for babies so they don’t suffocate under heaps of fabric.”

My heart jumps inside my chest. “That’s... incredibly thoughtful. Thank you.”

“I wanted to make sure I could do what was right in case you wanted to rest. I’m glad I learned before you arrived.”

“But I texted you just a few hours ago.” I frown and he shrugs, like his behaviour is obvious.

“I’ve been learning since she was born. I read a lot. It’s confusing because people have different opinions so I’m not sure what is correct but this, professionals agree on.” His matter-of-fact admission is both jarring and cute. I turn my attention back to him. His eyes are on Ember but he has a puppy-like excitement written all across his beautiful face and when he looks back at me, his smile is blinding. I find myself smiling back and wanting to hug him. He’s tall and lean, unlike the men in my family or the goons who watched over my sister and I. I think I like it, but I remain rooted in place instead of closing the short distance between us to settle into his arms. Rejection would break me right now.

He gives me privacy while I change her and wrap her to my chest.

“Do you want to see the rest of the house?” he asks with something akin to hope in his voice a few minutes later.

I nod and Nico takes me to visit the rest of the small cabin. He lights up another side lamp that illuminates the space in a warm yellow glow. The lounge area and open kitchen is comfortable. Night has truly fallen and without any neighbours close, it’s too dark to make out the landscape outside. After walking a short corridor, two doors on the right side open to bedrooms and one on the left to a bathroom made of black and white tiles. There’s no bath but a beautiful shower with what looks like a lot of jets. It’s calling my name and Nico must sense it.

“There’s a bathrobe and towels on your bed, if you’d like to shower.”

The way he anticipates my needs makes my stomach swoop. He shows me how to operate the massage jets and leaves me to it, telling me that he’ll take care of Ember if she wakes up.

I haven’t trusted any member of my family with her but I trust Nico. I know he won’t take her away from me and with all the online research he’s done since she was born, it makes me feel like he was waiting for my call. Is it wrong of me to rely on him more than I thought I would? To let him take the burden off my shoulders for a few moments? I decide to answer the million questions in my head at a later time, when I’m not so frazzled and raw.

I untangle my daughter from my chest and lay her in his waiting arms. His entire body softens as he carries her to the living room.



I STAY WAY LONGER under the spray of hot water than I normally would, allowing the heat to melt my tired muscles and relax my overstimulated brain. Unfortunately, it doesn't abate the raging headache pounding in my brain so vividly I feel it in my eye sockets.

I put on dark joggers and a comfy black sweater from my suitcases that only comprises dark clothing. I never liked colour but now, they remind me of Lisa too much and I can't bear to see colours anymore.

When I step back into the open living room, Nico is setting up an easel and blank canvas by the large window in front of the patio, brushes and paint next to it on a high table.

"You paint?" I ask incredulously. I don't know why I've never pictured him as an artist. Maybe it's because I know he comes from a criminal family like mine and hobbies seem futile.

"Yes. But rarely in here," he answers cryptically.

My stomach rumbles loudly in the silent room and I blush.

"You're hungry. I have some leftovers in the fridge, we can reheat them."

Without waiting for an answer, Nico moves towards the fridge on silent feet and graceful movements that speak of his occupation. I stand and observe him, unguarded in his home as he places what looks like lasagna on a plate and re-heats it in the microwave. It's so common. Too common for a man like him, that looks like Death itself but feels like a safe haven.

The microwaves beeps and he takes the steaming plate out. The smell of homemade cooked pasta in cherry tomatoes sauce wafts towards me, and my stomach grumbles louder, pulling a smile on Nico's pierced lips.

"Eat, Marie," he says and I frown. Receiving orders from him sends a chill to my spine—not a good one—and I click my tongue.

"I'm sorry." He bows his head slightly. "My mother made the lasagna for Friday's dinner at Andrea's. Would you like some?"

"Yes, thank you, Nico."

I sit and take my first bite of food since the beginning of the day. Flavours burst on my tongue and my eyes close, savouring. It tastes very



different from my Mammona's recipe and I think that might be why I love it even more. My heart clenches at the reminder that I basically fled my family including her. If someone never made me feel like a burden, it's my grandmother but I still died a little more each day, isolated in that big house full of life.

"You're trembling. Are you cold?" Nico asks and pulls me out of my daydreams. Or are they nighttime thoughts? It's past nine in the evening after all.

"No."

The trembling is automatic when my body misses the alcohol I've got it accustomed to.

"Do you need a drink?"

My mouth gapes open. I've never hidden from him but his brutal honesty is disconcerting and makes me want to lash out and hide. His eyes retain no disdain or disgust that yes, my body needs it, so I simply answer. "Yes".

Nico gets up and pulls a can out of his fridge. "Here. It's a low alcohol beer. Going cold turkey isn't going to cut it. I also want you to use me when you need to drink."

"What?" I sputter around a mouthful of lasagna.

Use him? I'm a virgin and I barely know him. What sort of proposition is that? That's not only an unconventional approach, it's ridiculous. Besides, what is he going to do on top of offering sexual favours? Enable me? I still have Ember to take care of. She hasn't woken up in hours and I know she'll cry for her first night bottle soon.

"I said 'I want you to use me when you need to drink'."

"I heard you loud and clear, Nico." I cross my arms, plate discarded in front of me. My hand itches with the need to lift the beer to my lips. I don't even like beer. But I do like the promise of relief from the ache in my system. "I have no clue what you mean and I didn't come here to play games. Explain."

Slowly, Nico drops his fork and dabs his luscious mouth with a napkin, leaving the kitchen island to sit on the sofa. It's not the first time I'm alone with this man while he sits as if setting himself lower than me. The butterflies taking flight in my stomach have nothing to do with the need for alcohol for once and everything with the killer in front of me. Of course I know what role Nico plays in our chess board of underground

organisations, but he's letting me have the upper hand. My head swims with the power of it.

Nico cranes his neck ever so slightly to look up at me. Driven by a force stronger than the one coursing through my hands and directing me to the glass bottle, I rise and walk to stand in front of him. "Use you, how?" I articulate each word.

"Anyway you like," he answers, his eyes glowing with what I think is trepidation behind the amber irises.

I lick my lips involuntarily.

The tether between us is taut and pulls me to him. Our eyes stay locked as I rise and close the distance separating me from him until I stand just in front of his knees. When he doesn't move, I raise a brow. Nico opens his legs until I can step in between. My chest swells with pride as he does exactly what I want and I give him a gentle smile. What is it with this dynamic that makes me crave more?

His eyes shine with eagerness, his hands clasped on his thighs like he's trying his best not to reach for me. The cocktail is heady.

"Are you offering to distract me, Nico?"

He nods.

"Use your words."

"Yes, Miss Marie." I almost groan and bite my lip instead. "I didn't think you'd take that road. I thought you'd want to talk but I'm not complaining."

"Are you offering your body as a distraction, Nico?" I ask, tilting my head to the side, trying to gauge his interest.

My heart beats inside my ribcage, expecting rejection and more disappointment. I don't recognise myself. I'm not interested in intimacy like that. At least not until now. Not until him. I haven't taken a sip of that beer but I'm drunk on something else. Something I don't know how to name but as powerful. Is that why he's offering? Does he know what he does to me?

## MARIE

NO MORE HIDING MY SADNESS



Nico leans forward, his hands hovering over the sides of my knees. He flexes his knuckles three times. He does things in three a lot.

“Yes, Miss Marie. I said anyway you like,” he finally answers.

I glance at his hands still hovering over my skin.

I wonder how that would feel. How his slender fingers will run their way up my legs, awakening goosebumps or heat. If he will go up or around to caress the abundant flesh until he finds the place where my legs meet my ass.

My breaths come out in pants, anticipation making me feel warm and drunk and needy. I want him to do what I say, to give me what I want and do it with a smile. I don’t understand it but maybe I don’t need to.

“You can touch me,” I tell him.

Nico hesitates and swallows hard and doubt slams into me. I jerk back, like someone doused me in cold water.

“You don’t have to! Forget it, it was stupid.”

I take a step back, then two, wrapping my arms around myself. The need to flee, to escape is so strong I almost bolt out the door.

Nico remains seated, giving me all the power once again. I can decide how to handle his rejection. The answer is not well.

Ember chooses this moment to wake up and wail and I rush to her, grateful for the reprieve from Nico’s unflinching gaze and attention. I scoop my daughter into my arms, smelling her hair. That brings my nervous

system back into reset almost immediately but I still sense his presence behind me.

“I’ll make a bottle,” Nico offers and I close my eyes.

He’s too kind and I’m a fucking mess. I’m a highly functioning alcoholic with suicidal thoughts who can’t talk to her family for shit, with a baby who needs me and won’t have a stable home to grow up in and be healthy and happy. I’m gonna fuck her up and yet, I can’t let her go. And Nico, he’s so... sweet and gentle and nice. Why is he so nice to me? Can’t he see that I should be in a mental institution right now, sedated and medicated, with my baby in my family’s care so she actually grows up to be happy? I don’t deserve to have him, in any way. Not a friendly way. Not a whatever-happened-just-now way. I don’t even deserve to be in his house.

“Here,” Nico says behind me and I jump, gasping loudly.

He moves like a wraith.

I thank him and take the bottle, shushing Ember as she laps up at it.

“What do you need, Marie?” Nico asks, staying close to me even as I try to keep my back to him. I can’t deal with the pity that will inevitably show up in his eyes.

“For you to leave me alone.”

“Okay. Before I go, can you tell me why you freaked out just now?”

I huff. Now I’m getting angry. I almost laugh when I turn to him, dreaming of slapping his pretty face. The alcove is dark, the light from the main room barely reaching the corners here. He fits right in. I’m sure many have pissed themselves in terror because of the man in front of me. All I want to do is put him in his place. I’m pathetic but I’m not to be mocked.

“You rejected me, Nico. And I get it. I’m a mess and I have a kid. I told you not to play games with me earlier. Don’t insult me by asking the fucking obvious.”

His eyes widen but other than that, he doesn’t give away any emotion. He gently shakes his head but I think it’s more for my sake than an actual reaction.

“Marie. I didn’t reject you. The truth is I’ve never wanted to touch someone as much as I want to touch you. But that takes time.”

The only sounds in the space around us are the suckle of Ember. There’s usually always a low buzz of electricity in the air. A fridge or microwave that emits a frequency barely noticeable to the common ear. But its absence is deafening. In the silence, I hear my heart beating in my ears and could

almost perceive the blood flowing through my veins. I try to understand Nico's meaning but my mind blankets. And I need his words. His honesty helped before. I need it now.

"Continue," I ask.

"I don't like touch, Marie. I don't touch people I don't know, barely touch the people I love so when you said I could touch you, even if that's what I want, I don't know if I can."

"Oh." I didn't consider that. Relief floods through me. I actually relate to that a lot. I've never wanted anyone to touch me like I want him to.

"And I'm not playing games, either. Some non-verbal cues are harder for me to understand. That's all."

"Oh."

"You already said that," he chuckles. His eyes soften and I relax a little more. Ember fusses in my arms and I focus my attention on her again, helping her with digestion with gentle taps on her back before changing her.

While I go about my mundane tasks, Nico silently watches, his arms crossed over his chest and a leg over the other, leaning against the doorframe that doesn't hold a door. He shouldn't be as sinfully distracting.

I pretend to ignore him until I can't avoid the inevitable anymore.

"I'm gonna go to bed. I'm taking Ember with me."

"Of course. Can I do anything for you?" he asks, then comes closer and looks at Ember, awake in my arms, when I say no. "She looks like you."

My chin trembles and a shiver courses through my limbs. Instead of letting it go, I take a deep breath in and swallow my tears.

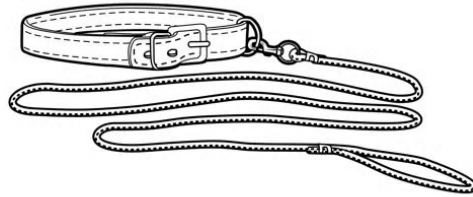
"You don't have to hide your sadness here, Marie," Nico says before leaving to his bedroom. The door closes with a soft click.

When I get into bed, my daughter next to me in her own, a passing thought that I never had that beer comes to mind but before I can make sense of it, it's already gone.

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# NICO

LUNA MIA



I wake up covered in sweat. My room is dark but the moonlight shines from the open window. The silence in the house is eerie and I strain to hear my guests on the other side of the wall. There's faint movement but I don't know if that's normal or not.

It's like fire still licks my skin. I take three rounds of deep inhale and exhale. A ritual that's as familiar as it is painful. My hand itches to make the person responsible pay before I have to remind myself that it already happened.

The sheets are damp and I get up, stripping the bed and walking to the laundry room to get them into the laundry machine. I'll start it in the morning; now that I have a guest, I can't live during the night like I usually do. I want to know what Marie looks like when she sleeps. Is she as peaceful as Ember? Does she frown?

I pull on a pair of grey sweatpants and advance on the bedroom door, slightly ajar. Pushing it open, I stand there frozen as I survey the room. Ember sleeps soundly in her cot but Marie seems to struggle against her own demons. Her head whips side to side and she whimpers low. I know the feeling all too well and my gut stirs.

I approach the bed and, not for the first time, the need to touch her almost overwhelms me. Years of conditioning and training help me remain in control. Though I'd wished she'd take it from me.

“Marie,” I call out but she doesn’t wake up, turning away from me and curving herself into a ball.

I know first hand what it’s like to have nightmares. To be stuck in your own head, knowing intimately that you’re reliving a memory and that nothing is real but being incapable of waking up. I call out her name, louder this time, bedding a knee on top of her bed. I don’t mind if Ember wakes up. She’ll fall back asleep, but Marie needs to get out of her own head.

“Marie!” I raise my voice and shake her shoulder, her skin soft under my hand. Before I can fully get comfortable with the new feeling, she gasps as she sits up.

“Where’s Ember?” she asks in a panicked tone.

“In her cot. She’s safe. You’re safe.”

Slumping slightly, she raises her hands to cover her face, shaking it slightly, then rubbing her eyes.

“I’m sorry I woke you up, Nico. I’ve always had trouble sleeping without...” She doesn’t finish her sentence but I don’t need her to voice the name of the person she loved most. “I don’t sleep well by myself.”

She fidgets with her hands, her soft top revealing her left shoulder. Without thought, the fingers of my right hand travel the distance between us. I pull the fabric back up with my thumb and index finger, grazing Marie’s skin. Our breaths itch in tandem.

What comes out of my mouth next isn’t like me but I wouldn’t take it back for the world.

“Want me to sleep here with you?”

She sputters and I smirk. I’m not propositioning her again. But I could if I knew she’d take the bait. The uncertainty of our situation right now is too intense, too deep. I don’t like not knowing. I want to lay myself bare before Marie but she’s not ready to receive me.

“Get your head out of the gutter, Miss Marie. I’m only offering my presence.”

“I know”, she huffs.

It’s adorable. A sign of her youth. I’m not much older than her. Twenty six to her twenty, but the blood on my hands and the need for vengeance in my system aged me beyond the number written on my passport. Marie has always been sheltered.

I stay silent and let her decide. It doesn’t take long before she scoots over to one side of the bed and gives me an order. “Get in.”

Those two words send a shiver of need down my spine and I bury it deep inside myself. I'm her reprieve, her safety net, her guardian in the storm. I don't want to be the one making demands, yet another person to satisfy and listen to when she's probably already dealing with too many at home. I get under the covers without a word and turn to face her.

The pillow is cool under my cheek. Despite the cover of night, her eyes shine with an emotion I don't have a name for.

"What are you thinking about?" I ask.

I can't be sure but I think she blushes and now I definitely need to know. I wait again, giving her the upper hand.

"I was watching your lips," she says. I pass my tongue to my piercing three times. "Yeah, exactly that. You always do that when you're thinking or waiting for something."

"Are you telling me I have a tell?" It's more than a tell, but I won't reveal that.

"Yeah." She smiles and it could illuminate the whole room. "You have a tell. And I like it."

Her voice is barely above a whisper, like she doesn't want the walls to hear.

Hesitantly, her hand lifts. Before she can touch me, she asks softly, "Can I?", and I nod. We've been there twice before. Three is my favourite number. The knowledge of a circle completed sends flutters inside my chest. My throat dries. These sensations are new. I catalogue them in a folder named after her and let her move slowly.

When her index lands on the metal on my lower lip, she presses down immediately this time, giving me yet another taste of what it's like to be touched by her. And to like it. Even Damian doesn't touch me beyond helping my skin heal after a session. She flicks my piercing side to side three times before pulling my lower lip down and releasing. I hold my breath for what she'll do next.

Her eyes, turned darker, flick to my nose ring. She meets my gaze and I nod again, consenting to whatever she has in mind. Her middle finger glides softly from in between my eyebrows to the bridge of my nose, to the piercing but she doesn't linger and slowly brings her fingertips to my left cheek. "Is this okay?"

I swallow hard and close my eyes, focusing on where her hands rest against my face. She's warm and I don't recoil. My body isn't trying to tell



me to remove her from me. My heart beats fast in my chest at the novelty but none of the usual shudder and disgust taints the experience. “Yes, Miss Marie,” I breathe as I open my eyes again.

Her fingers slowly move down until they rest at my pulse point, while her thumb is back at my mouth. Trepidation makes me dizzy.

“Open,” Marie commands, and my cock stirs to life underneath the sheets. I obey and she slides her thumb inside my mouth, finding the metal on my tongue and playing gently with it with the pad of her finger. I can taste her skin, and unlike the first time, I can fully revel in it this time. My eyes roll back and I harden further in my sweatpants.

The slight pressure she applies on my tongue in a series of three threatens to unravel me right in front of her. My own hands tighten into fists. I could play the brat and move but I don’t want that with her. I want her to tell me what to do, I want to be what she needs. I don’t know what that is yet but I know we’re about to enter a new territory.

She retracts her thumb from my mouth and puts it in hers and I whimper. I don’t mean to, my body not fully my own where she’s concerned and I’m finding that exhilarating. Through her own finger, our tongues touched and I moan at the idea of doing it but this time, without any intermediary. What would that be like? Does she taste as good as her skin does?

The sudden image in my mind of me licking every inch of her skin as she pulls on a leash locked on a collar around my throat has my balls tightening up. I’m not even discreet as I squirm, my hips thrusting against thin air, trying to get a modicum of relief against the fabric of my boxers.

Marie watches me intently, her lips parted around her thumb. She closes them around the digit and hollows her cheeks and I moan again, following the movement. For the first time in my life, I want her to do that to me. I want her to touch me. I want her to give me pleasure. I want to give it all to her. All I am is *want*, needy desire and mindless lust.

She removes her thumb from her mouth with a pop and arches a playful brow. Her attention is intoxicating, smoother than warm liquor and stronger, too. “What do you need?”

“Whatever you’ll give me, Miss Marie.”

The sheets cover us up to our shoulders but she glances down and it’s as if she could see me and where I hurt most right now. “I’ve never seen

anyone come before. I've never wanted to," she says, almost conversationally. "I want to see you do it for me."

I frown. What she wants is still unclear to me. Does she mean she wants me to throw the sheets off our bodies and get naked or touch myself above my clothes, or none of the above? "Can you be more specific?"

"I want to watch your face as you come, Nico. So touch your cock under the covers and make yourself come for me. Can you do that?"

I nod eagerly and wrap my hand around my hard cock under the waistband of my pants. Playing with my piercings, I let out a soft breath, though it's not enough. Our eyes stay locked as I pump my length into my fist hoping I'll get to experience more of this. I want to be on my knees for her the next time we do this. There's no doubt in my head that there will be more times. I'm barely scratching the surface of what I want to do with Marie. I want the tails of a flogger branded with her name to lick the skin of my back. The things I'd let her do to me... My brain is going haywire trying to conjure images of what could be.

"Look at me," her stern voice gets me back into the reality of this moment.

She licks her lips. My orgasm draws near as I look into her sad eyes, alight with hunger, just for me. Her face relaxes with awe as she takes me in, covering every inch of my face with her dark gaze.

I squeeze myself harder and whimper again, clamping my lips shut.

"Fuck, I love that sound you make. Don't hold it."

"What about Ember?" I pant.

"She's asleep."

It's answer enough. My breath hitches, my rhythm picks up and I come with needy sounds that she devours greedily, the edges of my vision turning white.

It takes me a few seconds to come down from my high. I'm drunk on lust, the call for more already having my cock jump back to life. It won't ever be enough with her. Without ever touching me fully, or me touching her, I came harder than I ever have. And I'm determined to keep her, forever.

"Show me," she urges.

The mess left in the wake of my climax makes me wince, the texture of coldness unpleasant, but I'll hold on for her. I lift my hand from underneath the sheets, my fingers glistening with my release.

Marie simply smiles. “You did so good, Nico. I’ve never seen anyone so beautiful and vulnerable before. Thank you.”

“You don’t have to thank me, Marie. I’m the one who came.”

“I know but I needed the distraction.”

Pride swells in my chest and my cheeks heat. “Anytime, *luna mia*. Now, I really need to shower. I don’t like having my cold cum on my skin.”

“Oh my God, I’m so sorry, of course. Do you need anything from me?”

She moves to sit up but I place my clean hand above her shoulder, shy of an inch. I want to touch her but I’m on high alert and focused on cleaning myself. Nothing else matters but showering and changing into clean boxers. The only reason I’ve held on this long is because the fluid belongs to me and she gave me the best orgasm of my life. “Just sleep. I’ll be back in five minutes.”

“Okay.”

When I’ve scrubbed my skin and changed into clean clothes, I make my way back into Marie’s bed, just shy of an inch between us. Her soft snores send me into a peaceful sleep only disturbed twice by Ember’s cries for feeding. Each time, I fall back asleep a little closer to the woman who’s changing everything.

## MARIE

IN THE CAPALDI FAMILY, TRACKERS ARE A LOVE LANGUAGE



I've been living in Nico's cabin—though it's more like a beautiful house in the woods—for a week. We haven't touched, or become more intimate since the first night. I was not myself that night. In reality, I'm not myself now either.

I've been hiding. Hiding from my family, from my grief, from the world.

I can't go on like this. Especially since I'm out of supplies.

Every night I've drunk one of my miniatures I hid in my suitcase before going to sleep, except that time when I asked Nico to come for me instead. God, just the memory of his lips parting on a whimper makes me press my thighs together.

On my phone, I save articles after articles speaking about dominance and submission. I didn't realise it was such a codified world. I'm so out of my depth but every word has me more aroused, all hot and bothered. It's a nice change to the cold desire for alcohol. It warms me from the inside out.

I imagine Nico on his knees for me, waiting for my every command, willing to please after he tells everything he wants me to do to him. We would need to establish what they call "a scene", talk about limits and safe words. I've never had sex, I've never even kissed anyone so this all could be too much but it feels right. The absolute control, the choices of what I could do with someone's submission—not someone's, Nico's. That's what I crave.

“Are you okay?” Nico asks and I jump, a hand to my heart.

He moves like a wraith, silent and graceful, and I can never anticipate where he will be the next minute. I need to sharpen my senses if I ever want to be anywhere close to his skills. The voice inside my head reminds me that the only thing I truly like is when my senses are dulled and muted by sweet liquid oblivion, but I ignore it.

“You scared me. Don’t scare me like this, Nico.”

He cocks his head to the side and I know I’m about to hear another nugget of truth from the man who can’t seem to know how to lie. I pretend that it annoys me but I’m waiting with bated breath. “But your pupils widen so prettily when you’re scared. You have a similar look when you want to touch me. I like it.”

My cheeks heat and I press my hands to them before standing and moving around the room to prepare Ember’s mid morning bottle. She babbles happily in her cot, yet another item Nico made sure he had on hand before we arrived. My heart softens when I watch her touching the mobile above her head and smiling sweetly.

She’s such an easy child. She rarely cries except when she needs to eat or a change. Grief hasn’t tainted her life, resentment isn’t yet part of the range of emotions she’ll experience. I pray she never will have to, but I fear she’ll become just like me. Grey, full of rage and nowhere to put it, because I chose to raise her, and daughters often become their mother.

As I keep my eyes on my precious daughter, I’m aware of a phone buzzing close by. I turn my head to see Nico pick his phone from his pocket. The corner of his lips lift but I don’t have the luxury of studying him. My phone starts blaring a tune I haven’t changed since I was sixteen.

Giulia’s name shines on the screen and I sigh.

“Don’t even think of not answering, Marie. Giulia’s the most stubborn human I’ve ever met.”

Sometimes I forget that Nico is my cousin’s brother-in-law, now. They must have grown close since she moved here last year. But even in a day, anyone would know Giulia Moretti is the most stubborn Leo they’ll ever meet.

I pick up the phone. “Hello?”

“Hello? Hello?! That’s all you have to say for yourself, Marie Louisa Annabelle? You’ve been here a week and I heard that only today? Dragged

it out of my husband's mouth with my feminine guiles? Explain yourself, *ciucciarella*."

"Don't call me that, I'm not a baby!"

"Then don't act like one," she counters but it lacks heat. She's teasing me but somehow, this is the familiarity I've been craving for so long and never managed to touch. I smile and I'm about to answer when she continues, forever the drama queen. "Do I have to come to you or will you deign grace me with your presence, your majesty?"

"Come on, Gigi, don't be like this."

"You wound me mortally."

"Okay, why don't you come over here? Ember is awake and everything I need is here and I just—I don't know. I needed a break, you know?" My voice breaks. I'm so tired of shedding the same tears over and over.

"Of course, babe. But you should have told me. I'm right here. I'm always here for you, you know that."

My entire family has always been there for me, without ever being there. The dichotomy of what they said and what they showed was too hard to sustain, and now, I don't know if I can trust my cousin, my own blood, to be there for *me*. Only me. Not snitch to my sister about my whereabouts, though she knows I'm here, of course. Not convince me to go back to Kalliste or give my daughter up.

"I'll bring wine," Giulia says and my ribcage becomes too tight. My fingers itch with the need to raise a glass to my lips. I turn my gaze to Nico but he didn't hear. I don't want him to see me drink. He's the only one who knows but he's also the only one I want to impress. With my family, hiding my little problem is more a case of not wanting them to scold me and berate me, treat me more like a child than they already do. With Nico, everything is different. New and not yet spoiled by years of resentment, lies by omission and abandon.

"Sure, I'm not doing anything special today," I tell her and we hang up quickly.

I haven't seen Giulia since the funeral and, maybe because she isn't one of my sisters, or because she has a new family now and isn't the epitome of loyalty to the Morettis only, she's less pressure for me. And she's bringing what I need.

Nico disappears into his bedroom and reappears seconds later with an object in his hands. Without a word, he sits next to me on his comfortable

couch, facing the bay window overlooking the dark green forest surrounding his house. The view is breathtaking and so peaceful, so different from the turquoise and cyan of the Mediterranean Sea from my window on Kalliste. The field of Scottish Bluebells is the only pop of colour but somehow, they don't trigger me.

He opens his hand to reveal a thin gold bangle. It's an elegant piece, finer than any jewellery I've ever allowed myself to get or wear. My mother always offered for me to borrow some of her precious golden ornaments but I never dared, I never thought it would do anything for me. And with my formal clothes, I always looked too serious anyway, I didn't want to add the bracelets and necklaces to it. But I never dared to wear any of the grunge chains and metal Lisa would buy either. Always stuck in between.

"It's beautiful, Nico. Is it for Giulia? She'll love it," I tell him. I almost dismiss this entire moment but he frowns again and I do a double take.

"Marie, this is not for Giulia. This is for you." He says it like it's obvious. There's nothing obvious about being offered a beautiful bracelet by a man who makes my heart pound and my core heat. There's nothing casual about this moment while my daughter looks on with little stars in her shiny green eyes.

"Why?" I ask, unsure. I don't deserve it.

"It's a tracker."

"What?" I jump back. "Are you mad?" I'm close to losing my shit but Nico shrugs.

"Everyone I care about has one. Giulia in her wedding ring, Andrea around his neck, my mother, in earrings she never removes even for sleeping. I need to get to work this afternoon." His eyes harden and I don't need to ask what work means. Nico and Andrea are both in on Lana's war against Moscow and even without the threat on the horizon, Nico kills for a living. He hasn't said it but it's an inner knowing I can sense in my bones when I look at him. Especially when the warm honey of his eyes disappear in dark pools of bloodlust like now. "I need you to wear this so I can know you're safe."

"I'm only going to be with Giulia, I'm safe." I try to reason with him but his resolve is solid as steel. He stands and walks in front of me.

"I'm not leaving until you put it on, Marie. I'm not taking risks with your safety. We did with Giulia, and—" He stops himself mid-sentence and my hackles rise. I never heard about anything happening to Giulia.

“What happened to Giulia?” I ask, taking on my commanding tone I know he didn’t resist before. It’s no use.

“That’s not for me to tell.” Ember babbles at our feet and he glances down, his eyes softening, before he looks up to me again. “Please, Marie. Wear this. There’s a hidden lock, here.” He shows me how to close the bracelet and gently open it again in a hidden mechanism. “It’s important to me. The tracker is linked to my phone. I need to know you’re safe,” he repeats.

My shoulders sag and I nod, holding my wrist so he can lock the bangle around it. When the lock clicks into place, butterflies take flight in my stomach. I must be losing my mind.

“What about my daughter?” I ask, because I can’t bear to think Nico wouldn’t include her in the people he cares about.

His lips curve and his smile broadens until he gets a small box from the coffee table I hadn’t noticed before. I can’t blame myself, it’s not every day that I get offered a tracker. Even my father never suggested it—though maybe he should have, considering there have been two kidnapping attempts against Angèle and Lana, and one against Lisa and I.

He opens the little carton box and takes the cutest blue little baby shoes from it, Mary-Janes, holding them proudly, and showing the tracker inside the small buckle.

“It took me a few days to think of it because I read a lot about babies and jewellery and it’s not recommended for little ones younger than three to have them. Some have their ears pierced but I noticed when you arrived that Ember doesn’t and I didn’t want to suggest something you wouldn’t be comfortable with. So shoes seemed like a good idea.” He holds them to me and pink rises on his cheeks like he’s proud and shy all at once. He’s so goddamn cute, my eyes water.

A sob escapes me and his face falls. “You don’t think they’re good enough,” he says and it sounds like a question.

“No, I love them, Nico. Thank you. That’s... so very strange and also thoughtful.”

“Then, why are you crying?”

“Because I don’t think anyone has gone through so much trouble for me,” I choke on the words, tears wetting my cheeks on their way down the floor. My shoulders shake with the force of my emotions and I put my face in my hands, hiding the shame of feeling so much.



“What do you need?” Nico’s rough voice filters through my meltdown. Eyes puffy and lips wet with salt, I say, “Nothing you can give me, but that’s okay.”

“You want me to touch you?”

His face is so open, genuine concern shines on his striking features. He worries the piercing on his lip and I dare to ask. With him, it always seems easy. “Can you just hug me? It doesn’t have to be long.”

Straightening up, Nico nods. Awkwardly, he wraps his arms around me, making me laugh in between sobs. My head lands on his chest, his heartbeat under my ear, soothing the maelstrom of hurt in my soul. His posture is stiff but he doesn’t let go, giving me what I need yet again. When will I learn to give back? I’m selfish, demanding to be held when I know he doesn’t like to be touched.

“Can I touch your hair?” he asks, his lips above my ear, his cheek resting on top of my head.

I nod again and before long, Nico caresses my dark locks from my skull to my neck.

“It’s so soft,” he says but I’m not sure he’s talking to me.

With his touch, my eyes close and I breathe again, the sobs ceasing and disappearing like dust in the wind.

“Can I put my hands on your back?” I ask, eyes closed and taking in his dark scent, bitter chocolate and leather mixed with a hint of paint. It makes my mouth water.

“Yes.”

Softly, I let my hands rest on his back, trying not to move too much and letting him adjust to me this time, to the feeling of being touched by me. He squeezes me against him and I take it as a sign to do the same. His breath itches and I smile against his torso.

I’m about to glide my hands up and down his back when a loud bang echoes against the glass wall. We step apart to watch a curvy red-haired woman raising a bottle of wine in one hand and slapping the glass with the other again. Her eyes are wide and shocked. I’m pretty sure Nico has never allowed anyone to touch him like I just did. I’m greedy for more, and a little giddy that he let me.

“Open the door, assholes,” Giulia mouths before rolling her eyes and going for the door again, which Nico opens for her.

She storms in with flourish and embraces me in a warm hug that smells of home, but also of something new.

“I’ll be back, tonight,” Nico says before his eyes dip into the bottle and back to me. There’s no judgement in them but I know he knows I’ll be buzzed when he gets back. There’s no avoiding it. He won’t be there to distract me, and the temptation is too good.

“Yeah, yeah, we’ll be good,” Giulia says with a shake of her hand, dismissing him in his own home. I snicker as Nico shakes his head and takes off. “I swear to you, Marie, if you don’t fuck him I’m gonna lose so much money.”

I cough up at her straightforwardness.

“What?”

“Come on, babe. I have eyes. I don’t know what I walked in on, but you two are going to fuck, like I told Andrea you would. Nico hates to be touched yet he was hugging you like he couldn’t bear to let you go.” She keeps talking as she goes to the kitchen and pulls the drawers until she finds the bottle opener and takes two glasses out of the cabinet like she knows exactly where everything is. I shouldn’t be jealous but I am. Her and Nico are close and the three of them—with Andrea—are a unit I have no part in. “I bet him twenty grands that you’d fuck within a month.”

Wide-eyed and both embarrassed and excited, I ask, “What did he say?”

“That it would take six,” she laughs and hands me a glass before going to her haunches and cooing at Ember. “Who’s my favourite girl?”

All I wanted when I left Kalliste was to be away from my family, as far as I could and left alone to grieve and be with my wretched self. But Giulia won’t leave me alone, of that I’m sure. And I don’t think I mind that much.

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## MARIE

NEW ALLIES AND A BLOOMING TRUST



Ember is half asleep in Giulia's arms, my cousin holding her glass of red wine aloft in her manicured hands, her perfect red waves of hair floating around her like a halo. She looks so gracious, even with her legs tucked under her comfortably.

Half the bottle is empty between us and I relax into the comfortable sofa. Silence settles but it's not heavy with unsaid words. It's companionable and helping me quiet the demon talking on my shoulder about how much of a liar I am, how I abandoned my family, how Lisa would be ashamed of me. Maybe it's because Giulia isn't my sister or because she looks like me, yet not. Whatever it is, my lids droop and I exhale the worries away.

"So, you want to tell me why you fled like the whole of Kalliste was on fire, *ciucciarella*?" Giulia asks, voice serious and unyielding.

I scoff, reminded how much her and my sister Lana act alike, unused to being told no. Not that I necessarily want to lie further to the only person in my family who's never made me feel like a failure and a cast-out.

"You lasted—" I look at my golden watch, a present from my mother on my twentieth birthday, "—fifty minutes. Must be a record for you." My lips pull up into a smile but I know it doesn't reach my eyes; the slight frown on Giulia's freckled face confirms it. "Listen, you're not gonna like what I have to say so why don't I spare both of us the trouble. Besides, all I say

will be held against me next time I see Lana.” I mumble the last part under my breath.

“Is that what you think? That whatever you have to say, I will repeat to your sister, like I’m her pet? You wound me, bitch.”

“Well, you’re best friends. I know you talk every day,” I counter like my defence is irrefutable. I straighten up, ready for battle, and Giulia softens in turn. It makes me want to fight even more.

“Marie, I love Lana. She’s my best friend. But you’re my cousin, too. And I love you, too. If you fought with her and that’s why you’re here, that’s between you and her.”

“Everyone always chooses her side.” I look down to my wine. Maybe if I don’t look at Giulia, she won’t find all my weaknesses and judge me for them. Why would people not side with Lana, anyway? She’s the beacon of our family. She’s strong, loyal. I know she loves me. I merely hate that she thinks I’m not capable of raising my kid. And that’s only the tip of the iceberg.

The maroon liquid swirls in my glass. I’m aware of Giulia’s movements as she stands and drops her sleepy niece in her bed behind us in her little alcove. When she’s back to sit in front of me, she takes the glass, placing it aside, and holds both of my hands within hers. Her intent green eyes, a little clearer than mine, hold me captive, love shining in them in a way I’m not used to. In a way I’m undeserving of.

“Babe, you know what your sister did for our family.”

I cut her off. “Of course, I do.” It’s hard not to remember that abuse and neglect my sister lived through during her first marriage. I never wanted someone dead as much as I did her first husband, then.

“Let me finish,” she admonishes and I press my lips shut, blushing with embarrassment. Giulia has that authority shit down to a science. “Lana did what she had to do. And today, she’s doing what she thinks is best. It doesn’t mean she’s right every time. There’s a lot happening, right now, Marie.”

“I wish I knew what that meant,” I tell her, sniffing, the tears mounting in my eyes, a reminder that I’m the only one excluded. As always. Especially now that I have Ember. I let go of Giulia’s hands and pick up the glass, downing it in one large gulp before pouring the rest of the bottle into it.

“Is that what this is? You want to know we’re going to war?”

“I’m not throwing a tantrum!” My voice rises. Of course, that’s the conclusion she’d go to.

“That’s not what I said. Let me ask you this. Would you still be on Kalliste if Lana had included you in her plans?”

I asked myself that question before. But it’s not only the isolation that made me leave. There were so many deciding factors. My mother suffocating me with her pitying look, the absence of my sister across the room from me and my incapacity to move on, everyone looking at me like I’m incapable of raising a child, like I’m throwing my life away because I’m choosing her. As if I even had a life to begin with. The thought is ridiculous.

And then, there’s Nico. The man I barely know who told me he was a safe haven and I decided to believe him and just left.

“I don’t know,” I whisper. My chin wobbles and I look away. The alcohol that made me mellow earlier is turning into ice in my system, tasting like regrets and bad choices. “Maybe it’s just about me, you know. Maybe I want to do something for myself, away from everyone.”

“Yet you want to know what’s going on with the war against the Bratva?” Giulia asks, her head tilted to the side like she can’t make sense of my words. I can barely make sense of it, but yes. That’s what I want. I want to understand who I am, without my family breathing down my neck. I want to be part of the decisions that will impact me as well, even as they try to keep me away from harm. I want the choice to walk away from a meeting that talks about death and crime and pain. I want agency.

“Is it too much to ask to have it all?” I look at her then and she smiles softly at me, before it turns conspiratorial.

“Of course not, babe. That’s your birth-given right.”

She clinks her drink to mine, and the conversation digresses to easier topics like if Ember sleeps or if I like England. Considering I haven’t even stepped foot outside the four walls of Nico’s house, except to stand on the patio, overlooking the field of Scottish bluebells, I’m not sure. But her questions emboldens me to want to explore. If I didn’t come here to escape my old life, but discover who I am and build a new one, I’m afraid this place won’t be enough to do that, though I already know Nico will probably help me do exactly that.

“Well, tonight is Friday and on Friday, we host the Capaldi Friday dinner,” Giulia tells me with pride. She can’t cook for shit though. I raise a

brow. “Of course I don’t cook. I do what I do best, look pretty and entertain.” My laughter comes easily this time, melting the pinch in my chest. “Come with Ember. Nico never misses it so he can drive you or walk you. We’re only a mile away and the road through the forest is lovely and illuminated with fairy lights. Oh, and Catalina is going to love you and Ember.”

As she continues to ramble about her mother-in-law, who sounds like an amazing woman, I get a tingly feeling in my heart. Suddenly, it’s like the ashes that made up the composition of the organ blow away with the hope of what I could build here. But there’s still something hovering between us, something Nico mentioned before he left.

“What happened between you and Nico?” I ask Giulia and she startles.

“Did he say anything?”

“No, he mentioned it in passing and said it wasn’t his story to tell.”

Giulia sighs and puts her glass on the coffee table, getting up to face the bay window like facing me is too much to bear. I let my feet hit the ground again and rest my elbows on my knees, waiting for what I feel isn’t a pleasant tale.

“I was assaulted by my ex a few months ago.”

I gasp. She never mentioned it. I don’t even think Lana knows. Otherwise she’d have flown here immediately. That’s when I realise that’s what we do in my family. All the hovering, maybe it’s how we show love. I understand why Giulia wouldn’t want to talk about it.

“Nico tried to save me,” she continues. “He was with me when I got abducted, and he got shot. It was bad, Mimi.” I let the nickname slide as she turned to face me again, her expression regretful and pained. “He almost didn’t make it.”

I have to breathe through my nose to stave off the sudden urge to kill. It’s so sudden it takes me by surprise but I embrace it. “Is he dead?” I ask through clenched teeth.

“Yes. I killed him. Made him suffer, too.”

“Good.”

Silence stretches between us but I don’t drop her gaze. As though she doesn’t want my sister to hear, Giulia whispers, “Lana doesn’t know. After what she’s been through, I didn’t want to burden her with it.”

“It wouldn’t be a burden,” I tell her.

“Then, why don’t you talk to her either?”

“I—”

“Some stories are not meant to be shared, Marie. Andrea and Nico know what happened to me. And now you do, too. I trust you with this. I’m not ashamed. I don’t want this to define me. I want this in my past, not rehashed over and over. Maybe that’s what you came here to seek, too. Somewhere you have no past, only a future to build.”

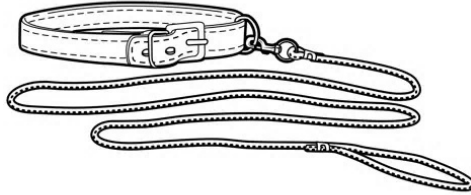
Her words land inside me like a veil of truth.

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## NICO

FRIDAY DINNER OR HOW TO GET AN INKLING OF A BREEDING KINK



As we walk the country lane that links my house to Andrea and Giulia's, I keep my hand on Marie's lower back, guiding her gently along the way, the other holding freshly cut bluebells for Giulia's table. After our hug, I've been craving more touch and letting myself try, small steps after small steps. My fingers are warm from her body heat but mostly, it's my heart I feel beating a drum in my chest. I'm touching her, and she's letting me. The anchor of that touch feels like a privilege and something more than I have a right to, especially since my fingers itch to create pain. After her arrival, nightmares still plague my nights, but less regularly than they have been since the night of my dad's passing.

Ever since I opened the door to our enemy that fateful night ten years ago, I've relived my father's death, flames licking my skin just like I remember the heat of the fire that destroyed our home and put my mother in a wheelchair. The last thing the man I thought was a friend did before he left was giving me a friendly clap on my cheek, his bare fingers on my face.

I thought I'd never be able to sleep without nightmares, or touch anyone without my brain conjuring fire in my blood until I burnt alive in my mind.

Then, Marie touched me. And now I'm touching her. It's through clothes but I'm comfortable like this. I enjoy it, even. Her warmth is soothing and I almost wish my fingers would trace the bare skin of her back.

*One day, I think as we approach my brother's humble abode.*



Where my home is all straight lines and raw wood, his is refined to look like a cottage, but one you would find in a magazine of most luxurious houses in the country. The lawn is made of grass and rose bushes that I know none of them take care of, preferring to hire an external hand rather than tend to their own garden. Giulia is as good at gardening as she is with cooking. And since she can burn pasta—and did, twice—that says a lot. The inside is all understated luxury, too. It fits them perfectly.

“I prefer your house,” Marie whispers to me as Giulia ushers us in, kissing Ember, wrapped on Marie’s front like the cutest bundle.

Giulia doesn’t kiss me, simply winking, before moving through the house. I love that I don’t have to pretend that I like contact with her. Intimately, from the very first time we met, she understood what I couldn’t vocalise and has never made me feel bad about it. That’s her strength. My sister-in-law knows everything about the people she interacts with, from the first look, which makes her incredibly good at being my brother’s spy.

“There they are. I’ve heard so much about you two,” my mother exclaims then wheels herself closer. I dip down to kiss her cheek briefly.

Marie’s eyes dip quickly to my mother’s wheelchair and I’m glad to see that her expression doesn’t change. She bends at the waist to kiss my mother’s cheeks, then turns a wide-eyed Ember.

“It’s lovely to meet you, Mrs Capaldi,” she says softly, so far removed from the woman who commands me at will.

“Call me Catalina, *carina*. Mrs Capaldi was my late husband’s mother,” my mum jokes with a fake shiver. “That woman was not pleasant to be around.” She then turns back her attention to Ember. “And this must be Ember, your sister’s daughter?”

“She’s *my* daughter,” Marie interjects defensively, silence following the small outburst.

“Of course, *carina*. I’m sorry. I didn’t mean to upset you.”

Andrea clears his throat, but as always, it’s Giulia who jumps in and saves us from the awkward silence. “Let’s eat. Andrea’s stew is gonna get cold and no one wants to eat coagulated meat stock,” she says with a shiver and a shake of her head.

“Aren’t you vegan?” Marie asks her cousin with a frown.

“Andrea made a portion without meat for me,” Giulia answers with a soft look to my brother, who preens under her attention. He’d do anything

for her. He did, while I was in the hospital down for the count and unable to save her when I should have.

The shame of those events still haunts me. Knowing she suffered because I couldn't protect her reminds me that I haven't nearly paid the price of my mistakes. As it always does, slowly throughout dinner, ants start to crawl up my limbs. Focusing on the conversations around me gets more difficult but I try. For her.

"Can I hold Ember?" my mother asks Marie when it's time for her nightly bottle. There's apprehension in Marie's green eyes but she swiftly looks my way and I give her an imperceptible nod. She places a fussy Ember in my mum's arms and the picture does something to the organ in my chest. I don't understand why it squeezes almost painfully but I take a mental picture, burning it inside my brain. My mother looks so happy with a tiny baby in her arms, like she's found a new purpose. She's the most resilient woman I know, but both Andrea and I left her house years ago and despite her position at the West Hill Hospital Board, she's mentioned to me that days can get lonely.

Andrea and Giulia are adamant about not wanting children. I turn to watch Marie, her features soften as she idly talks to my mum about Ember and her first week in my house. Her shoulders are relaxed and the grey under her eyes is almost gone. She looks more at peace than she did when she landed. She isn't smiling yet, but that's okay. I can own all her smiles.

We move to the living room, Andrea and Giulia staying behind to clean up the kitchen.

"She's such an easy babe," my mother says conversationally. "Both Andrea and Nico were so fussy when they were her age. Do you think you'll give her brothers or sisters?"

With the way Marie chokes on her diet coke, I understand it's not something you should ask. Since Marie is a twenty—soon-to-be-twenty-one—year-old mother who met mine an hour ago, with pain, grief and trauma that could fill the entire city of West Hill, I get it.

"Mum," I admonish, and she apologises before moving on to planning a shopping trip she can take Giulia, Marie and Ember on.

Now that she spoke the idea into existence, I picture Marie, round with child, and a little Ember playing on the patio of my house. The sun is setting as I approach Marie from behind, settling my hands on her belly and my chin on the crook of her neck. She smells like her usual lavender scent,

but underneath is the distinct smell of my hypoallergenic detergent and my favourite lemon soap. She smells like mine. My fingers flex on her stomach, carrying *my* child.

“So?” Marie asks and my eyes fly open.

Fuck, that vision felt so real. What did I miss? I’m never this reckless, my attention always on my surroundings. But the moment my mother talked about other children, my subconscious took over, showing me what I could have.

“So, what?” I ask, schooling my features to nonchalance.

“Do you think you can drive me to West Hill on Thursday? To meet with Giulia and your mother?” Marie asks, then places a gentle hand on mine that’s resting on the arm of the leather chair. “It will do me good to get out of the house.”

For the second time this evening, thoughts leave my mind as all my attention is stolen and drops to where the pad of her fingers touch the back of my hand. I drop my eyes to her hand and swallow hard, unknown emotions clogging my throat as I bask into her touch and attention.

In the corner of my eyes, I don’t miss the exchanged looks between my mother, Andrea and Giulia who are two seconds away from giggling like teenagers.

I look up and her dark green eyes ensnare mine. We could be alone in the room for how the world around us disappears, creating a safe bubble around her and I.

Marie moves to remove her hand, “sorry” leaving her lips and I want to banish that word from her vocabulary. So fast she doesn’t see me coming, I keep her hand on top of mine, pressing my second hand on top of hers and squeezing my fingers once.

Her lips part and her pupils widen, something dark and possessive swirling within the dark depths. It’s breathtaking.

“It’s settled, then,” Giulia breaks the silence and our bubble pops, but she doesn’t remove her hand and I keep mine exactly where it is, conscious not to move an inch. “Nico, before you go, Andrea and I would like to talk to you.” Her voice drops as though there’s a secret to share. They want to talk about the next step in the war against Misha Petrov. My brother is allied with Aleksei Dobrev, the Pakhan of the London Bratva, who’s decided to go rogue and take our side instead of supporting Misha’s

endeavour and dark trade. He must have intel on the whereabouts of our enemies.

In the corner of my eyes, Marie deflates and seems to curl up in the corner of the couch, used to being dismissed when her family wants to talk shop.

“That’s my cue to leave,” my mother says before embracing everyone and calling her chauffeur to take her home.

When it’s just the four of us, Ember sleeping in a small basket Giulia made for her in front of the fire, Giulia motions for me and Andrea to follow into Andrea’s study at the end of a dark corridor. Marie’s downcast eyes break my heart, the way she nibbles on her nails and eye the whiskey bottle on the vintage cart making me want to kill her entire family for making her feel this way.

I walk to her and take her hand in mine. Like every time I’ve touched her, energy sparks between us, my body a live-wire of electricity that only she can turn into power. “Come on,” I tell her. “Let’s hear what they know.”

“I’m not wanted there, trust me.”

“Do you want to be there?”

She rolls her lips into her mouth and nods, no hesitation whatsoever. “Then, take your rightful place, Miss Marie,” I say with a lift of my lips.

Her eyes brighten, shining with what I can only interpret as excitement. I caress her wrist with my thumb and her blood thrums under the digit.

We walk the short distance between the living room and the study hand in hand, leaving the door open in case Ember wakes up. Andrea sits like a king on his throne behind his mahogany desk, Giulia standing tall and proud at his back. Keeping my fingers on Marie’s hand, I move to stand behind her. Ready to have her back. Guarding her like a dog.

“Are you sure you want to be here, *ciuciarella*?” Giulia asks Marie who flinches before righting her shoulders back.

“I have a right to know what will impact my future and the future of my daughter.” Her voice rings like steel in the lavish space and I suppress a groan. I give her a light squeeze, showing her my support in whatever way I can. People in her family needs to stop telling her what the fuck to do. Can’t they see they’re snuffing her light every time they push her away?

“Lana’s gonna kill me,” Giulia mumbles, raising her eyes to the ceiling like it will give her strength to deal with this family drama.

“Lana isn’t my keeper. We talked about this, Gigi.”

*Attagirl.*

My cock jerks to attention as Marie establishes her demands. She's soft in her immovability, her lush curves almost resting against my front, taking strength from me.

Giulia shakes her head lightly but concedes. "You're right. You're an adult, you do what you think is best for you, exactly like I will when this blows up in your face, Marie. I won't take sides between you two." Marie nods and I can't see her face but her energy shifts to one of glee and empowerment. I can almost see her tap her feet in a little dance even though she isn't moving at all.

"*Fratellino*, Dobrev called last night," Andrea starts. "He and Ventura are on the trails of one of Misha's handlers in the country. They think they can find him and bring him to your workshop soon."

"How soon?" I ask as I take in the information that Aleksei Dobrev has been working closely with Dante Ventura, his enemy for decades. I don't necessarily care for their feud. They both hire me for side projects, and as long as no one in London or West Hill asks me to kill a rival, I take these easy contracts gladly. They scratch the itch and help me stay in touch with the underbelly of the country, collecting favours and information as effectively as Giulia does with her club.

"This week," Giulia answers for him. They always end each other's sentences. You wouldn't believe they started off as a marriage of convenience when you look at them eating each other up with their eyes. These two are the horniest people I've ever met and I know I need to end this meeting soon because with or without us present, they're about to go at it until the sun comes up.

"I'll handle it," I say.

"What does it mean?" Marie asks, turning to look at me over her shoulders. The light catches in her dark locks, giving her hair a midnight-blue hue. She knows what I do. Everyone knows. But I look into her eyes as I lay down the ugly truth of who I am.

"Dobrev and Ventura will catch the man who finds the women Misha's organisation abducts and sells into his traffic ring. They will bring him to my workshop, a barn a few hundred meters off my property. I will torture the information we need out of him, over hours or days depending on my mood and needs, and then I'll end his life."

Our eyes stay locked but there's no grimace on her precious face. "Good," she states before turning back her attention to her cousin and my brother, who both raise their brow at her. "What? Did you think that because I'm younger than you and have been kept in the dark all my life, I'd be disgusted by violence? That man deserves what's coming for him."

A large smile spreads across Giulia's red lips. "Maybe we were wrong to keep you apart all this time, Marie." She plops herself on Andrea's lap, dismissing us.

My blood pumps fast in my veins, echoing in my ears as Marie's words sink in. Her acceptance tastes like salvation on my tongue and the need to touch her, to show her how grateful I am for what she just gave me, threatens to unravel me.

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## MARIE

SUBTLE VIOLENCE IS A TURN-ON, APPARENTLY



Nico's pace is urgent as we walk back to his house. He carries the little basket Ember is sleeping in in one hand and holds mine in the other, our fingers threaded together.

For the first time in my life, someone stood up for me and empowered me, made me feel like I was a part of the family. Even more than that, he made me feel like I was part of the business. I clamp my lips shut to avoid smiling like a silly girl, but my cheeks hurt nonetheless.

When we reach the living room, Nico hands me my daughter and I place her on her bed in my bedroom. She doesn't rouse and I'm grateful she's such a heavy sleeper. I need time with Nico. Alone.

To do what, I'm unsure. Anticipation and desperate need to show him how grateful I am replaced any anxious energy I felt at dinner.

When I make my way to the living room, legs like jelly, Nico's seated on a chair, elbows resting on his thighs. The dark tee-shirt he's wearing leaves the skin of his arms on display, the black and grey tattoos painting a striking picture. The Fallen Angel on one of his forearms, what seems to be the ecstasy of Saint Theresa on the other, mixed with a demon chasing an angel and a murder of crows taking flight on the other side make up a gothic composition within which fits random smaller ones. It's stunning and mesmerising.

With measured steps, I walk to him until I stand shy of a foot away from his opened legs. I take my time devouring the sight in front of me. His dark

hair looks soft to the touch and I bite my lips, thinking of how much I want to run my fingers through his scalp until he purrs under my hands. The metal of his piercings glints in the yellow light of the side lamp. What kind of noise would he make if I pulled on the lip one with my teeth until it hurt?

Curious to know, and turned on for probably the first time in my life—or second if we consider what happened in my bed the other night—I reach forward and gently let my right hand wander from his cheek to the back of his head, gliding my nails down to his nape. Nico shivers underneath my touch. I don't know how to interpret it.

“Do you want me to stop?” I ask.

“Don't.” His voice is low, the sound going straight to my already heated core. “*Please.*” He watches me intently, his pupils so large I can barely see the amber I like so much anymore. He looks desperate. And I love it.

I continue my exploration until my hand reaches the column of his throat. The whimper that comes out of his chest threatens to make me come on the spot.

“Oh, baby,” I gently mock.

I might not have much experience but Nico wants me. I dip my eyes down to his crotch and the confirmation stares right back at me. He's hard underneath the dark jeans. Liquid need fills my veins, more potent than any alcohol I've ever tasted.

With a hard shove against his throat, I press his body against the back of the chair and straddle him, lining myself against him. A needy sigh leaves my lips and Nico parts his as though he wants to swallow it.

“I trust you to tell me when it becomes too much, do you understand?” I ask, and Nico nods enthusiastically. The sensation of my smile is foreign but he's so fucking hot when he can't speak. “I need you to say it, baby.”

“Yes, Miss Marie. I'll tell you when I need to stop. Can I touch you? *Please?*”

*Fuck.* He begs so pretty.

I never thought I'd be into it. If I'm honest with myself, I never thought I'd be into any kind of sex. I've never found anyone attractive enough to want them, and I've always preferred to numb my feelings rather than explore them. Yet, right now, all I want is to stay stone cold sober so I can experience Nico's sweet pleas over and over again.

“Yes, you can touch me, Nico.”



He doesn't need to be told twice; his hands land on my thighs, roaming over the expansive flesh until they slow and creep towards my ass. Nico squeezes my curves and groans. It's the hottest sound I've ever heard. The power it sends into my system is electric. It's a shock. A high. It's everything.

I place a hand on his shoulder while I keep the other at his throat where his heartbeat erratically thrums underneath my fingers.

"I love to feel your heart right here," I tell him, my eyes oscillating between his throat, his lips and his eyes. "It reminds me how alive you are, and how you stood up for me. My heart was also beating so fast when you let me be part of tonight's meeting. I've never felt so strong as when you stood at my back."

The words pour out of me. I wouldn't be able to remain silent if I tried. After bottling—literally—my feelings for so long, Nico shows up and all I can do is let them free. I might have known him for a short period of time but already, he's a safe haven, a guardian of my untangled thoughts and hurt little heart.

He remains silent and licks his lips. I want to be the one to do that. "Have you ever kissed anyone, Nico?"

"No. I've never wanted anyone to touch me like this."

I pause on my descent towards his lips.

"Me neither."

I keep peering into his eyes unhurriedly. He's meant to be savoured like the delicacy he is, every second to matter. When everything undoubtedly comes crashing down, I'll have this precious moment to hold onto.

Nico shifts underneath me, his face strained. "I want you to kiss me. Please, Miss Marie. I feel like I'm gonna go mad if you don't let me taste you."

Jesus, I will never be able to resist him if he keeps saying 'please' like *that*.

His words ignite an inferno inside me, spreading from where his breath skims across my lips down to my throat and my stomach to settle deep into my core.

Pressing the side of his throat slightly, I let my mouth descend on his.

And the moment we touch, my world shifts.

Nico cradles my body deeper against his, my hands wander to clasp his shirt into a desperate grip. The metal of his bottom lip warms quickly

between us as we press into each other harder. My soft mouth yields to his just as much as Nico gives himself to me.

I tilt my head and our angle changes. Instinct takes over, and I open my mouth to take my first real taste of Nico Capaldi. I sigh into his mouth as he opens for me, letting me control our rhythm with my tongue. We glide against each other, making me want him even more.

I'm barely conscious that I'm rolling my hips, searching for friction that won't ever be enough as I devour him. Nico's groans spur me on and I keep going, kissing his perfect lips like it won't ever be enough. I've never felt such a rush before. Euphoria rises under my skin, going straight to my head.

The world around us vanishes and we lose each other into our kiss.

I come up for air for a second and open my eyes. Nico's are already on me, pupils blown, his body trembling with restraint. My eyes dip to his lip and like I've wanted, I pull on it with my teeth until he bleeds.

I can only describe the sound that escapes from him as pure masculine need. Possessed, I lick his blood and he does it again, making me moan. "You like the pain?"

"Yes," he breathes. "Hurt me."

I kiss him harder, the copper taste of him hitting my tongue again in a flash. Before I can fully savour it, it's gone. My body isn't fully my own as I bite him again, until I can luxuriate in the tang of his blood. Tangling my tongue with his, we feed off each other again. Nico's hands twist into my hair and press against my back to keep me nestled against him.

The world could be on fire and I wouldn't care as long as I'd get to kiss him like this.

Urgency ebbs away but we don't part for another long moment, our dance becoming one of simple enjoyment.

It hits me then, that neither of us ever kissed anyone before. Nico is twenty-six but he also doesn't like anyone to touch him. This must be a lot for him. Hell, it was a lot for me. I fear I'm ruined for anyone else. How could anyone ever measure up to the feeling of Nico's lips on mine, his body against mine, of the ownership he gave me over his entire being? Of the power and trust he confided in me when he allowed me to not only touch him but be so intimate?

The responsibility has me breaking away from him. We're both breathing hard, and his eyes have a shine to them I've never seen. He's

breath-taking. I could look into them forever. But I don't get to keep anyone.

"Are you okay?" I ask. "Tell me how you're feeling."

"I'll never lie to you, Marie. It was a lot." He swallows, then frowns. "I think I need to walk for a bit."

My heart breaks a little, and my shoulders sag. They shouldn't. It was only a kiss, it doesn't mean anything.

I nod and move to step back but his hands clasp on my thighs above my jeans. "I've never kissed anyone before, Marie. It was... incredible. I'm not good with words but I want you to know it was everything I could have wished for. But now, I'm starting to itch and I need to... expel the energy, I guess. I'm also incredibly turned on and that usually only happens when I get physically hurt, and I don't think I want to take it further right now."

"That's okay," I tell him, putting a chirp to my tone that rings false even to my own ears. I have two miniatures left in my suitcase and they would be perfect right now to swallow the shame and rejection I feel. "What do you need from me?"

After a featherlight touch to my lips again, Nico braces his forehead against mine. "I need you to believe me when I say that I'll be back for you. I just need time to process."

"Of course." I stand on wobbly legs, running my sweaty palms against my legs. I turn around to hide the tremble in my chin and the tears rising in my eyes. "Good night, Nico."

Without waiting for an answer, I power-walk to my room and close the door behind me, crashing against it until I bury my face into my knees. How I went from the best night of my life to the most humiliating will remain one for the records. On hands and knees, I dive into my suitcase. I pull all the clothes in there. The underwear. A book I brought and never read. I unzip the inner lining but they're not here. There's nothing left hidden in there. When I hear the door, I race to the kitchen and pull all the cupboards and drawers open.

Still nothing.

Frustration tastes acrid at the back of my throat and I pull at my hair before I discard my clothes and let the covers on the bed swallow me, hoping the night will make me forget that I almost had something I wished for.

Lisa's spectre watches me from the corner of the room and my throat clogs with fresh tears. My cheeks are wet with them in minutes while I sob silently, hoping I won't wake Ember up. It's not fair for her to wake up to the sound of my tears. Even if I get to raise her, I'll lose her too. She'll resent me for all the times I wasn't enough.

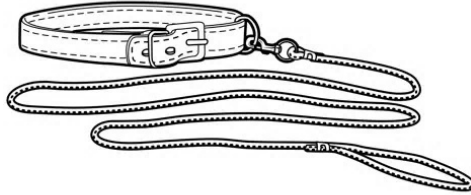
And Nico? I haven't even had him yet, but I'll lose him too. It's obvious I'm not worth his time or care.

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## NICO

CRIMSON RED PAINT



Something is wrong with Marie, but I have no clue what, or why.

She fled after what happened between us, her eyes downcast and sad, as though what we shared didn't shatter her like it did me. Her reaction surprised me, but I'm so overwhelmed I can't focus on her right now. I can't give her what she needs because I'm in no position to guess and I don't think she will tell me.

I need to take care of my needs so I can take care of hers. Painting has always been my solace and that's all I can think of. I wish I could paint *and* kill, not necessarily in that order, but Dobrev hasn't brought me my next toy yet. The blank canvas will have to do.

That kiss flipped my world. I went from not wanting anyone to touch me to being a needy mess on the brink of asking to burrow under Marie's skin. The way she took command of my body was a thrill as high as the lick of a whip on my limbs. It could rival the perfect control of holding someone's life in my hands. I'll lay it all down for her.

My phone rings in my jeans pocket as I make my way to my workshop in the dark. There's still a few hours left before sunrise, the forest pitched black. But I know the way as if I carved it myself.

I pick up without a greeting and my brother's voice echoes on the other end of the line. "I'm bringing you a treat, *fratellino*," he says with glee and a menacing tone I know is meant for his guest.

"I'm already at the workshop."

I hang up without ceremony and pull the door of the barn open. The hinges are silent, white on white greeting me when I light up the room.

I'm faster than usual, discarding my clothes and fitting them neatly into the cupboard before I put on my painter's suit. I might spend more time in it than usual today so I keep my t-shirt on underneath. It also smells like her from when she pressed herself against me, the memory of her breasts and sweet curves making me groan. The plastic on top of the soft fabric creates a new sound I'm unfamiliar with and I wince, but removing the tee isn't an option. I need it for the next part of my night. I need her close when I lay the paint on the canvas and recreate what we shared.

After a few minutes, Andrea drags an unconscious man of medium build to the centre of the room. We fasten him on the hooks to hold him upright but he doesn't rouse. "Do I need to know?" I ask my brother.

"His wife cried on Giulia's shoulder about how he beats their son when she's at work, then her when she gets home."

I grind my teeth. Another man preying on those weaker than himself. I'll show him what it's like to be prey. I nod to Andrea who leaves shortly after, unaffected by how I look, and ready to get back to his wife rather than spend his night drenched in blood. He'll indulge from time to time, but I guess tonight is not the night.

I preemptively put duct tape on my victim's mouth and turn to my canvas and my sets of black and white, creating an array of greys on my pallet to paint the moment that changed my life.

I get lost in flow, creating the perfect abstract representation of what Marie means to me, of what her kiss changed for me, of how much I want her. One canvas turns into two.

At some point, the man suspended to the ceiling of the workshop shuffles, his muffled cries irritating me. I stand up and take a mallet, swiping it across his cheek violently. The blow reverberates into my arm and sends my heart into a frenzy, blood pouring from his nose onto the concrete floor. What if I added it to my masterpiece?

Carefully, I swipe the crimson liquid from the floor with a new brush and bring it to my canvas, highlighting the top corner of the piece. It brightens the painting immediately and reminds me of when Marie bit me so hard I bled for her. I touch my lip and shudder, opening up the small wound again. My cock strains against my boxer briefs but I ignore it. I keep on painting.

And on, and on.

Until a shy sun ray floats through the small window on top of my workspace. My eyes sting from the focus, my mouth dry with lack of hydration. Movement in my periphery brings my mind back to the present moment. I admire the pieces I created and smile. They'll need to dry, then I can hide them, to be coveted in the dark when I need a reminder that this is real.

Now, I need to tend to my client, but the usual excitement is replaced with an emotion I don't have a name for. It's a sense that I'm not where I'm supposed to. I'm meant to inhale sweet lavender scent, not lemon-scented bleach and copper from blood that isn't mine.

I sigh. "It's your lucky day," I tell the man in front of me. His eyes shine with hope and I snuff it out when I take a single pill from my shelves. He whimpers in fear and that strokes the pride in me.

I keep it for very rare cases, but I don't have the will to wait for him to bleed out. I certainly don't want to touch him long enough to strangle him, even though my hands are covered with gloves. I need him to die fast so I can burn his corpse and grind his bones to dust. That already will take long enough, and the itch under my skin isn't coming from the need to kill right now. No, it's the need to touch my sweet, dominant and shy Marie. And Ember.

I miss my baby, I realise.

What a novel thing to feel.

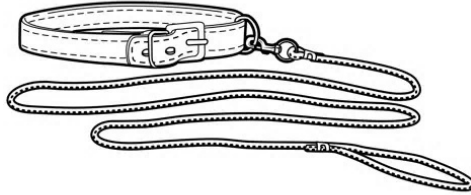
I'm smiling, a pep to my steps, as I advance on the man and shove the pill in his throat, closing his airways so he has no choice but to swallow. The cyanide works in minutes and he convulses before giving his last breath.

While his body burns, I take another canvas and paint him as well, though it's only 12 by 18 inches. He wasn't memorable enough to deserve a bigger format. The sun is fully up when the grinder works its magic and I take the quickest shower, walking back to my house naked.

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## NICO

HEART TO HEART



I enter my home and get to my bedroom, throwing a soft grey sweatpants and tee-shirt on before making my way into the living-room to find Marie. It's 9 am, later than I wanted. She's on the couch, playing with Ember.

I simply stare. They're so perfect, in my home, on my couch. But when Marie finally looks up to me, her eyes are unfocused and the grey underneath is back, creating a deep shadow on her youthful cheeks. The light smile I'm growing addicted to is absent.

"Where were you?" she asks, her voice so raw I hear my heart breaking into tiny pieces inside my chest.

I'm not used to considering another person when I take care of my needs to regulate after an overstimulating experience. It's always been just my brother and my mum for the past ten years and they know how I operate. I've never had to explain myself. Marie's hunched shoulders and sad demeanour tells me I fucked up by leaving last night. I was overwhelmed but so was she.

I approach her, kneeling at her feet, fingers grazing her calf while I support my weight with the other. She doesn't flinch away from my touch. Hope blooms inside me.

I can salvage this. I can explain.

"I went out to paint." She frowns but averts her gaze again. "And I killed a man," I add because I want her to know exactly who I am. There



will be no unsaid words or secrets between us. She's been kept in the dark long enough. I won't be the one to put her back there again.

She lifts her eyes to mine then stands to place Ember in her crib next to us. I don't move until she sits back down again and gives me her full attention. I don't read any disgust on her face, her green eyes shine with curiosity, the dark locks of her luscious hair falling on each side of her in beautiful curtains. Compelled, I lift a hand and glide my fingers through a soft strand.

"Who was it?" is her first question and my lips tip up. Marie Moretti is much more bloodthirsty than her sisters and cousin suspect and I love that I'm the one to know that about her before anyone else.

"Someone who beat his kid and wife, but not the man Andrea is tracking."

She nods once then straightens up, the image of regal beauty. "You should have told me, Nico."

"I know, I—" She raises a hand to cut me off and I obey. "I haven't given you permission to speak, have I?" I shake my head and she continues, oblivious that my cock is hardening under the soft fabric of my pants, oblivious to my growing need for her. "This was my first kiss, Nico and you left. Do you know how that made me feel?" Despite the assurance her position portrays, her voice breaks and the truth of her words register in my brain, confirming what I already knew. I refused her aftercare and that's against my principles and what I thought I knew about myself.

"I thought you rejected me. I thought you hated that I touched you like this and needed to clean yourself of me. I thought you wanted nothing to do with me, like the rest of *them*."

Ignoring her previous order to stay put, I lift myself off the ground and invade her space, as I sit close to her.

"Permission to speak?" I ask and she nods. "I told you I would be back, Marie. And I don't lie. I felt overwhelmed and I needed to find my outlet. I've never let anyone touch me like this."

I take her hands in mine, creating small circles against her skin with my thumb. Her fingers are frozen and I encircle them with both my hands.

"I have very specific needs, Marie. I thought I could never desire anything if it didn't come from pain, until you touched me, until your kiss. When I feel overwhelmed, that energy needs to go somewhere, and I was

lucky Andrea brought someone for me to pour all of that into. Do you understand?"

"Yes. Can you bring me with you, next time? I can let Ember with Giulia and Andrea. I trust them with her."

I've never shared that part of me with anyone, not even Andrea. The killing, yes. But not the rest. "Of course," I answer gently. Whatever she wants, she'll have.

She shifts then looks down, and I wait for her next words.

"I really wanted to drink," she says and her cheeks flush. "I wanted to numb the pain but you don't have alcohol here. I looked everywhere. So I stayed awake as long as I could, hoping you'd be back and take the pain away. I felt out of control." A sob cracks inside her throat and on instinct, I pull her into me, hugging her soft curves to my body.

Just like last night, the heat of her soothes something inside me. It's euphoric and calming all at once. A dual sensation I can't make sense of, but maybe I don't need to.

"You need to feel you're in control, Marie?" I ask against her head.

"Yes. Everything else is so fucked. But with you, it feels safe."

"Have you heard about dominant and submissive relationships?"

She squeaks and my lips tip up, then she nods against my chest. "I've been reading about it. Since you... you let me, uhm, give you orders and I liked it. I read about scenes and aftercare and safe words, but this is all..."

"A lot?"

"Yes, but it's also exciting. But only because it's with you."

My heart beats inside my chest at the prospect of showing her exactly what she can do to me, how I'll lay my submission at her feet. When she looks up at me, her green eyes have darkened to the most beautiful forest green and I want to drown in them.

It's time to introduce Marie to what my full obedience looks like.

"I want to show you something," I tell her. I observe the micro expressions on her face, hunting for any signs of discomfort or, I hope, curiosity.

"Is it your workshop?"

Blood rushes south at the perspective of sharing all the ways I stave off my need for pain, not just on my own body but on others. "Are you thirsty for violence, Marie?" I taunt.

She shrugs, but her body betrays how excited she is about discovering something new, her pert nipples poking through the silk of her black blouse. I don't know if it's about me or her. How her family has never picked up on her soft violence is a mystery to me. But I'll be more than happy to show her all the ways she can extract pain.

"We can visit my workshop later. It's another place. One I haven't shared with anyone, not even with Andrea."

Her head tilts to the side, waiting for me to explain further. "I own a club. And you're right, I do enjoy it when you give me commands. I want to show you the safe space I created for people with the same proclivities."

"You own a sex club?"

"I do. Are you curious?"

She hesitates. "Yes. But I... I'm..." She blushes and I don't understand what she's trying to say so I ask.

"What is it, Marie?"

"I... I'm a virgin. Our kiss is as far as I ever... I don't know the first thing about BDSM except for all the books I've read in the past three weeks, or whatever people do at your club." She sighs and her ears turn the cutest shade of bright pink where she tucks a strand behind her ear.

As always when she's uncomfortable or feels unworthy, she tucks her shoulders in. That won't fucking do.

"That's what scenes and safe words are for, Marie. We can establish what you want to do before we start. And I'm a virgin, too, *luna mia*."

Her head snaps up and she grimaces. "What? But, you own a sex club, Nico."

"Yes, I do. And I like to be dominated and I like pain, which I get there. I'm a virgin but I'm not inexperienced. I've never touched anyone and no one ever touched me. Sex isn't limited to penetration."

"I guess I never thought about it that way. But I'm still inexperienced and I don't want to do something I shouldn't."

"That's what safe words are for. Are you curious?" I ask, hope blooming at how much she squirms on her seat. If I read her body language correctly, she's more than curious but I don't want to get excited too fast. Having her deliver the kind of agony I need is the sweetest promise.

She nods and I continue to lay out my plan. Open communication is how I establish trust and I can't have her wondering again if I care for her, or thinking that she isn't my priority and my centre. "I have a business

partner. His name is Damian. He often delivers the pain I like and if you're interested, he could show you. *I could show you.*"

I place my hand on her thighs and squeeze her soft flesh. She draws in a sharp breath that I want to swallow. "I want you to deliver the pain I crave, Miss Marie. Would you let me show you how?"

"Yes, baby."

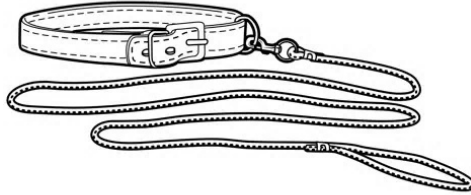
Fuck. The little nickname inside her mouth has my insides in knots. In a good way. I kiss her lips softly and stand. "I'll make arrangements for tomorrow. Call Giulia and Andrea. They need to babysit Ember so I can show you control."

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## NICO

LESSONS IN DOMINANCE



The next day, after dropping Ember at an ecstatic Giulia and a sceptical Andrea, I take Marie's hand in mine and guide her to where I parked my bike. I don't want to take the car to drive to my club. The roaring motor underneath us as she clasps my body to hers to hang on for dear life is a much better option. I hand her an extra helmet and help her fasten it around her neck. The black jeans and cashmere sweater underneath the leather jacket she wears fits her like a fucking glove, showing her luscious body that I want to sink my teeth into. If she'll allow me.

It doesn't escape my notice that I'm dressed in a similar fashion and that strokes a primal part of myself I didn't even know existed. If only she could wear my shirt after tonight, then the fantasy would be complete.

I help her up on the back of the bike and drive into the night at full speed, drawing a cute little yelp from her that brings a smirk to my face. Maybe it's the brat in me, already teasing her for punishment.

When we arrive in front of Absolution, the bouncer nods to me in greeting, his face impassible. His eyes dip to where Marie and I are holding hands but he doesn't comment.

The air inside is warm and smells of that luxurious laundry scent I asked Damian to diffuse at all times to dull the smell of cum and sex. The combo is heady and I look over my shoulder to take in a tense Marie, walking behind me, taking in all the hard shapes of the place and the display of bodies already thrumming in front of us.

Some people are fully naked, some fully clothed and all the in-between. Scenes are happening all around us, with different intensity levels but Marie's gaze stops on a woman who's standing by the bar, dressed in a short glittery red dress, her pet on a leash at her feet, licking her black boots dutifully like a kitten.

I slide behind her, murmuring in her ear. "I've been down before. The emptiness in my head made me feel like I could stay there for hours. I didn't have a collar though."

"I... I like the collar. I don't know about shoe licking though. Looks unsanitary."

I scoff. Surprisingly, for someone who doesn't like other people's fluids on me, boot-licking isn't an act I view as unsanitary. Maybe because I know the rules of our club by heart and these shoes are cleaned and polished before being worn, and only here. There's no need to tell Marie that so we abandon the patrons to their trysts as I guide her down a corridor illuminated in red.

We enter a soundproof room. I chose it because it doesn't have a bed. It's set up like our office, with dark blue walls with delicate upholstery, a comfortable and large brown sofa on a dark green carpet, and a mahogany desk to the side. There are no windows or two way mirrors, giving us absolute privacy. But there is an array of toys, and tools and a trusted Saint Andrews cross and spanking bench in the corner. Everything is understated and made to be soothing to the senses. Even the music is a soft jazz melody that's barely audible and won't be distracting as we proceed with this evening's entertainment.

I tap my leg three times with my right index finger as I wait for Marie to say something before I introduce her to Damian, who's waiting for my text in our office. Only years of discipline prevent me from shifting from foot to foot as I impatiently wait for her to make a move.

She turns slowly to take in her surroundings, walking on smooth feet to the cross and bench, caressing the leather reverently before going to the toy display. She picks up a metal tool shaped like a hook with a ball at one end, and frowns. My smile threatens to turn into a full one laughter, but I don't want her to think I'm mocking her. "It's an anal hook," I supply and she drops it like it burnt her.

"Oh. I don't think I'd like to use that."

“Good. I don’t think I’d want you to use it on me for my first experience, Miss Marie.”

Her honorific has the desired effect, her eyes turning dark and that pillowy bottom lip crushed between her teeth.

“I like it when you call me that,” she says shyly, biting her lip.

“Did you notice it’s a title I use when I want you to dominate me?”

She nods and smiles, pink on her pretty cheeks, looking relaxed and ready for tonight’s entertainment.

She takes a full breath in and I walk to her, standing in front of her without touching her. My hands itch but I remain focused on the next part. “You can always back out, Marie. I would never force you to do something you don’t want to do. We can also start and at any point, you can stop. That’s what safe-words are for. They’re not only for the submissive one, but for the dominant, too.”

“Okay.” She exhales heavily. “That’s making me feel better. What should I use as a safe-word?”

“A word that’s easy for you to remember. Mine is ‘fire’,” I tell her and she doesn’t question it, which I’m grateful for. “I also use a colour system. I say ‘green’ to indicate if I’m ready to continue, ‘orange’ if I want you to slow down or pause and ‘red’ to end the scene immediately.”

“That’s a good system. My safe-word will be ‘purple’.” Her face betrays a hint of pain but her head is held high, making me wonder why she chose this word in particular, but I don’t question her.

She surprises me when she says, “We should talk about limits.”

I hum. “You can touch me, and I’d like to touch you but I don’t want to be penetrated today.” She coughs-chokes, reminding me that not everyone is as brutally straightforward as I can be. But she invites me to continue. “It’s not a hard limit for another time, though. If you’d like that. But not here. I want you in my bed the first time I take you, or you take me.”

Her soft hands glide up my chest and she pulls me in for a kiss. Our lips seal and our breaths catch. It’s as powerful as the first time and I chase her when she starts to pull away.

“Be good,” she teases with her fingers on my lips. I can’t resist taking them into my mouth, playing with her skin and using my piercing as a reminder that it’s here. And could be anywhere she’d like tonight.

I send a text to Damian, who knocks on the door a few minutes later. Marie jumps to her feet and I let him in, introducing them briefly. Damian

looks at me quizzically. In the five years I've known him, I've never introduced anyone myself, always choosing partners through our vetted members. Last time he wasn't supervising ended so badly I haven't asked anyone else but him to paint my body in red marks.

"The rules are the same as usual, but Marie is allowed to touch me," I tell him and his brow flies up. It would almost be funny if the air wasn't heavy with the promise of pain and sex.

His eyes oscillate between Marie and I but he simply nods.

"Nico, you'll address me as *Sir*, as per usual. Marie, I'd like you to use that, too. What honorific does Nico use for you?"

The question is meant to establish the boundaries and dynamics of our scene but she blushes all the same, a satisfied smile gracing her perfect lips. "Miss Marie," she answers with a tinge of pride.

Damian takes us through the simple teaching sequence that will be focused on bringing me pain and pleasure, while helping Marie learn to lean into her soft dominance.

"Are you ready?" Damian asks Marie.

"Yes, Sir."

"Perfect. Then, let's begin. Pet, take off your clothes and wait for us on your knees by the bench," Damian orders, his voice taking on a low quality. It usually sends a shiver down my spine but today, my attention isn't on him, his focus barely eliciting a sense of recognition.

"Don't make him repeat himself, baby," Marie says and the dark tone of her voice has me scrambling to obey. It's like a possessive touch on my skin and I revel in it, taking my clothes off and folding them on the couch, then and dropping to my knees on the dark wood floor, naked and exposed to her eyes.



## MARIE

POWER AND CONTROL



I can't remove my eyes from the sight in front of me. Nico kneels by the dark leather bench, his head bent forward in submission, completely naked. I've never found him more attractive. I take my time letting my eyes roam over his body, full of tattoos of angels and demons, numbers on his legs, fire-heart on his chest. The bullet wound is unmistakable on his shoulder and I clench my fists so I don't reach for him yet. He's dangerous but so is the life he leads.

I envision myself licking the metal on his lips and going down and down. When I feel ready and steady, I look where I'm most curious and, like I suspected, his cock is pierced with a shiny loop of silver metal at the head. The more we wait in silence, the harder he grows, revealing three rows of barbells on the underside of his shaft, and I almost moan at the sight.

Feeling desire is something I'm not used to. The power I take from watching him in silence goes to my head in the most delicious high and I picture myself licking the metal there, too, as he struggles against the cross, leaking pre-cum and pathetically whimpering, begging for relief.

"He looks delightful when he submits, doesn't he?" Damian asks and I nod eagerly. I almost forgot we had someone there with us. Conflicting emotions roll through me. One part of me is grateful someone can show me the ropes so I can give Nico everything he desires. The other is green with jealousy that this man has already done that for him, seen him like this,

gotten his sweet surrender. Violence thrums in my veins but I rein it in, listening to the rational part of me. The primal one can wait until I get my footing.

“Sweet Nico here might be the most dangerous predator in the city, but he’s a sweet pet for us, aren’t you, Nico?”

“Yes, Sir.” Nico’s voice is rough and needy, spurring me into action. In three steps, I’m right in front of him, taking his chin and lifting his gaze to mine. “And you’ll be a good boy for us so we can give you what you want, won’t you, baby?”

The words tumble out of me, as easy as breathing. Better even because in this room, there’s no pretending, there are no demons. It’s just us and desire firing up our veins.

“Yes, Miss Marie,” he answers with no hesitation, eyes shining with something akin to adoration. It goes straight to my core and excitement bubbles inside me.

I turn to Damian, waiting for directions on what to do next. The man smiles gently at me, obviously enjoying his teacher position. “Settle on the bench for us, pet. Show us that pretty ass so we can turn it the perfect shade of red.”

Nico obeys while we wait, then Damian takes a leather object with a flat end that looks like it’s made for training with horses, not humans. He must read the question on my face because he talks without prompting.

“This is a riding crop, one of Nico’s favourite tools to start a session with. I enjoy it a lot as well and I suspect you will too, Miss Marie.” He hands it to me and I caress the black leather reverently. The surface is smooth and warm, the craftsmanship a signal of excellence. I’m not surprised Nico would choose such a tool. It speaks of his attention to detail and taste for luxurious and understated objects, just like in his house. Even though it’s the first time I’ve touched one, the object is familiar in my hand, it’s weight like an extension of my arm. I slap it on my fingers once and Nico shivers at the sound, goosebumps erupting on his backside and legs. I smile and bite my lip, looking to Damian for reassurance. “The honour is all yours, Miss Marie,” he says and I don’t hesitate before positioning myself on Nico’s side, where I can look at his face and still access his body.

The crop descends on Nico’s ass cheek in a beautiful arc that barely makes a sound. He exhales like that’s all he needs and I do it again, watching his body deflate and any lingering tension leave his limbs. It’s a

sight to behold and I don't stop, switching between cheeks and thighs until he starts to let out low moans.

"You can go harder, Miss Marie. Nico loves the pain, after all," Damian offers and I try again. Nico's exhales turn into pants and hisses, giving fuel to my desire.

A slight sheen of sweat coats my forehead and I'm growing wet under my jeans, searching for friction by squeezing my thighs together.

Observant and kind, Damian offers me to remove my clothes. "You can always pause the scene to take care of your own needs, Miss Marie. Have Nico wait and watch. He'll enjoy it, I think."

"I will, but not yet. And not with you present, Sir. This is only for his eyes."

Damian makes a sound of approval at the back of his throat and Nico lets out a pathetic "Oh fuck, please" that makes me giggle. I'm on top of the world, nothing can beat this feeling.

Damian shows me different types of paddles, floggers and whips, detailing which have Nico's preferences. As much as I want to dominate him, I want him to enjoy it and I keep getting attracted to the leather ones.

I pick up one with a lot of tails and proceed to spank Nico with it. His chants of *yes* and *more* and *fuck* fill the room and my brain, leaving space for nothing else. His ass is turning a dark pink and when I touch it, the warmth under my palm sets me on fire.

"Oh fuck yes, please, Miss Marie. Touch me," Nico begs.

"Look at you, baby. Begging so sweetly for me."

I don't know where any of what I say is coming from, only that I need to praise him for taking all the pain so well for me. I knew he could but I didn't expect to feel so proud of him. I kneed his ass cheeks and the back of his thighs, his head falling forward with a groan. "You did so good, baby. Barely moving while you took everything I gave you."

"I want more," he says with a strain and Damian clicks his tongue. "Don't be fucking greedy. You take what we give you or you don't get anything at all."

"Yes, Sir. Yes, Miss Marie."

"Get up," Damian orders and Nico obeys, wincing slightly. It makes me want to hurt him more.

"I'd like to see him on the cross," I say, barely containing the glee and anticipation.

“Go on, pet. You heard your girl.”

Nico steps onto the small platform on which the cross is laid out and opens his arms and legs to fit against the boards. I watch, panting, as Damian fastens him to it. He looks so perfect like this, bound and at my mercy. My nipples are tight peaks against the fabric of my bra, heavy with need. Nico’s eyes are solely focused on me and I preen under his attention.

I take hold of the riding crop I previously used and swipe it across his legs and pierced nipples in quick succession. His cock is hard and leaking. I approach him, like I’m under a spell.

“This is usually when I’d let one of his arms out of their bindings so he can touch himself. Or see if I can make him come just from the pain. But I guess since you can touch him, you might have other ideas.” Damian’s tone is salacious and I swipe my thumb on the head of Nico’s cock collecting pre-cum before sliding the digit into my mouth.

Nico’s usual whiskey eyes have turned dark with lust, his lips parted and fixed on where my thumb glides inside my mouth.

“I’ll take my leave now. You’re a natural, Miss Marie. Trust your instincts, check in regularly and use your safe word if you need a break or a renegotiation.”

“Thank you, Sir.”

I barely hear Damian leave but when he does, the air changes between Nico and I, charged with possibilities, dark desire and hunger. I want him so badly, I could drink him down. I’m not interested in his pain right now, I want his pleasure, his cries, his moans, his sweet begging in my ears. I discard the crop and bring both hands to his body, gliding my fingers on his chest first, my fingers softly skidding across the raised skin of his scar.

Tentatively, I press a kiss on top of it. His nipples are pierced and I pull on them, pain and softness already entwined like I could train him to crave both if it’s at my hands. Nico’s brows tighten together and he groans. I replace my lips with my tongue, tasting the sweat on his skin.

I will never need another drink for as long as I can lick the salt of his skin.

“Colour?” I simply ask.

“Green.”

I let my hands descend on his body until I reach his cock and take it into my hand, caressing his sack with the other one. I have no clue what I’m doing but Nico’s right here with me. “Spit on it,” he begs.

I spit into my hand and return it to his cock, his length gliding perfectly into my tight fist.

“Fuck, this feels so good, Miss Marie. Please don’t stop.”

Incapable of helping myself, I bring my lips to his, kissing all his moans, and claiming them for myself. He tastes like desperation and if I weren’t so drunk on him already, I’d fantasise about bottling him up so I can indulge in it every night before bed. I want to own him fully so I drop to my knees in front of him, keeping my eyes locked with his. I’m still fully clothed while he’s naked and magnificent in front of me, ready to be used. I can’t rush this.

“Give me a colour, baby,” I ask softly. It’s one thing to kiss him, to hug him; and completely another to touch him so intimately when we’re both high on each other and the emotions running the show. I want to be so good for him.

“Orange. I don’t know how I’m gonna feel about this,” he admits and I pepper his thighs with soft kisses, eliciting a path of goosebumps straight to his pierced dick.

“I’ll go slow. Keep communicating with me, okay?”

He nods and I purse my lips. “Yes, Miss Marie.”

Slowly, as though he’d run away any minute, I bring my hands back up from his thighs to encircle his length and take a tentative swipe of my tongue along his slit.

“*Oh, shit—*,” Nico swears, spurring me on.

I lick the pre-cum straight from the source again. It’s thicker than I thought it would be now that I’m getting more than when it was on my thumb. It’s also salty and something undoubtedly *him*. It makes my head spin, but not as much as his pleas do.

I let my instincts guide me as I lick a long line on the pierced underside of his cock, enjoying the split between warm flesh and cold metal. Using my hands, I continue my thrusting motion as I take my time to explore him with my tongue and mouth.

Before long, I slide his cock in between my spread lips. Only the tip. In and out until Nico squirms, almost screaming “green” at me, begging me to suck him deeper. I chuckle and indulge him, because he sounds so desperate and I’m curious how much more he can take, and how much more of him can fit into me. I go an inch deeper, then another until he hits the back of

my throat and I gag, getting off him to cough. *Not too deep, good to know.* I'll have to use my hands to reach where my mouth can't.

From the sounds Nico is making, he doesn't care so I don't either. I guide him in and out of my mouth at the same time I play with his piercings with my hands, never going too deep.

I let my eyes roam over his face and body. His clenched fists are turning white but he keeps his gaze to me. He's so beautiful on the brink of climax, so soft and different from the hardness he portrays to the outside world. And that vision is only for me.

In here with him, on my knees for his pleasure and mine, there is no place for grief or pain or anyone but the two of us. I'm the woman who gets to touch him, give him orders and make him come, and he's nothing but the sweet man who only has to give it all to me. For the first time in years, I'm at peace. Ironical that it's with a cock in my mouth, while on my knees ready to ask this man to come for me. Lisa would have been proud.

There's no place for her here as I refocus on Nico, who's an absolute begging mess.

Since it's our first time, I don't really want him to come inside my mouth. The unknown of how he would taste or how he would feel since we haven't discussed consent before is too much so I stand and undo the bindings.

Nico sags and I bring us both to our knees.

"Be a good boy for me and show me how you touch yourself, baby. You have my permission."

His hand squeezes his shaft before it moves up and down, adding a gentle twisting flick of the wrist on the downward motion. I watch, riveted, learning the reactions of his body. His abs clench slightly before he spills all over his hands and abdomen, throwing his head back on a low moan.

With his throat exposed, I lick the sweat off the column of his neck before we merge again in a deep kiss that steals the breath right out of my lungs. Our tongues tangle and he lets me choose our rhythm, submitting to me even then. The stomach flutters with butterflies.

"Don't move," I order as I get up. I remember he doesn't like the feel of his cum getting cold on his skin so I grab tissues and clean him up, hoping this is enough for him, for now.

"I want to do the same to you," Nico breathes against my lips when I bend down for another kiss.

“Nico, you don’t have to.”

“Please. *Please* let me eat you out, Marie. I feel like I could die if I don’t.”

I let the fact that he didn’t call me *Miss Marie* slide and stand, keeping him where he is. Then I discard my clothes and drape my body across the sofa, removing my ruined panties and letting them drop at my feet. Nico’s eyes are feral as they fall on the discarded fabric. I’ve never been so exposed, nor so powerful as when I open my legs and Nico *whines*.

“Crawl to me, baby, and make me feel good.”

Dutifully, Nico gets on all fours and crawls to me. His body is a masterpiece of shifting tattoos and glinting metal, a predator who allows me to own him. There’s no doubt in my head on who truly holds the power here, but the gift of his submission, making me feel like *I’m* the one in control, allowing *me* to direct and decide is the sweetest gift someone has ever given me. The feeling in my stomach is back and now my chest joins the party, as though it expands to make a space just for him.

I straighten and take his chin in my hand again. “Whenever you need to pause or stop, use your words, baby. Understood?”

“Yes, Miss Marie. Now *please*, let me make you feel just a fraction of what you did for me.”

I recline against the back of the sofa and Nico doesn’t waste a single second, taking hold of my spread thighs and diving straight for my pussy. He takes slow licks at my entrance, tasting me, and I buck against his mouth.

Sharp intakes of breath are all I can manage as he moves over to my clit and sucks. Stars explode at the edges of my vision, my back bowing off the sofa. I’m not in control anymore as Nico does it again. I throw my head back and moan loud, my hands flying to grasp the strands of his dark hair to keep him exactly where he is. “Do it again!”

Nico groans and obeys. Tension coils at the base of my spine. He dips down until his tongue enters me. The sensation is foreign but so fucking good and he does it again, finding a rhythm between sucking my clit in between his pursed lips and entering me softly with his tongue. The harsh and soft dual sensations send me towards my peak. His hands caress every inch of me, grabbing at my soft stomach and ample breasts, his touch urgent yet reverent.

I come with his name on my lips, my body shaking with the strength of the euphoria spreading into the rest of my body in waves. It goes on for a while, pin needles on my scalp and panting breaths in my lungs.

Then, it recedes and I'm left exhausted. I look down to where Nico waits patiently for me, hands resting on his knees, the same droopy smile I'm sure I'm giving him as well.

"That was incredible. Thank you."

I'm unsure how to end the scene or what to do, unease creeping into me but Nico picks up my panty from the side of the sofa and helps me get it back on. I wince at the wetness of them but I don't have another set here. Nico hands me the rest of my clothes next, taking back over. His measured actions help me release the anxiety of not knowing what to do.

He stands and gets his own clothing on, the black jeans and tee fitting him perfectly. He looks like a dark prince of the night and if I didn't experience the best orgasm of my life thanks to his submission, I wouldn't believe that he is real.

He goes to a small fridge I hadn't noticed and retrieves two bottles of water, giving me one and signalling to drink it with a tilt of his chin.

My mind is still high with oxytocin, my brain frazzled and not ready to get back to reality so I remain silent. But I'm curious. I want to know more about how it was for him. Is it always like this? Did he enjoy himself? Before I can overthink, Nico speaks.

"Thank *you*, Marie. I've never felt anything like this before. I think my soul left my body at some point."

"I think mine did, too," I tell him truthfully. "What happens now?"

"Now, we decide what we do for aftercare. We should have talked about this before but I was so eager I kind of forgot," he says sheepishly and I find myself falling harder for him. Because I can be honest with myself. I'm falling for Nico Capaldi. And not just because of the sex. "I usually don't require a lot of aftercare but Damian likes to put ointment on my skin after a harsh session." I crinkle my nose at the mention of his business partner.

"You let him touch you?" I ask, sounding insecure. I don't know why the knowledge that someone else can touch him when he keeps saying that I'm the only one makes me irrationally sad and mad all at once. He's a grown man and he doesn't owe me anything.

"Only during aftercare," Nico says matter-of-factly. "And it's more for *his* aftercare than mine. I allow it because it's important for the dominant



party to also tend to their needs. Damian's caretaker personality requires that he makes sure I'm not gonna be in pain the next day and to show me that he isn't a violent person."

"Oh, okay. That makes sense. What do you require?"

"Mostly, to be left alone to process. But with you, I want to know everything that went through your mind. And that's new. That will be an adjustment. What do you want?"

I ponder the question, looking around me. Now that the high is slowing, the room almost seems sterile and lifeless. The sofa underneath me creaks and I don't like the sound, the jazzy music irritates my ears and I don't like the colours of the rug under my feet. I also miss my daughter.

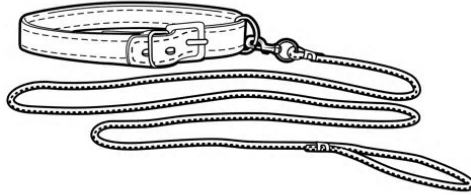
"I want to go home and maybe watch a movie? After, we talk?" I ask with a hint of insecurity. Nico takes my hand in his and kisses the back of it. "Then, let's go, *luna mia*."

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NICO

AFTERCARE



As we ride back to my house in the middle of the forest, my head has quieted down to an unusual level. The only element still present there are the vivid memories of Marie's taste on my tongue. I've never even considered going down on someone before but when she opened herself up for me and told me to lick her leaking pussy, it was like a trance. I couldn't control my body or my body's response if I wanted to. I had to do what she told me, be her good boy, bring her pleasure, just as much as she gave me. That's the least I can do for her.

Already, I'm planning a repeat.

I understand how she could become addicted to alcohol if it gave her even a fraction of what her sweet commands do to me. It's addictive. *She* is addictive. I don't care to put a label on what I feel as long as I get to experience it over and over until the day I die.

I park my bike in front of the house and help her off. My fingers tap a staccato of rhythm on my legs as we approach the front door. Marie regards me curiously and decides to be brave, asking what's on her mind. Watching her bloom is such a privilege. "You do that a lot."

"What?"

"Tapping your fingers. Always in a set of three. And always when you have something on your mind. Do you want to tell me?"

"I thought you wanted to watch a movie first, then talk." She shrugs, but it's a small disruption in the plan. It's all part of the after care she asks for

and as long as we get to do all the steps she laid out, I think I'll be okay. Even if it's not in the order she expressed at first. It makes me uneasy, but her eyes are still set on me, waiting for my answer.

"It calms me down. Ever since I was a kid, there were always three people I cared about: my father, my mother and Andrea. Then, my father died because of me and I was down one person but the number stayed. It's like an anchor."

She nods to herself in my periphery. Now that I've started, it seems the words have decided to come out, with or without my permission. "I also like it when we're in a scene."

"I know. I tried to keep count of three tonight."

"I noticed. Thank you."

She dips her head down, her hair falling like a curtain around her. I tuck it back behind her ear so I can fully watch the expressions going through her face. "If I don't see your face, I'm not sure what you feel. And it's important for me to know. I've learned non-verbal clues but I can read faces better."

"Oh. Of course. I'm sorry. I guess I'm used to hiding," she says as she sits on the sofa and I take my place next to her. Her hands wrangle together on her lap before she passes her palms on her jeans a few times. I guess she does need the comfort of the gesture before she continues. I wait with bated breaths. "When I was young, like twelve or so, I hid a lot in my house so I could listen in on what the adults were talking about. I never got caught eavesdropping and it felt good at first, like I was good at something. Then, I realised it's because I'm invisible. When I started drinking, at sixteen or seventeen, I started hiding in plain sight. It's easy. My family drinks a lot of wine at parties and dinners. After a while, the less they saw, the more I drank and the more I drank, the bitter I became. And now I can't stop. Because it helps with the pain, you know."

"You haven't drunk in a while though," I say. She's been with me for three weeks but except for a few glasses of wine at dinner with my family, and the occasional low alcohol beers I keep in the fridge so she doesn't feel the negative effects of going cold-turkey without medical supervision, I haven't seen her sneak alcohol into the house or drink, and I've been watching her constantly.

"I actually had miniatures in my suitcases and I drank them all by now. The past few nights have been restless. I'm on edge and I really, *really* want

it.” Her voice cracks at the admission. “But I’m alone here with Ember so I can’t indulge. As much as I trust you, it’s the first time I realised how much she needs me. And she needs me sober. But it’s constantly on my mind. Except tonight.” Once again, she dips her chin down with what I believe is shame. “And I know you lost someone, too. You lost your father, yet you didn’t turn out like I did,” she croaks.

“Marie, look at me.” Her eyes meet mine, full of fat tears and red with pain. “I have this urge to kill people because every time I do, I imagine it’s the man who made me an accomplice to my father’s murder, and I make him pay over and over again. I did not become an alcoholic, no. But I’m the bigger monster.”

“Is this why you need to hurt, Nico? Do you think you deserve it?” she asks, her face softening.

“I do. If it weren’t for me, my father would be alive. I’m the one who let the man I thought was a friend into our house that night. My parents were away. I don’t know what he did but he left with a condescending slap on my cheek. And that night, a fire started in the house and no alarm went off. My father died from inhaling too much smoke and my mother ended up in a wheelchair because a roof beam fell over her. Andrea had already left the nest and was in his apartment in London, so he wasn’t there, thankfully. But I walked out without a scratch, Marie. I deserve to atone for this for the rest of my life.”

“When was this?”

“Ten years ago.”

“You were sixteen,” she exclaims as she shifts on her knees and frames my face with her soft hands. There’s nothing she can say that will make me change my perspective. I’ve seen therapists. I’ve worked on my guilt and my grief. And I transformed it.

“It was my fault. And every time I have to clench my teeth in pain, I’m reminded of it and I feel like I’m paying my dues. I learnt to take pleasure from it, too, and I have no interest in changing, Marie. Don’t ask me not to love the pain.”

She shakes her head gently. “That’s not what I’m saying. If you love to be whipped, that’s one thing. I’d love for you to not associate it with your father’s death, one day. That’s all.”

She drops her hands and laces them with mine in between us. Silence hangs, but it’s not heavy. I’m not sure what to say so I don’t talk. All I know

is that she's not fully understanding me, but at least she doesn't want me to change and that's enough for me.

I'm eager to cuddle with her, Ember close by. When I started considering Ember like mine and started needing her as much as I need Marie, I'm unsure. But I convince Marie to pick her up from Andrea and Giulia's even though it's the middle of the night.

When we get there, Luca DeRossi is leaving and Giulia introduces him to Marie. My brother's lawyer doesn't keep business hours so it's not a shock to see him there, though I'd think he'd rather be wrapped in his new wife.

Marie and I don't linger once Ember is wrapped around her front. As we walk the way back, it almost feels real when visions of other kids running around us assault me. Marie round with child, claimed by me, at my side. The idea has my cock rising uncomfortably in my jeans but I can't stave off the sudden and new need to breed her. If she'll even allow it. I hope she does. I could groan out loud imagining it but I focus on opening the front door instead.

When we get back to the house with our daughter, we settle together and Ember falls back asleep in Marie's arms. She links our fingers together and watches the TV screen I've never used before, a film called *Moulin Rouge* playing in front of our eyes. It's a lot of singing and I don't care much for it so I watch *them* instead.

I like having Marie here. And I like that living with a baby is so regulated with rules and a time for everything. Ember is fed a bottle every three or four hours no matter the time of day or night. Which means she wakes up crying during the night too, but after I understood what she needed that first time, it hasn't bothered me. I haven't worked up the courage to feed her myself so I let Marie get up instead, and always follow, hovering behind them. It always creates a pang in my chest. Marie also always tries to bathe Ember at the same time, 5 pm, every day, creating another routine element that I can latch onto. Then, there's the morning nap and the afternoon nap.

"Can you pause the movie?" Marie whispers, as though she doesn't want to wake up the bundle in her arms.

I straighten and click pause on the remote. "What is it?"

"I really need to pee," Marie giggles and the sound goes straight to my heart. *Am I having a heart attack?* I'm too young and healthy for it.

“Okay,” I answer, unsure what that means for me.

Marie’s shoulders shake with restrained laughter. “Nico, take Ember.”

I’ve held her before. So many times in fact but every time, her fragility hits me in the chest. I take Ember in my arms and raise the bottle to her little mouth. I don’t know why I was so anxious about this because it’s so easy now. She’s a greedy babe, I noticed and clasps the sides of the bottle with her tiny hands. In the past month, she’s become so much more expressive and her eyes crinkle at the corners.

“She likes you,” Marie says from behind me when she returns, and it’s my turn to smile.

“Who wouldn’t?”

Marie’s mouth drops open and I know I did the teasing right.

“Nico Capaldi, are you mocking me?”

My cheeks hurt and warm when I answer. “Only if you like it.”

Marie plops back on the couch next to me and rests her head on my shoulder. “I like *you*,” she says, and it sends my heart into overdrive.

Before I can get distracted by her lush lips and sinful body that I now know every dimple and curve of, I delve into the conversation we need to have.

“How do you feel after tonight?”

She sighs heavily as she sits next to me, caressing Ember’s head.

“I’ve read a lot of material about this type of relationship over the past month. And all the blogs, whether they were written by submissive or dominant people, they all describe that deep space within yourself where nothing exists. Like you transcend the physical plain or something.” She looks up and meets my eyes, smiling bashfully for the first time since I met her. I lift a hand to touch her cheek and she leans into me like a cat. “That’s what I felt. And it could be really addictive.”

“Is that a bad thing?” Battling her addiction is constantly on her mind, she said so herself this evening. Every behaviour driven by the need to drink. I’m a bastard for wanting to replace one addiction with another, but the way I want to consume and own Marie Moretti isn’t rational and I don’t want to control and tame it.

“I don’t think so. We’re not hurting anyone. Well, we’re hurting you but you love it.”

“That I do.”

“Being the hand that dealt you pain, a pain you crave, it made me feel in control. Powerful. Cherished. And the way you came for me,” her voice drops, sinful and enticing. “It was a gift. Even more than when you made me come on your tongue.”

I close my eyes at the image she depicts and turn my focus back to Ember. “Your mamma’s a real tease, Bibi.”

Marie giggles and kisses my cheek with a quick peck.

“Sorry not sorry.” The youthful retort is a reminder that under all the pain and grief, Marie’s young and full of life. “Let’s finish the movie.”

I nod and settle, Ember on my chest and Marie tucked under my arm, sharing the space with her daughter. Before she presses play, she whispers, “If you’ll let me, I’d love to do it again.”

I bend down and kiss the birthmark at the corner of her eyes and the little scar next to her mouth before I agree enthusiastically. Anything for my little bird, until she can fly off her cage.

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## MARIE

SOMETIMES, A MOTHER DOESN'T KNOW



I'm having lunch downtown West Hill with Giulia and Catalina when my phone buzzes. I'm not quick enough to hide the caller ID and Giulia takes a peek before clicking her tongue.

"How many times has *zia* called you over the past six weeks?" she asks, and I know she's well intentioned but the reproach in her voice is unmistakable.

"A few times a day. I texted her that I was okay," I answer weakly.

The phone screen switches off again, a voicemail notification lightening it up a few seconds later. My mother has left me a message every single time she's called. I haven't listened to any of them. I wonder how many she can leave until my inbox says "full". Guilt burns a path down my throat before considering leaving them unanswered forever.

"Giulia," Catalina calls, pretending she didn't hear everything my cousin just said to me. "I need to check a new set of jewellery before the charity gala at the hospital next weekend. I'd love your opinion. Marie, I can take Ember and give you some time alone."

She smiles at me and it's so genuine and devoid of expectation, tears fill my eyes.

"Of course, I'll join you in a moment."

Her hand lands on mine, a kind smile spreading on her elegant face. "Take your time, *carina*. You, Missie, are coming with me."



Ember laughs freely as Catalina takes her into her arms and sets her on her chest with my sling. It's the picture of grandmotherly love. Something I've refused my own mother ever since she was born, too afraid she would take Ember from me. It's not guilt I taste in the back of my throat anymore. It's shame. I'm such a waste of love. My mother doesn't deserve how I've treated her.

When Giulia and Catalina disappear on the corner of the street, I pick up the phone and dial my mother's number.

"*Picculina*," my mother cries. "Oh baby, I've missed you so much. Are you okay? Is Ember okay?"

Of course, this would be about Ember.

"She's okay, mum. I can take care of her." My tone is petulant and dismissive. I want to fight. I want to push her away. There's no point in delaying the inevitable. One day or another, my mother will notice the wrong twin died and she'll hate me for it, if she doesn't already. Angèle was right. I should spare myself the pain and the rejection and sever our connection already. God, I need a stiff drink. I need to burn that pain away with my favourite liquor. Now that both Giulia and Catalina are gone, it's the perfect moment to shop for what I need most.

I barely hear my mother as my half-baked plan comes into fruition when I step foot into the small supermarket across the road from the cafe I was just seated at.

"You know, I think it's time for you to come back home but if you prefer, we can also come visit the Capaldis. It's been so long since your dad and I traveled. And with Lana at the head of the family, we have time."

"Uh uh, I'll just be another few weeks. It's been good for me to be away from Kalliste for a little while," I say as I scan the articles at the self checkout and pay for my vice.

"So, you're coming back?" my mother asks and there's no hiding the hope in her voice. The voice that used to bring me comfort and that turned into an accusation ever since Lisa died. Or at least that's how it feels to me.

"When I'm ready, Mamma. I'm not ready yet."

I don't want to tell her that every single second in our house is a second closer to the death of my soul. That being away from where Lisa left me all alone to deal with the demons in my head has healed more in me than the years of therapy I'm sure my parents would have sent me to if only they knew the depths of my addiction. How do I tell my own mother that I can't

look at her without resenting her for trying to separate me from what gave me a new life?

“Okay, baby. Remember that a child needs stability. Do you have any plans for your future?”

And there it is again. I’m not jealous of my own daughter. Of course, my mother would have questions and concerns about her. But the pangs of sadness that takes hold of me sure feel like someone ripped my heart and stomped on it. My future is my child and I tell my mother as much before we quickly hang up. She doesn’t voice her disagreement but she doesn’t need to. She wanted more for me than the life of a mother. She wanted me to be more like Lana, and go to university and do something with my life. I know that’s why everyone has kept me away from mafia life and now I left them to live with the epitome of it.

I never thought I’d be a stay-at-home mum. I didn’t think I’d be a mum at all, but now that I’ve been living this life for a few weeks, I like it. It’s quiet and comfortable. I get to spend time outside, walking through a gloomy forest that appeals to me more than the Mediterranean landscapes does, if I’m being honest. I get to read and watch Ember grow. It’s all a privilege that I don’t want to squander by trying to be anything else.

And then, there’s Nico. My cheeks heat, images of what I did to him filling my mind until the ghost of his touch heats my blood.

I let out a *umph* as a strong shoulder bump into mine as I exit the supermarket with my new supplies of liquid shame inside my purse.

“I’m so sorry, I didn’t see you there,” the stranger says and when I lift my gaze, a familiar face stares back at me. “Oh hi. Marie, is it? You’re Giulia’s cousin? We briefly met the other night.”

“Yes. Hi. Luca, right? You’re Andrea’s lawyer?” I ask politely and he smiles awkwardly at me.

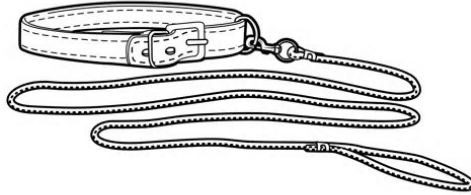
“That’s right. I was on my way to my office.” He points to the building across the street, then excuses himself and says goodbye before disappearing behind the revolving door.

Giulia explained that his new wife is her lawyer and I park the information inside my brain, in a neat little box called ‘just in case’.

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NICO

MURDER MAKES THE HEART GROW FONDER...



I'm up and ready to pounce the second someone knocks on the door of my house. Marie rouses and sits up, looking at me with sleep-addled eyes and I place a finger to my mouth so she stays silent.

When I open the door, Andrea's on the other side of the threshold. "We have him."

He glances behind me and frowns. I follow his gaze to find Marie wrapped in a blanket, standing a few feet away. I know she hates being kept in the dark, I should have known she'd follow. It doesn't matter, I want her to be sure about me before my obsession for her prevents me from letting her go when she'll finally realise I'm a killer and unworthy of her. Every day with her and Ember here brings me closer to the point of no return already. It's been a week since that night at Absolution, and six weeks since I first started to sleep in her bed. I don't see myself being able to sleep as soundly if she left.

"Get Ember, *luna mia*. Give her to Andrea, then get dressed. We have somewhere to be," I tell her and she disappears without a word in the bedroom that's now ours.

"Want to tell me what the fuck you're doing?" Andrea whispers when she's gone, a tinge of disappointment and concern behind his words.

"What does it look like I'm doing? I'm taking Marie to the workshop with me, and you, *fratello*, are going to play house with your niece."

"She's not my niece," he quips and I growl, getting into his face.

“You better reframe that mindset, Andrea, because as far as I’m concerned Marie and Ember are mine.” The usage of his name does the trick, his eyes widening before he tampers it down. He’s incapable of not clenching his jaw hard though and I know he wants to grill me, but I said all I needed to.

“I don’t think it’s a good idea to bring Marie to see your target tonight.”

“Don’t underestimate her,” I say before I feel her presence behind me. I turn to face her. My next words are not for him. “She’s stronger than anyone knows.”



I THOUGHT I would feel anxious or excited about bringing Marie here, but there’s nothing but peaceful calm settling in my mind as I open the heavy door of my workshop and we step in.

Andrea and I are very careful with disclosing where we live so I already know that he picked up my guest at Dobrev’s and drove him here. I’m unsure about the state of him and *that* brings a cold sweat at the base of my nape. I don’t like surprises. I would usually do the picking but Dobrev and Andrea are closer so I guess he called him instead of me. Which is fine, I don’t need a new friend. Bringing two new people into my circle of trust is new enough.

Marie’s fingers tense against my own and I turn to face her before we enter my territory.

“I’m not about to throw you into it, Marie. There are multiple rooms inside this barn so first, I’ll show you the room I sometimes use as an office. If, and only if, you are ready, we’ll go meet my guest. You are in control, okay?”

She nods and swallows thickly, anxiety written all over her body and gentle face.

“It’s okay to back down now, *luna mia*. No one will mock you or comment on it if you decide that getting closer to your family’s business is too much for you,” I tell her. There’s no pressure to perform here. I will be

the knife and if she wants to be the hand dolling out our punishment, I'll gladly follow but it's all up to her.

Yet, a flash of fire glints in her eyes, the challenge I didn't realise I voiced having her stand taller. "I'm ready."

We get to my office and I show her the feed of the cameras set up in the work room. Like I thought he would, Eli Kent stands in the middle of the room, suspended by chains pulling his arms above his head. Just how I like to start. My lips pull into a smile at Andrea's clear display of affection. I don't know how brothers are acting in other parts of the world and fringes of society but to me, to us, this is what brotherly love looks like.

I take a step back and let Marie take it all in. She doesn't say a word but her lips part slightly, and she takes a step forward towards the cameras. "What did he do?"

"Remember when we had that talk at Andrea and Giulia's family dinner a few weeks ago? That's him. You don't need to know his name, I don't want it to sully your tongue. He supplies Misha Petrov with easy targets for his skin trade," I say on a hiss.

Retelling his story makes my skin crawl and my vision tint red. The need for violence threatens to pull me under and I tap my right leg with my right index three times.

Marie doesn't stop me. Instead, like I'm not a monster about to take a life, she caresses my cheek. "Let's go, sweet boy. Someone needs to meet their maker, and you're the executioner." Her voice is pure sin and I let out a low groan.

I've never been aroused by my own violence. Only by how it feels on my skin when I get it. But she makes me want to make her proud.

We leave the office and walk the short distance to the work room. The sliding door glides silently but our movements draw Eli's attention. His beady eyes follow Marie with a leering gaze and the asshole has the audacity to lick his lips. For that alone, I'll make him suffer.

As always, I start the process the same way. By removing my clothes and putting on the painter suit and mask that will protect my skin from a stranger's fluid.

"What's all this for?" Marie asks.

"I don't want blood on my skin. It makes me violently ill."

She frowns and tilts her head, not reconciling how hard I got when she made me bleed. "You're the only one who can have me begging to

bleed for you, Miss Marie,” I whisper in her ear, satisfaction swimming through my veins like whiskey when she shudders.

“Do I need to dress like that, too?” she asks.

“I would prefer it, yes. I also don’t want you to be sullied by someone else’s fluids on you, especially blood. It sticks everywhere.”

She nods solemnly before removing her dark jeans and knitted black sweater, leaving her in nothing but a lace bra and panties that barely cover the curves of her ass. I’m salivating, clenching my fists with the need to kneel at her feet.

Eli decides it’s the perfect moment to let out a low whistle. “You got me my last meal, Death? I don’t mind dying if I get to sink my cock into the pretty whore. Bet she’ll scream so good for me.”

I stalk to him, grabbing one of my knives from where it rests on the metal table, and seize his jaw. The sharp blade cuts through the thin flesh of his cheek as I carve from his mouth to his left ear. Blood oozes from the wound, pooling along my gloved hands and painter suit, the rivulets creating a mesmerising crimson river on the white fabric. I do the same to his other cheek while he thrashes against my hold, tears mixing with the blood. It’s useless but his instincts are driving him to fight.

Good.

I want him to fight every minute I’m gonna drag this out.

“The only reason you can still see her is because I’ll take my time carving out your fucking eyes so I can keep them for my shelf trophy,” I tell him, unhinged and so fucking close to his face I barely recognised myself.

Of course layers separate us, but it’s very rare that rage drives me so close to my assignments.

My threat lands as desired, fear painting his eyes and staining his pants. The mask doesn’t fully protect me from the acrid smell of urine.

It never occurred to me before this moment that someone could reject me because of what I do. I’m so used to the people I love knowing exactly who I am that considering any other reality where I’m not myself didn’t register. For the first time, I doubt my choice to bring Marie here. My fingers mindlessly tap my legs in the same old rhythm. Apprehension has my stomach roiling and I turn back to face her slowly, preparing myself for the disgust or fear on her face.

She’s fully dressed in the gear I prepared for her. Her voice is muffled though the mask but I hear her loud and clear as she asks if she can join me.

My heart is in my ears, beating against my body as though it wants to leap out to join her. The three steps she takes to make her way to me are weighted.

“You’re beautiful when you look like Death,” she says as she lifts a gloved hand and caresses my plastic-covered cheek. The fabric between us doesn’t erase how much I want her.

My sole purpose since she entered my life is to kneel at her feet. So I do.

The corner of her eyes crinkle with satisfaction and I don’t need to see her mouth to know she’s smiling. As I drop my head down, silence fills my ears. It’s like the sound of fresh snow on a winter morning over the field of Scottish bluebells by my house. Untouched and pure.

I barely know why I’m here other than to please the goddess in front of me.

“Be a good boy and do your job, baby. I’ll be watching.”

I stand and turn to Eli whose face is ashen, eyes shot red with fear.

“You’re sick,” he garbles and I decide right then, his tongue needs to go. I spend the next two hours engrossed in my tasks as I strap him to my table and remove his eyes before harvesting his organs and skinning him. Alive.

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## MARIE

...OR MAYBE JUST HORNY



**B**earing witness to Nico's controlled brutality shouldn't have been enticing. I definitely *shouldn't* be wet and pressing my thighs together. I even wonder why I do it because it's not giving me any relief.

Maybe there was never a way for me to escape violence like my family wanted. Maybe it's a genetic trait to be turned on by it. Or because I've known what my family does, I'm de-sensitised. Whatever the reason, I observed Nico with fascination and self-righteousness as he rid the world of this man.

His eyes on me gave me cold shivers, the feeling of being unclean sticking to my skin like a disease. I'm glad he won't be able to hurt anyone ever again. And I'm glad Nico got what he needed, too, replacing the face of this man with the enemy he wishes to kill over and over again for hurting his family.

I can echo the sentiment.

I'd never be able to do what Nico does. But if my family were hurt, if there was someone guilty I could punish for Lisa's death, I might. That's the problem with how I feel. My family's way of treating me has made me bitter, they've hurt me though they never wanted to. But I still love them, and I would do anything for them.

As for Lisa, that's what cancer does. It takes from you and you have nowhere to put your pain, your grief, your hate has no where to go. There is no one to blame. Alcohol gives me someone to blame. Myself.



Something clatters to the floor and my attention is stolen again by the man who has my heart on overdrive. He's focused, cleaning the space from blood where it disappears down the drain at the end of the room.

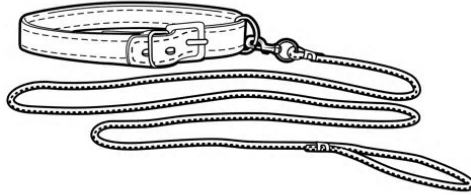
In his painter suit, he looks like a macabre angel of Death, the clinical version that probably gives grown men nightmares. Though none live to tell the tale. I watch riveted as he takes measured steps, using his favourite number to swipe the floor, disinfect all his tools, then disappear with the body before coming back. I'm fascinated, entranced. I can't look away.

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## NICO

NEVER LOOKING AT KITCHEN UTENSILS THE SAME



I clean up the workshop and dispose of the body, all the while, Marie observes me with unnerving stillness. She's usually so easy to read, one of the things I love most about her. Yet, now in my element, where all my thoughts come to die with the souls I take, she doesn't give me anything. It's the first time I feel the need for reassurance, like an inferno blazing inside my mind. My fingers have started their incessant tapping again.

She removes her mask and from the corner of the room, her voice carrying with imposing calmness, she says, "You did so good, baby. Now, tell me what you need."

The space is pristine and there's no chance of getting any fluid other than paint on my skin when I go onto my final step of my process. I remove my own mask and start discarding the paint suit carefully, laying it to the side to be bleached later.

"I need you to tell me you don't hate me." I can't look at her. I didn't realise how raw I feel after a kill, the emotions and primal needs right under the surface. I usually shower and crash but right now, I need her hands on me, steadying me. "I need you to not be afraid of me," I supply barely above a whisper.

When she's discarded her own protective gear, her hand lifts to touch my cheek and bring my lips to hers in a soft touch of our mouths. "I could never, Nico. I'm not afraid of you and I certainly don't hate you. Was it a

lot? Yes.” She grimaces but it’s short-lived. “Despite what everyone thinks, despite how sheltered and protected I’ve been, I’m no stranger to violence and I find your justice kind of poetic. Does that make me a monster?”

”Of course not,” I reply vehemently.

“Then you’re not one either.” The finality of her judgment lifts the weight off my shoulders. “So, what’s the next step?”

I stand up straighter, my own hand hovering over her head. The strands of dark luscious hair beckon me in but I can’t touch her when death lingers so close. “Let’s shower.” I don’t tell her that I can smell the plastic on her and I hate it.

When we’ve cleaned ourselves up in the adjacent room and put on our clothes again, I drag two chairs from the side closet. They’re uncomfortable, white folding plastic chairs that were meant as a functional tool, but I don’t want her to keep standing. I sit Marie down, her perplexed expression lifting the corners of my lips.

Then I set up the easel, a blank canvas, and my assortment of black and white paints until I create a palette of greys that will capture every moment that happened tonight. I don’t talk as I start to sketch. Nor as I start to paint. The guilty is usually the centrepiece of my canvases but today, it’s an abstract feminine silhouette. All elements revolve around it. Black and grey mix with my harsh movements, always in a set of three. Soon, frenzy takes over and I barely control what I reveal on the painting. My arms burn with the effort of holding the brush and the palette after the strenuous task of killing Eli slowly, yet my mind has emptied of anything that isn’t this very moment.

Just like when Marie dominated me a few days ago, only peace and the present moment exist. The pain of my father’s death, the guilt and the need to repent has given way to this creative vortex I’m losing myself into. Sweat beads at my brow and I don’t stop. I fill more of the canvas until no space has been left unattended. Until no space is left blank. She’s everywhere.

When I stop, I’m breathing hard. Two dainty hands snake around my middle from behind to settle on my stomach. They slither gently and I shiver, tension leaving my body as though it was never there.

Marie’s cheek presses against my back and this time, I grin freely as she tries to squeeze me to her body. “You’re so talented,” she breathes.

I look over my shoulder, and she raises her head to meet my gaze. Her eyes have darkened to a green so deep it's almost black.

"I paint death. It's morbid." It's not self-deprecating, but my honest truth. Every person that has the misfortune of ending in this room is painted after their death. My own fucked up version of a bedpost. Yet, she doesn't recoil.

"I think it's beautiful. You're beautiful. You look so free while you paint."

I turn to hug her to my frame. Her curves fit on the plane of my body like she was made just for me, carved by a merciful God who thought maybe I could be saved.

There's one room I haven't shown her yet.

Taking her hand in mine, we walk out of the work room and close the distance to a door facing my office. I open and switch on the light, letting her step inside in front of me.

Her intake of breath has me holding my own.

"I've painted the death of who you were ever since you stepped foot in my house weeks ago. I know that's what you came here to do. To bury that version of yourself you were before we met."

I've never been more prolific than in the past month. Inside the room, there's about fifty portraits and abstracts of Marie. All in black and white. Most are sad and dark but lately, the white has been more prominent.

She stops in front of a larger piece. She sits naked, giving her back to the viewer and leaning on her right hand. Her face is fully covered by the sheets of dark hair and slanted to the side to reveal her neck.

"This one is from the night at Absolution," I tell her and wait for her reaction.

Her focus is fully on the canvas, her hands covering her mouth.

"When did you have the time to paint this? You're always with me."

That's not what I expected her to ask but I answer honestly. "I barely sleep at night so I come here and paint you."

When she turns to me, her eyes are filled with tears, brimming with an emotion I can't recognise, let alone have a name for. I just know I can feel it too. Energy crackles between us, drawing us together, sizzling with promise. We're on the verge of falling. I had the same sensation when I watched the azure sea on the Hills of Sant Armellu, back when I first met her and contemplated falling over the edge of the cliff in her garden. The

emptiness on the other side of what we'll do is terrifying and exhilarating, because I know she'll be right there with me. As much as I've never felt alone with Andrea and my mother, it's different with her. She's different.

She's everything. And I want to give it all to her.

"Can I take you home, Miss Marie?" I ask bending over her to graze my lips against hers. "You already own my soul, I need you to own my body."

The dark pools of her irises widen, her gaze turning sultry. I get hard on her confidence as she grabs me by the throat and crashes her lips to mine. She consumes me with every nip and lick, dominating me already with only a kiss. I melt for her before I scoop her into my arms, and march back to the house.



"LET me down and kneel by the bed. Wait for me there," Marie orders. Her voice has dropped so low the dog inside me wants to bark. I dart inside our bedroom and kneel dutifully by the bed, eyes cast down. She rummages in the kitchen and anticipation has me hard and barely holding a groan already.

Her feet appear in the corner of my eyes when she steps inside and closes the door. The click is loud and I shiver, making Marie chuckle darkly. *Fuck, I've never felt so needy.* My cock twitches inside my jeans, painfully pressing against the zipper.

Her fingers glide under my chin and she raises my face to meet her lustful gaze. She's still fully clothed in a comfortable wool dark dress and thick tights that I want to rip them with my teeth. My eyes dart to see she's placed glasses of water on the bedside table and a metal spatula on the bed. The unknown of the situation has a cold sweat rising on my skin but she gives me a sharp slap. It doesn't hurt but it's savage enough to bring my attention immediately back to her.

"Do you trust me, baby?"

I nod.

She clicks her tongue. "Words."

"Yes, Miss Marie. I trust you."

“Your safety is my priority. Use your safe word if you need everything to stop and give me colours throughout the scene. Otherwise, keep your eyes on me, baby. You’ve been such a good boy for me, wiping the world of the undeserving. You deserve a reward, don’t you, sweet boy?”

I nod, before remembering what she likes. For me to admit how pathetically gone for her I am, and whatever she has to give me. “Yes, Miss Marie. I’ve been so good for you.”

She caresses my cheek. “Get up, lose the clothes and bend over the bed, baby.”

I obey, eager to please, dropping my jeans and boxers to my ankles but not stepping out of them and position myself as she requested. I’m fully exposed. It isn’t much different than when we were at my club, yet the air has thickened between us.

There’s an intimacy in giving myself over to her in my home that sends zings of electric need straight to my cock. My head floats with anticipation. Before I know what I’m doing, I’m wiggling and trying to get friction on my aching cock.

“So fucking pathetic, baby,” Marie coos as the back of her hand trails along my spine until it reaches my ass cheeks. A whine escapes and I chant yes, hoping she’ll continue. Hoping she’ll touch me and make me *feel*. I’m so tired of being in my head all the time. With Marie, I can finally be in my body. “You need me to touch you, don’t you?”

It’s phrased as a question, but we both know it’s a consent check. After I tell her how much I want her to do whatever she wants with me and we repeat our safe words to each other, both her hands spread my butt cheeks. She spits in between, working the moisture with her fingers. I buck against her deft fingers and moan when she slides her wet fingers against me.

“Give me a colour, baby,” she asks.

“Orange.”

She hums before withdrawing her fingers and kneading my ass instead, caressing the back of my thighs. She spits again, one of her fingers sliding in slightly. “Green, so fucking green,” I yell, my voice muffled by the comforter underneath me. The sensation is so new and overwhelming, the perspective of exploring it sends a shiver up my spine and jolts of pure electricity to my cock.

She withdraws and I mourn the loss of her inside me. I wouldn’t let anyone near my ass. Damian asked in the past and it was always a hard

limit but now that Marie has awakened this new side of me, I can't wait for her to own it fully. I lift my head to see what she's doing and her soft hand lands on my neck, pressing me into the mattress. Even with all her weight, I could overpower her easily but letting her dominate me is a promise of sweet pleasure and surrender. "Don't fucking move until I tell you to."

Does she even realise how hot she sounds when she commands me like I'm her pet?

"I know you need the pain, baby. And I'll always take care of you, and give you exactly what you need," she says as she reaches for something above my head.

The first slap of the metal against my buttocks is a sharp awakening of the senses and I gasp, half shocked, half turned on. I will never look at this kitchen tool the same way ever again. I already don't cook much, but I won't ever, now. She'll rewire my brain into thinking any meal could lead to this.

The second slap hits the exact same way and I revel in the heat blossoming under my skin. The material heats too and after a while, the oscillation between heat and coolness gives way to pure fire. I burn everywhere, not only where I know she's turning my skin red and molten but the rest of my body where she hasn't touched me yet. My cock must leak on the comforter and I have this dark thought that then it will smell like me when she puts it over us to sleep. I crave to cover her in cum so I can mark her up just a fraction of how much she's marked me and my wretched soul.

Marie checks in regularly during our session and it's always green. The pain transmutes into euphoria, my ass and thighs will be fucking blue by the time she is done and I want her to take a picture to immortalise it.

I'm a mess of sweat, whimpering weakly as she palms my ass then soothes the ache away with a gentle caress. Yet even that much skin to skin has me keening. I love every second of it.

"You did so good, baby." Her cool lips land on my nape, a shock to my overheated senses. "Settle back on your knees," she asks softly. I hiss when I move to stand, legs wobbly from the pleasure-pain, and she drops a pillow to make me more comfortable. My heart does a little somersault and I must have heart eyes like in cartoons as I look up.

She's fully naked, resting on her hands, her glorious curves on display as she sits where I just was. Long silky dark hair covers her nipples and I

hold a growl at the offence. I take my time devouring the vision in front of me. Her cheeks and neck are rosy with the exertion of spanking me for what felt like hours, heavy breasts that deserve to be held and worshipped calling my name. I admire her soft stomach and the dips of her luscious hips until my eyes finally land on the dark curls on her mound between thick milky thighs. My mouth waters and I lift my eyes up again, pleading without words, clenching my fists with the desire to be her good boy and not listen to my basic urge to delve straight in.

Marie's worrying her bottom lip, a cheeky grin spreading on her face as she spreads her legs and I'm rewarded with the best view of her glistening cunt. I exhale heavily.

*"Please."*

A single word like a prayer between us.

So taken with her, I didn't notice the belt she holds in her right hand. "May I?"

My breathing picks up, my cock getting incredibly harder. I nod, throat bobbing as I wait for her next move. "Yes."

She loops the belt around my neck, holding it like a leash. There's nothing but dark lust in the usually green irises of the woman I love. And she's never looked more beautiful.

My owner. My God. My creed.

"Please, Miss Marie. Let me please you. Let me taste you again."

She nods, and somehow, despite the power dynamic, it's shy. Her heels land on the mattress as she reclines on the bed and this time, I don't hold the groan coming deep from my chest. I launch myself at her wet pussy without preamble, fucking her with my tongue, sucking her clit ravenously into my mouth. The belt tightens slightly around my neck and feeds my hunger for her.

"Fuck me with your fingers, baby." Marie's voice is twisted with desire and lands inside my brain. Like a good pet, I obey, inserting one finger, then two when I feel how wet she is. Her walls flutter around my digits and I add my tongue in, loving the way her back bows off the bed. I'm barely two knuckles deep, pressing upward at the same time that my other hand presses on her stomach.

All the reading I did since our first time together is paying off. Marie's cries of pleasure get louder and louder until she clasps my head down, framing it with her thighs and clenching erratically around my fingers. She



comes on a deep moan that has me grasping my cock so I don't come all over myself. I want to settle back on my haunches but the belt keeps me exactly where I am and I lick her folds and entrance languorously until she's fully come down.

"Come here," Marie asks, nothing like the dominant woman who owned me a few seconds ago. It's a needy two words, barely a pull of the belt and I settle over her, framing her head with my elbows.

"It's my first time, Nico. Go slow."

"You want me to take you raw?" I ask, awe blossoming inside me.

"Yes. I don't want any barrier between us."

I can't believe it. The thought has me ready to burst, to flood her with my cum, filling her until she's round with my baby. I notch the head of my cock at her entrance. The contact already fills me with that familiar warmth I associate with Marie. Slowly, I sink inside her.

And I fall harder than I ever thought possible.

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## MARIE

COLLARS AND LEASHES



I pull gently on the makeshift leash, inviting Nico inside me, and my world is thrown on its fucking axis. Each of his piercings has me gasping for air as they slide against my inner walls. I understand him more as the pain of his intrusion gives way to pleasurable fullness. Settled inside me, he doesn't move but chants my name, his eyes darting all over my face with awe, and that emotion I start to see behind his whiskey eyes.



*Scan QR Code for access to this scene NSFW art*

Tears rise to the surface, my throat clogged with the knowledge of how undeserving I am of him.

Then, he moves, withdrawing a few inches before thrusting back in with a gentleness so unlike him. I know his reputation. That he is a cold killer, a

machine made for taking lives but they couldn't be further from the truth. Inside Nico, a fire burns bright. He doesn't always have the words for his emotions and why they appear but he feels them all the same and is more accepting of them than anyone I've met before. More than me.

A pathetic whimper brings me back to him until he's all I can see, smell and feel.

"You're making me feel so good, baby. Do you like fucking my pussy?"

Another whimper is Nico's response and I grin. I'm getting addicted to his noises. I need more of them.

"Do you like knowing you'll be the only one to ever touch me because all I want is you? That I'd never be able to do this with anyone else?" I ask, pulling on the leash to bring his lips close to mine, yet just shy away of kissing.

"Oh fuck, yes. Yes, yes, yes. God, I fucking love it. It makes me want to come," he cries out.

"No God here, baby. Just me. Now fuck me like I know you want to." I pull his head down until I whisper in his ear, "You have my permission."

Like an elastic band that snapped, Nico slams his lips to mine and hikes my hip above his, thrusting into me with renewed violence. His hand on my ass opens me up for him, pelvis slapping against my flesh. The symphony we create is obscene, made of grunts and moans and wetness.

Pleasure coils at the base of my spine, rising steadily. Nico takes one of my tits inside his warm mouth, biting playfully at my nipple, and I'm free-falling. The pressure of his teeth on my flesh, his hard cock inside me pistonning an erratic rhythm, his sweaty skin gliding over mine, it's all too much. Throwing my head back, I come on a silent scream, detonating over him like it's what I'm meant for.

"Oh fuck." I hear him groan as if in a fish bowl. Then, he's unleashed. He fucks me into the mattress, grabbing my thighs with rough hands, and letting go. Pathetic cries fill my ears as he spurts his cum deep inside me. I float on the high, drunk on his pleasure.

When he stops moving and collapses over me, the weight of his body all I will ever need, my pussy spasms around him and he swears again. That makes me giggle uncontrollably, his softening cock slipping out of me. I get on my elbows while he rests on his haunches, the belt still hanging from his pretty neck, and we both admire the place where we were joined, leaking with a mix of cum and a little virginal blood.

Possessed, I swipe my index and middle fingers on my cunt, gathering the mess of us and sit up. I take hold on his jaw with my other hand and hover over his mouth.

“Open for me, baby.”

He does and sticks out his tongue with a cheeky flush on his face. Without prompt, he sucks my fingers into his mouth and moans.

I’m in danger. He’s about to become my deepest addiction, if he isn’t already.

While Nico feasts on us, my gaze drops to his cock and I’m drawn to taste us, too. Pushing him with a hand on his chest until he’s on his back, I take his flaccid length into my mouth, metal and salt swirling on my tongue. I’m not doing this for him, this is all for me, the proof that someone cared enough for me to give themselves over to me fully. I take my time cleaning him up, licking all traces of who I was away. I kiss the underside, take the pierced head into my mouth, caress his sac. Nico thickens under my ministrations and pride floods my veins like the most delicate alcohol. Before long, he’s moaning again, fists clenched at his side and begging for release.

“Give me everything, baby. Fuck my mouth like a good boy,” I urge, before taking it again into my mouth until he hits the back of my throat. He doesn’t hesitate, obeying sweetly and fisting my hair to pump inside me with abandon.

Before long, Nico’s coming again, crying so beautifully it sounds pained. I release him and swallow, climbing up until I rest my ear on his chest, listening to his heart settling down to a normal rhythm again.

Silence envelops us, protecting the little bubble we created for ourselves. I know it will pop soon. This sense of bliss, it can’t last long. Not when I’m the one breathing and my sister’s ashes are scattered in the wind. Not when Nico deserves more than I can ever give him. I was selfish. Taking his submission, that should have been meant for someone worthy, is the ultimate betrayal. He just doesn’t realise it yet.

Attuned to the dark clouds looming over me, Nico squeezes me closer. “What are you thinking about, *luna mia*?”

“Nothing,” I lie. “Just you.”

That much is true. He’s all I think about lately. How in another world, he could have been my everything. How in another reality, him, Ember and I could be the family I wish I could give my daughter. She deserves to have

a father figure that loves her and cherishes her and I know Nico has so much love inside him, he'd give it freely if I asked. But *I* don't deserve it.

I let the illusion of us lull me into a false sense of normalcy as we shower together and get into bed, his body moulding against my back. He said he doesn't sleep much so I'm hoping he'll leave soon to go paint and I can find what I need. The unopened bottle of white wine I bought at the store is calling my name like a demon on my shoulder. Once Nico is gone, I won't resist the siren's call. I don't even want to.

I want to stop feeling. I want the oblivion the clear liquid promises. Since I haven't had much alcohol in days, I know it will come fast. I want that. I need that. The bleeding heart wound inside my chest is too raw right now, memories of my sister's smile haunting me as I try not to fall asleep and wait for the man I can never have to leave.

When Nico finally moves, he kisses my temple and it's the nail in the metaphorical coffin. He's too kind, too sweet, too perfect. Not for me. A few minutes after the door closes, I get up and walk to the place where I've stashed my vice, driven by the invisible force of my self-loathing. Getting on my knees, I contort my thick body until I reach behind the washing machine and grab the bottle. I unscrew the twisting cap and drink straight from it.

I don't even deserve the dignity of a glass. Long pulls burn at my throat and I almost throw it right up. I push through.

Cold wetness covers my cheeks. I don't realise it's my own tears, and I keep drinking. The problem with alcohol is that it doesn't hit me up right away, unlike Nico's kisses and touches. It festers inside me first, breeding more of that self-hate until all I can think about is that my sister would hate me too if she could see me. But she can't. And it's my daughter who will have to live with a mother like me. Yet, I can't abandon her. I'm left in this limbo where I can't take care of her yet I can't let go.

"Look at you! You should be ashamed of yourself," my sister sneers from her place in the corner of the room. I finish the bottle and cry myself to oblivion, right there on the floor, in the living room of the only person who could save me. But he'll be gone too when he realises who I truly am.

## MARIE

WHISKEY OR SEX?



I get jostled around and groan, trying to understand what's going on and failing. There's something soft underneath me, a delicate caress on my face. When darkness pulls me in deeper, I let it.



I GROAN LOUD as I wake up, my daughter's name on my lips.

I sit up and it's a fucking mistake. The sharp movement brings up a wave of nausea and I rush to the bathroom. My knees hit the floor hard but I don't have the time to cry out in pain as I heave above the porcelain bowl. The cold sweat that tenses my whole body isn't new, but I haven't felt it for so long it's a shock to my system.

I hate this phase. Forehead on my forearm, I wait for the stomach contractions to recede. My mouth is sticky and my tongue thick. I can barely swallow. The pounding headache behind my eyelids makes me want to reach inside my brain and tear my eyes out with my nails. Yet, this is all familiar, a routine well-honed. I'll jump into the shower, as cold as can be, brush my teeth until my gums are raw then apply concealer and the lightest makeup. I'll pretend I'm starving when I come down to eat breakfast with

Lisa and my parents and use the carbs to absorb the remaining liquid sloshing in my stomach.

A baby giggles in the distance, waking me up from where I fell back asleep, head hanging above the toilet. That's a new fucking low. I stand up and come face to face with my reflection. My chin wobbles as I take in the sunken cheeks and hollow eyes that used to be a vibrant green.

Once upon a time.

Because this isn't my bathroom. Lisa isn't downstairs. I'm not even at my parents' house.

A full body tremor racks me to my core but I shake it away, averting the mirror. I don't deserve to feel sorry for myself. I did this. I turned into this ghost of myself. No one pushed me there. I have no one to blame but my own wretched choices.

I quickly splash cold water onto my face, foregoing the shower for now and dab the droplets away with a warm clean towel set aside next to the sink. I know Nico placed it there for me and the kindness makes me want to die.

Ember's noises hang above me like an axe, but there's no escaping what I did. I have no idea what time it is or when Nico picked Ember up, or if Giulia dropped her off. I've lost track of what was important and what's the result? The hangover of the decade and potent shame clinging to me like petrol.

I take tentative steps until the living room comes into view. Nico's seated on the couch, Ember on his knees. He smiles down at her as he shows her brushes and runs them down her little arms, making her giggle louder. They're the picture of familial bliss.

I'm the onlooker.

Maybe that's where my place is and it's time I accept it. I'll never belong. Especially not with him.

"You're awake," Nico comments sternly. He'd have slapped me and it would have been less painful.

I pick at my pyjama top and nod. What am I supposed to say? *Sorry I got drunk last night and forgot I had a daughter that needed me.* I haven't had such a black out since that first week after Lisa's funeral. But then I knew my mum would take care of Ember. And I always set up an alarm to wake up and get my shit together.

“You want to tell me what happened?” Nico’s voice slashes through the heavy silence only punctuated with Ember’s little babbles.

I could lie, but he’d read me like an open book. And I’m so fucking tired. I deserve his disappointment and whatever punishment he sees fit. Maybe he’ll kick me out. It’s only a matter of time.

“I bought wine when I went downtown with Giulia and Catalina. They left me alone to call my mother and I... I don’t know. I couldn’t resist, I guess.”

I sit on the other side of the sofa, my hands pressed under my legs. I want to curl into a ball but even this little comfort I don’t deserve.

I can’t look at him. I can’t look at her.

I’ve failed her. It’s not the first time and I know it won’t be the last. But I lie to myself anyway. What other choice do I have?

“Why did you do that, Marie? If I had known you’d drunk yourself into a fucking coma, I wouldn’t have left your side. Is this what you want? To lose all sense of autonomy. For me to monitor you and make sure you don’t drink?”

“No.”

I close my eyes. But even then, tears rise up and fall on my cheeks. I don’t wipe them away. “I don’t want to feel like this,” I croak.

“Then, what do you want?”

I expected accusations and yells. Instead, his tone turns soft and almost pleading. It brings me back to last night. In a matter of seconds, it morphed from the best night of my life, a high so euphoric I thought I’d never come down, to one of the worst. But that’s what I do. Self-destroy. It started so long ago I wonder if I ever was anything but a disappointment to myself and my loved ones.

“I want to be better, for Ember,” I start. I glance up and Nico’s intense amber eyes are on me, calm on his striking features. The piercings I love so much on his nose and lips catch the light of the sun shining shyly outside. Maybe that’s what makes me brave. Or maybe it’s just him. “And I want to be better for you.”

I frown and he shakes his head. “Don’t you want to do it for yourself?”

I’m stunned into silence. I’m not high on my priority list. I’ve never been. “I lived for Lisa. Even when I was already drinking, I would keep it under control so I could take care of her. Before her diagnosis, she was a trouble maker, always.” The memories rushing in my mind make me smile.



Ember finally turns to me and smiles widely at me, breaking my heart all over again, as her little arms seem to reach out for me. Nico moves to sit next to me, handing me my daughter. Her baby hair is so thin on her little head. I hug her close to my chest, and continue. "When I look at Ember, it reminds me that I'm not strong enough." My voice breaks but I soldier on. "I want to have a family, Nico. I want to give her brothers and sisters, but how am I supposed to do that when I'm so messed up, when I'm already failing and she's barely six months old?"

"*Luna mia.*" Nico threads his fingers through mine as Ember tucks her little head against my chest. "You are the most selfless person I know. You're also the saddest person I know." A chuckle-sob escapes me. I can always trust him to give me the hard truth. "You haven't dealt with Lisa's death and you haven't dealt with how your family's behaviour made you feel."

"When did you get so attuned to emotions?" I half-joke.

"I might not always recognise them, but I understand the concepts and physiology. And you've been my favourite subject for a while now. Dissecting everything going through your mind is fascinating and heartbreaking all at once. You need to take care of yourself, Marie. Because I love you and I love Ember and I need you to not lose that battle. I can't lose you." His voice is urgent and his fingers tighten around mine.

My nose tickles as fresh tears leak on my cheeks. "I don't deserve your love."

Before I can say another word, Nico's lips crash onto mine. I taste the salt of my tears and the fresh bergamot of the Earl Grey Tea he loves to drink in the morning. Below all of that is that dark obsession that makes me weak at the knees. I lose myself to the kiss, until I take over and dominate him with my tongue, clasping my hand at the back of his head to keep him where I want him. This kiss tastes like the love he proclaims to feel for me. Maybe I can believe him.

Hope blooms and spreads from where our bodies touch to reach the deepest, darkest corners of my ribcage.

When we pull away from each other, we're a little out of breath and grinning like fools in love.

"I need you to be honest with me, Marie. When you want to drink, you need to tell me if I'm close, text me if I'm away. I'll always be in your

corner but as much as I observe you, I can't always know what's on your mind. Don't lie to me or keep me out. *Please.*"

It's the plea that breaks the dam. I nod, dropping my forehead to his. "I'll get outside help. And I'll text you or tell you. I hate it so much when I lose control," I sigh.

"Do you think that's why you love dominating me so much?"

It's an honest question and one I haven't taken the time to contemplate. I stand and place Ember on her bed in the alcove behind us for her afternoon nap, before walking to stand in front of the massive window. The field of Scottish Bluebells is now barren, the little blue flowers gone for the winter. The forest around Nico's house is a mix between green and grey, between the trees that never die and the ones that lose all their leaves come the cold season. In a few months, flowers will bloom again. I don't want to be the only one stuck into the grey, like cast into ice.

Muscled tattooed forearms snake behind me to settle around my middle. Nico's head rests in the crook of my neck, our cheeks fused together. His acceptance of my silence, of my need for time to process is a gift and despite his warm embrace, it's hard to believe I'm worthy of it.

"I think I love your submission because for once, someone I care about defers to me to make decisions, even if it's just sex and intimacy."

Nico hums deep in his throat and the sound travels through me, lighting me up from the inside out. "And you look hot on your knees for me, baby."

His hands clench on my stomach. I turn to face him, framing his face with both my hands before I kiss his full lips again. I push his body until he walks backwards and lands on the sofa.

"It's gonna take time," I say, looming over him, laying my soul to his delicate care.

His hands glide up the back of my thighs, so at odds with how we started. Now, Nico always finds ways to touch me, and I love it. "I'll be right here, Marie. Lean on me."

I straddle him and slide my tongue back into his mouth, our bodies fused together until there isn't any space between us. My heavy breasts are pressed against the hard planes of his chest, the glide of his nipple piercings against my own making me moan. I rake my nails down his neck and he shudders underneath me, becoming pliant, a willing victim to satiate my growing desire. I can't stop rolling my hips over his hardening cock,

seeking friction on my needy clit, driven to madness with the need to have him back inside me.

How I ever thought that alcohol could beat this feeling is beyond me. The primal part of my brain takes over as I discard my pyjamas and paw at his own joggers and soft tee-shirt, until I settle back on top of him, completely naked.

The warmth of his skin is like a balm over my bruised soul, his lips soft and seeking on the column of my neck and chest. He licks, bites and kisses my body while I writhe on top of him, covering his length with wetness and need.

“You’re gonna be a good boy and give me your cock, aren’t you, baby?” I breathe against his lips.

“Yes. Yes, Miss Marie. Anything for you, just please fuck me,” is the needy answer that comes out of his lips. His pupils are blown dark and when I notch the head of his cock at my entrance, we both hold our breath, exhaling heavily while I drop onto it like my life depends on it.

“Fuck, you’re so deep like this, Nico.”

I lift myself off halfway before dropping down again, his piercing gliding inside me deliciously. We both moan as we become nothing but sensations. Claspings his throat, I bring his lips to mine again and he obeys, following my silent orders with a blissful expression on his face. His fingers will leave an indent on the flesh of my ass cheeks with how strongly he’s grasping at the flesh, a sure sign that he’s holding himself back.

I get high on knowing I have that power over him, that I can make him mindless with pleasure and the need to fuck me. I create circles with my hips, taking him deeper and we gasp in harmony. “You’ll take what I give you,” I tell him, then set a harsh pace, bouncing on his cock fast and hard.

My thighs burn with the exertion, but God, I want to see him come. I want to watch as he loses himself inside me and fills me with his cum.

“You’re mine, baby. Mine to own, mine to fuck, mine to edge if I want to.”

“Yes, I’m yours,” he answers on a whimper. “Can I come now?”

“Say please.”

“Please. Please, I beg you, Miss Marie, let me come inside your tight cunt. Let me fill you up.”

My pussy clenches around him as his dirty words register and I nod, incapable of words anymore. I chant a mix of *yes-es* and *fucks*, and cry out

for God. Nico's hands become heavier on me, grinding my clit on his pelvis. Our breaths pick up and we don't lose eye contact as we come together, whimpering into each other's mouth and covering the other in our release. Nico's heart pulses under my fingers where I still hold his throat and I feel mine syncing up to his rhythm.

This beautiful, vulnerable man is all mine. And though the ugly voice in my head rears up to tell me it's all a lie, I don't let it this time, basking in the afterglow of our shared orgasm instead.

After we clean up and finally shower, transferring a sleeping Ember into a cosy we can carry with ourselves in the bathroom, we spend the day doing mundane chores, cooking and even taking a walk through the forest in the frigid late autumn air.

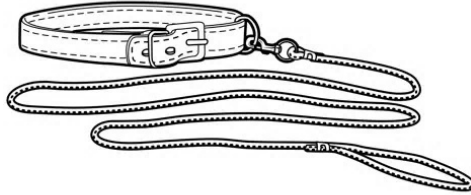
Happiness feels good, but I'm scared it won't last.

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## NICO

WE LOVE A MAN WHO COMES IN HIS PANTS FROM EATING PUSSY



Finding Marie passed out on the floor of our living room at 3 am was not how I thought my compulsive nature would come to be challenged.

The part of me that's obsessed and in love with her needed to care for her, take all her worries away. And the rational part understood it wouldn't help her.

I ran the rug in the bedroom raw with my pacing. I smoked a whole pack of cigarettes in the span of three hours, helpless and on edge. I counted her breaths until I dozed off myself, waking up with a kink in the neck from how I leaned on the chair I had placed in front of her bed. Giulia handed Ember over and asked too many questions that I refused to answer, after I texted her. I couldn't leave Marie's bedside. And I needed my baby girl with me. At least then, I had someone I could tend to.

That was four days ago. Four days staying with Marie and Ember, cooped up in our house. But it's not good for her. I don't think I realised it before but it's claustrophobic.

I come behind her as she prepares a soup for dinner. It's my favourite way to hold her. When I can nestle against her back and run my hands against ample flesh, feeling quickly how affected she gets by me. But tonight, for the second night in a row, she pulls away, pretending to take more ingredients from the fridge.

"You don't want me to touch you?" I ask.

“Oh no, of course you can touch me, but I’m almost done, so we can eat soon. Can you set the table?”

The levity of her voice and the bad, fake excuse have my hackles rising and my heart plummeting at my feet. But I let her. She’s going through her own process and so far, she’s kept her promise, telling me when she feels like drinking. It’s usually right before we go to bed, so we’ve taken to watching movies together on the couch until she passes out from exhaustion around 1 or 2 am. It’s not healthy but I’m out of my depth. I read about coping mechanisms and the healing process all night on my phone but I can’t help her if she doesn’t want to get better. And I know she does. Just at her own pace.

She loves Ember but I think she needs a social life, to understand what she loves and hates, to find herself and who she is when she doesn’t take care of others like she doesn’t matter.

Two days later, I drive her and Ember to meet with Giulia and my mother at her favourite cafe in the centre of West Hill.

“Oh, no I don’t have battery anymore,” Marie complains with an edge of anxiety. When we stay connected through text, she’s more settled and I also don’t want her to run into the possibility of not being able to stay in touch.

“I have one extra in the glove box. Take it.”

After she exits the car with Ember, I track the little yellow dot on my phone that indicates her location. Next to it are a green one and a blue one, each belonging to the other two women in my family. The three of them spend the afternoon together while Andrea and I take Ember for a stroll through the forest. For some reason, he wanted to carry her. The sling wrapped around his massive torso looks comical, but his bear paw of a hand is carefully holding Ember’s head, giving him the perfect uncle aura.

“You’re good with her,” I tell him and he grunts his agreement.

“There’s not much to do, honestly. She looks at me with those big Moretti-green eyes and I’m a goner.”

“It’s good you enjoy her company so much because she’s gonna become mine officially soon.”

His head wipes up so fast I’d almost think he’s gonna throw his neck. It’s funny how his eyes widen. It betrays his surprise though it should be a given since I’ve been taking care of Ember and Marie non-stop since they moved in with me.

“What do you mean?” he asks.

“She might not be my blood but she’s mine. Marie and I will make it official soon.” I shrug, then brace for another onslaught of questions when he opens his goddamned mouth. I don’t understand what’s so difficult to understand. My mum got it the first time I told her last night.

“So, I take it that things have escalated between Marie and you?”

“If by escalated, you mean ‘sex’, then yes.”

He coughs, a *fucking hell* muttered low. “I don’t need to know you bang my wife’s little cousin, *fratellino*. Though, now I owe my wife twenty thousand pounds, thank you very much. I was talking about whatever you two are. Like, are you even a couple?”

“We’re together. We’ve always been together,” I tell him. That’s always been crystal clear in my mind. We were meant to be from the first moment I laid eyes on her. The fact that I didn’t share that with my brother doesn’t change that my intentions with Marie have remained steady for a year now. I remember how skittish she had been at Christmas last year and how she now seeks my touch.

“You’ve always been together,” he parrots, then scoffs. “Does she know that? Does she even know your intention regarding Ember?”

“She will.”

“Don’t be fucking cryptic.”

I stop walking and turn to face him fully, sighing with annoyance. “Listen Andrea, I love her and she loves me. I’m making her and my baby mine soon, but we have shit to work through, first.” He doesn’t need to know about her struggles. That’s for her to share, if she ever wants to.

Andrea raises his hands in surrender. “Okay.”

“Okay?”

“Okay.”

We remain planted in our position for what feels like hours, standing off like in a movie. Until a cheeky grin spreads over his bearded cheeks. “I’m an uncle.” Then his head drops down to look at Ember. “Did you hear that, Bibi? I’m your *zio* Andrea. You’ll say ‘*zio*’ before ‘*papa*’, won’t you, *principessa*?”

“You’re ridiculous.”

My brother smirks, then his face turns grave. “I haven’t seen you so happy since Dad died.”

I shrug. “Maybe I’ve atoned enough and Marie and Ember are my reward, you know. And even if I’m undeserving, I’ll never let them go.”

Andrea stops abruptly, a hand on my chest that he carefully removes once I’ve stopped next to him. His frown is so deep, it changes the grooves of his face. “What do you mean ‘atone’?” He sounds angry and I don’t get it.

“It was my fault that Dad died that night, and—”

“I’m gonna stop you right there, *fratellino*. If someone’s responsible, it’s me for not protecting you, and the man who planned it all. Not you. You were sixteen, for Christ’s sake. Have you been feeling guilty for a fucking decade?”

I stay silent because he already knows the answer and no matter how many times he tells me it’s not my fault, that’s not gonna change how I view the event that changed our lives forever.

Andrea slides a hand over his face and sighs. “Fucking hell, maybe Giulia’s right.”

“About?”

“We need therapy.”

I scoff but he doesn’t. “I’m serious, Nico. It wasn’t your fault and Mama never thought so either.”

“Then, it wasn’t your fault either,” I declare. It won’t erase the grief or a decade of habits to tone down the guilt, but it’s a start.



ANDREA’S new found love of his niece gets me funny in my stomach, but in a good way. He told Giulia of our conversation, of course. They have no secrets for each other. In return, she gave me the ‘*hurt my cousins and I’ll kill you*’ talk. I pretended to be very scared, refusing to reveal that if there’s one of us who has the potential to hurt the other, it’s all Marie. She could wreck me with one word, one decision, one move. She’d destroy me if she’d walk away. Not that I’d allow that to ever happen.

With Ember tucked in at Andrea and Giulia’s for the evening, I’m left with my resilient, beautiful girl. The package I ordered arrived this



afternoon and I'm bouncing on my feet with excitement. That's a new feeling, one I'm enjoying immensely. When she'll see what I have in store for her, I doubt she'll avoid me like she has done for the past few days. She won't be able to resist.

As always, it's all about control.

After we have dinner of homemade—by Andrea—lasagna, we settle on the sofa. I asked my brother to watch Ember so I could have a proper date with Marie. I have a surprise for her.

She goes to sit next to me and I pull her up on my lap. I groan as she lands on my dick with her perfect ample cheeks.

With a petulant sound coming from the back of her throat, she faces me and clasps my chin, sending a thrill through my veins that ignites my entire body. "You're getting presumptuous and bratty, I see. Don't take my lack of discipline for you for weakness, understood?"

"Yes, Miss Marie. I'm sorry, I just needed to touch you."

"I don't care. Get on your knees." Her voice is like a sinful whip licking my skin with the promise of pain. She's never been so stern, eyes dark yet feigning cold indifference.

She stands and I drop to my knees like a dog at her master's feet. When she sits back down, her silence fills the room and shifts the energy around us, until the thread that links us together grows taut, ready to snap. Her head tilts to the side. What I would give to be in her mind right now. All I can do is wait, skin buzzing and heart thrumming inside my chest.

"Remove your belt and hand it to me," she orders and I fumble to present it to her with both hands.

Last time she used a belt was when we fucked. I can almost feel the sensation of the leather wrapping around my neck and she hasn't even touched me yet. I open my mouth to beg but her eyes snap up to mine, an eyebrow raised in challenge. I snap it shut and Marie hums with approval, sending a new wave of intoxication through my bloodstream.

Agonisingly slowly, she opens her legs and motion for me to crawl and settle in between with her right index and middle fingers. Her wide-legged brown trousers are soft to the touch as I lay my hands on her thighs and I force myself not to move more than she allows me. That's already a transgression but she doesn't say anything. Her satisfaction is written across her face in the soft smile and peachy hue of her skin. Marie takes her time

to let the leather glide at the back of my neck before she loops it at the front for her makeshift leash.

“I need to get you something better than this,” she breathes, admiring her handy work and recline against the sofa.

She might have told me she loves me. “You want to collar me?” I ask in a tone that betrays my hope and happiness. Not that I have anything to hide from her anyway. I don’t hide my feelings for her ever. But I don’t think she knows what this means.

“Is that what it’s called?”

“Yes. And it’s a big deal, Marie,” I say, breaking the scene for a moment. She can’t offer to collar me in the middle of a scene and not mean it. It’s like asking someone to marry you when you’re drunk or high. We’ll both be filled with oxytocin and you don’t make that type of decision unless you’re sure, and sober. Both for sex and substances. “A collar isn’t only a toy in the BDSM community. I mean, it could be, but it wouldn’t be for me. If you collar me, that’s it. You’re it. I will never let you go.”

She frowns but the promise of forever, instead of making her run, has her eyes gleaming. “Can’t you just use it during sex and then remove it?”

“Some people do. But that’s not who I am. If you collar me, you own me. And I take that commitment seriously, Marie.”

Time seems suspended as she takes her time to respond. I get lost in her green irises, and I hope she sees the love I have for her in mine. I’m not going anywhere and I’m not letting her destroy herself.

Eventually, she leans forward and kisses me. It’s tender, only a pass of her lips on mine. I like it a lot. I love all the ways she kisses me but that small one, with raw emotions coming to the surface, it’s my favourite.

“I think I might like that, but I’m not ready yet,” she declares.

“I’ll wait.”

She beams at me before dropping back into character, her smile turning salacious. “Show me you deserve it, baby.”

She doesn’t need to tell me twice. I help her out of her trousers and take my time unbuttoning her white blouse until I remove it completely. The little lace set she has under is a deep crimson colour that reminds me of blood and brings me back to when she watched me exert justice.

“*Fuck*, Miss Marie. You’re the most beautiful being I’ve ever seen.”

My mouth drops to her neck, leaving a trail of kisses on my way down. I don’t let any inch of perfect skin untouched and unloved, licking in

between her breasts and biting the nipples over the fabric of her bra, peppering her soft stomach with kisses that awaken goosebumps. When I kiss her inner thigh, Marie hisses but I don't get anywhere near her pussy, choosing to massage her legs instead. I start at the right ankle, moving through deep tension on her calf and then up her thigh, getting closer to where her leg meets the rest of her body but never giving her any release.

"I know what you're doing," she says, then hums deep when I press my fingers on her other calf.

"I don't know what you're talking about. I'm just showing you how much I deserve to be yours, Miss Marie."

She regards me with a deadpan expression and I can't help but chuckle, the sound unnerving. "You're so beautiful when you laugh, Nico." She pulls on the leash and I follow gladly, ending with my stomach flush against the apex of her thighs, as she wraps an arm around my neck and kisses me. Before I'm satiated, she withdraws, the leather taunt between us as she chokes me a little and whispers against my lips, "Finish what you started, baby."

I drop my head down towards her centre and breathe her in, her sweet arousal coating the fabric of her panties with a pretty dark spot for me. I move my mouth over the fabric, teasing. A sharp gasp escapes me when she pulls on my hair roughly.

"Don't be a fucking tease or I'll make you come so much you'll beg me to stop."

Why she would think that's a threat is beyond me but I'm done denying us both what we want. Her dark side came out to play, and I'm here to satisfy it.

Her hand presses at the back of my head and I move her panties to the side, entering her with my tongue straight away and tasting her slick cunt. Like the first time, it's a hit straight to my nervous system. She doesn't let go of my head and pulls on the leash, cutting my airflow and I grow so fucking hard. I don't dare humping the sofa underneath me but fuck, I want to. My head swims with the lack of oxygen but I continue to eat her out, never letting up. I lose sense of time as my tongue circles her clit the way she likes. When black appears on the edge of my vision, I tap her thigh twice and she immediately releases the belt. The rush is immediate and makes me float, my body barely my own.

"Shit, Nico, I'm sorry. Are you okay? Give me a colour, baby."

I lift my head to mouth 'orange' then dive back into the perfect place I want to die in between.

"You're doing so good, baby. You're making me feel so good. God, I'm gonna come."

Her chants and praises combined with the taste of her need is too much. I clasp her thighs harder and she lets go, framing my face with her thighs and making me come without even touching me. I moan and groan along with her as we share our release.

I straighten up and wipe my mouth with the back of my hand, breathing hard. Marie is slumped on the sofa, a silly grin all over her pretty face. "Did you just come from eating me out?"

"Fuck yeah, I did. You're the best meal I've ever had, Miss Marie. How could I not?"

Maybe there's a stigma around coming in your pants without someone touching you, but I haven't grown up with toxic men around me. The only one was my workaholic father, who loved my mother like she was the sun, and my stupid brother who always annoyed me in private and fought for me in public. And if Marie gets this blissed out, freshly fucked and smug as fuck expression when I do, I'm okay with a repeat.

"Let's get cleaned up, shall we?"

"So fucking proper," she jokes but lets me pull her up and drag her to the bathroom where I get down on my knees again because I wasn't joking. She's the best thing I've ever had.

When we finally reach the bedroom, both wrapped in nothing but fluffy towels, Marie immediately notices the pink package on the bed and turns a quizzical look my way before taking it in her hand and unwrapping it.

It's comical how she turns the box in her hands multiple times before deciding to read the back, gasping softly as understanding dawns on her. "What is this?" she asks.

"I believe now that you've read the instructions at least twice, you know exactly what it is." I snake my arms around her body, inhaling her soft peachy perfume and biting softly at her neck. "Do you want to use it?"

She giggles, actually giggles. And fuck if that's not giving me life.

"Yes, I want to fuck your tight little ass, Nico." She reverses our positions and places a hand on my chest, pushing me until the back of my knees hit the bed and I have nowhere to run and hide. "I want to watch you

take it like a good boy, and come all over yourself when I stroke your cock while I fuck you.”

The whimper that leaves my lips is pathetic and I know she loves it by the way a sinister smile takes over her face. “It’s clean. You can use it now if you want,” I tell her and it comes out breathy and pleading.

“Look at you, so needy to be fucked. Where’s the lube, baby?”

When I signal to the night table, she retrieves it with graceful movement. A predator about to play with her prey. She’s never been this sure of herself, this magnificent. And I’m the lucky fucker who gets to be owned by her. The weight of the responsibility would make a lesser man crumble but once she’s done owning my body, I’ll be the one holding her hand on her journey to get better. And *that* is the privilege of my life.

Slowly, she opens the lid of the box and takes out its content, the black strap coming out first, then the silicon cock, also black. Marie doesn’t like colours so it wasn’t hard to choose. I watch as she reverently caresses the dildo and turns it into her hand, getting familiar with it. She locks it into place on the strap like she’s done it many times before and my mouth waters with need. I’ve often wondered what it would be like to take a cock inside my mouth, but never wanted to try it in real life, happy to leave it be a fantasy, a far away possibility.

She drops her towel and sets it aside on the nearby love seat, then takes three steps back, never breaking eye contact with me. My hands fists the sheets at my side as she steps into the strap and adjusts it to her thighs and hips.

She stands in her power, and there’s nothing else for me to do but drop to my knees and crawl the short distance between us, towel discarded behind me. When I settle at her feet, pure instincts and dark arousal guide us. She orients her cock towards my mouth and I greedily take it in between my lips.

“Fuck, you look so good with your mouth full,” she murmurs and I preen at the praise. “Give me a colour.”

I withdraw just enough to say “green” before taking her into my mouth again. My balls are heavy with the need to come again, the act of sloppily licking and sucking making me dizzy with lust. My hand inches closer to where I need it but Marie’s sinful voice whips through my foggy mind.

“Don’t touch your cock, baby. Your cum is mine, understood?” I nod best I can, caressing her legs instead, worshipping movements to satiate my

want. But it's not enough and I whine low.

Marie pulls away from my mouth and takes hold of my chin.

"Give me your safe-word again, baby," she asks softly, eyes glazed like I'm sure mine must be, too.

"Fire," I answer before she leans down and her tongue delves into my mouth, showing me who owns me. As if I'd ever forget. Her kiss consumes me.

"Good boy. Now, on the bed, on your back." Her command is soft and sweet, pouring love straight into my heart. Once I'm settled against the cushions and pillows, my dick at attention against my stomach, I wait. Anticipation is a powerful drug, making me squirm under Marie's watchful gaze. Her dark green eyes rove over my body agonisingly slowly but I don't make a move. Obedient and hers to command.

Finally, she closes the short distance to the bed. It dips with her weight as she crawls to settle in between my open legs. Our roles and positions are exactly the opposite of what we shared a few nights ago and it's not lost on me that in that vulnerable moment in between, I'm her equal. I can stop this anytime I want. I can change my mind. Or I can give myself over to her like she did me when I got inside her. I hope she won't run and self-destruct again like she did that time. The anxiety sends a cold shiver up my spine and Marie's hand reaches my cheek, bringing me back to the present moment. "You stop whenever you need."

I nod.

"You look so perfect for me, baby. Such a gift you're giving me. You're gonna let me own this body, aren't you?"

"Yes, Miss Marie."

"And you're gonna moan loud for me, letting me know how much you love it when I own that tight ass of yours?"

I let out a groan as she takes hold of my cock and squeezes. "Yes, Miss Marie."

The bottle of lube clicks open and Marie dribbles a generous amount on her fingers before dropping them down between us, rimming my puckered hole before she enters me with one digit, her other hand holding one of my legs up.

"Fuck," I gasp.

"You okay?"

"Yes. It's green. Just, go slow. I'm... it's a lot of new sensations."

She hums and smiles. I'm at her mercy and I wouldn't have it any other way. I adjust to the intrusion quickly, closing my eyes to feel how good the sensations taking over my body are. Pleasure coils low in my belly. I'm almost ready to come again. How many times can I come in one night if she keeps this up? I've never felt so mindless with desire, reduced to my baser instincts.

Marie introduces another finger inside me, moving in and out slowly, dragging this out for her pleasure. When I open my eyes again, she watches completely riveted where I swallow her fingers into my body. "You can take one more, can't you?" she asks, voice raspy with lust.

A moaning "Uh uh" is all I can let out and she grins, giving me what she promised. The fullness takes my breath away.

"Look at you, so fucking mindless and pathetic, taking my fingers like you were meant for it. You're gonna take that cock so well, I already know it. Are you ready, baby?"

Her dirty talk makes my cock leak with precum. I'm so ready I don't even understand why she isn't fucking me yet.

"I need you," I breathe and writhe as she withdraws and replaces her fingers with the lubed up silicon cock. I inhale sharply when she notches its thick head in and she waits patiently for me to relax before she gives me another inch. And another. And another. She continues her progression until her hips are flushed with mine.

Her breasts settle on my naked chest as she lands on my front and kisses me like I'm the air she needs. Biting and owning, she dominates me with her mouth and body. I'm so fucking full of her, but I need more.

"If you want me to fuck you, you better start begging."

"Please, Miss Marie. Please move. Please fuck me. I need it. I need your cock."

She repositions herself on her haunches, both hands holding my legs up and open then takes a tentative slow thrust that has me seeing stars. "Fuck —" She thrusts again, cutting me off.

Her mouth is dropped open, her tits bouncing softly with the short snaps of her pelvis. It hits the perfect spot inside me and I throw my head back, ready to let the orgasm take me.

I'm a mess of gargled noises and pleas, mindless with pleasure but Marie has something else in mind. She squeezes my cock painfully, just how I love it and I keen.

“The only way you’ll come is with your eyes on me, baby.”

Then, she fucks me.

Sharp thrusts inside my ass accompany the tight up and down motion of her hand on my cock. It’s all too much. I come up on my elbows but I don’t know where to look. Where she disappears inside me or her dainty hand owning me, then I remember what she said and look into her eyes. Dark pools of lust and love welcome me and I lose it.

I come in thick ropes all over my stomach and chest, some dripping over her hand, her name on my lips filling the silent room like a prayer. She withdraws and I’m left to catch my breath but not for long. She retrieves a small object from the night table and squeezes it between the strap and her pussy. The buzzing sound betrays its function before she enters me again and I cry out. Using my own cum to jerk me off, Marie gets me hard in minutes. I’ve already come twice and my dick is painful, which makes me harder, like she knows it would.

She tugs on my dick with harsh strokes that have me keening and forgetting my need to clean up. Nothing else matters but how hard Marie fucks me. I’m begging again for her to let me come, to fuck me harder. I’m not sure I make sense but I don’t care. Let me lose my mind if it’s with her.

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## MARIE

NEW ADDICTION



I've never seen anything as hot as Nico taking the silicon cock into his ass and begging me to let him come. I'm mesmerised as I watch his face contort in pleasure. The tip of his cock shines with the mix of his previous release and precum. I want it on my tongue.

I slow my movements and let go of him.

"We're gonna move, baby. I'm gonna lie back and you'll be on top. You're gonna be a good boy for me and ride that dick."

"Yes, yes, yes."

"So greedy," I chuckle. No matter what I suggest, he'd say yes, especially as I squeeze his cock and his expression morphs from tightness and pain to pleasure. "Let me clean you up first. Don't move."

With the strap secured proudly around my hips, I go to the bathroom and quickly retrieve a soft washcloth to clean Nico's stomach and hands.

"Give me a colour," I order because I need to take care of him. I know how overwhelming this moment could be for him. I want it to be a memory he'll keep forever.

"So fucking green, Marie."

Coming up onto his elbows, he threads his fingers through the strands of my black hair and pulls my head to his. It's a break in character but I don't mind. I kiss his cheeks and his throat, holding it with force as a reminder of who owns him. His little pants feed the hunger inside me.

Carefully so I stay inside him, we switch positions and I lay on my back while he straddles me. The low grunt escaping from his chest is primal and makes me feral.

“You’re so fucking deep,” he whines and I slap his ass playfully. It won’t sting but now I have a new idea for the next time we do this.

“And you fucking love it. Now shut up and ride that dick, baby. Let me hear you.”

He’s a masterpiece above me, rolling his hips like the slut I know he can be, taking me deeply inside him. His tattoos glint with sweat, a tableau of black and grey made of crying angels, and cunning demons. No inch of skin is left blank except under his left pec. Enough space for my name. The thought has me gripping his thigh with one hand and throat with the other, possession the only thing left between us. He’s shown me this new side of myself I didn’t even know existed and the gratitude I feel mixed with the devotion and love I have for this man goes straight to my head.

“You’re so perfect.” I keep praising him, saying in all the words but the one I can’t say yet. How much I love him, how much he means to me.

My eyes finally drop to his erect cock, bobbing in between us, purple with need and I know I have him exactly where I want him. I ask him to pause and slide a hand in between us, clicking the vibrator stuck between the strap and my clit on. The vibrations have us both gasping and I can’t help but laugh as I realise he can also feel the vibrations and he’s not gonna last.

“I told you your cum belongs to me didn’t I?”

“Yes, you did, Miss Marie. Please let me come,” he begs on a low rasp. “Let me come, let me come.” His chant continues as he gets himself off, moving up and down on top of me, hands on the headboard for support. My orgasm draws near, the vibrator and the pure satisfaction of seeing Nico so owned by me a heady cocktail going straight to my pussy.

I grow wet and messy, wishing I could get him inside me to clench around when I come. There’s always a next time, my brain murmurs. Nico’s movements get quicker and his cries louder. I take his cock in my hand and lean forward on my other elbow, licking the head and stroking him where my lips can’t reach. His taste is all I need as I fall apart, my hips jerking and adding to Nico’s pleasure.

“Oh fuck, Marie!”

I open my mouth and stick out my tongue. Our eyes meet as his cum hits my tongue, chin and chest. The amber of his eyes has given way to raw love and pure awe. We both fight not to close our eyes, too taken by euphoria, as he comes all over me, watching where he paints me in his release. It's filthy and I can't get enough.

When he's fully done, I swipe my fingers through the mess and bring them to my mouth, moaning. If I can't get his cum inside me, I always want it in my mouth and on my tits. It's making me hot all over again and the vibrations of the toy send me into another orgasm. This time, I throw my head back as I scream his name until his lips fall on me to swallow the sound.

Overstimulated, I fumble to click the vibrator off and let out a deep sigh.

Nico's weight over me disappears for a moment and then, a warm washcloth grazes my skin, cleaning me up. I should be the one doing that. Taking care of him, making sure he gets all the aftercare he needs. This was intense for both of us.

"Let me take care of you, *luna mia*. That makes me feel happy and important. When you let me care for you."

I nod and swallow thickly. I know Nico too much. He didn't only mean letting him take care of me after sex. And that's the hardest part. After years of being ignored and dismissed, feeling like I didn't have a place, becoming the centre of his life and attention is jarring. I still can't believe I deserve it.

But my body and mind are floating in a place where these worries have less of an anchor and I let him. "You did so well, baby. You were so hot," I tell him, caressing his cheek after he cleaned my hands thoroughly. His soft smile and crinkly eyes make my heart squeeze.

"You should have seen yourself, *luna mia*. Owning me so perfectly. I'm gonna have the best sleep of my life. I feel a little loopy."

"We should get Ember and come right back to bed. You can paint tomorrow morning. I'd like it if you could hold me through the night. It would make me feel less on edge," I admit the last part on a whisper.

I don't mind that Nico comes and goes at night. He's been a night owl for years and old habits die hard but after what we shared, I don't want to wake up and not have him close by. He's the reassuring presence I want around me when the demons that hide under my bed try to claim me. When the doubt will become too loud and wake me up from sleep, when alcohol

will seem like the God-given solution, I want him to be here so I can share my struggle and he can appease me like he's done so many times before.

"Am I to become your new addiction, Miss Marie?" Nico asks against my lips.

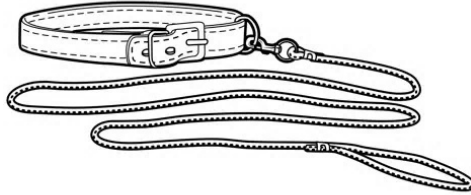
"Yes, and I don't ever want to get sober."

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## NICO

SOUL RIPPER



Is this what some people call marital bliss?

I spend my days between helping my brother run his Empire, tracking Misha Petrov and his goons down, and my nights between the thighs of the woman I love. In between are breaks with the cutest child I've ever seen. Granted, I have never seen any but she's the cutest one for sure. Every day, Ember and Marie make me feel more like the man I knew I could be. I'm not good by any means of the word, but I'm theirs. I'm still tainted by my past but I've turned my need to atone into something good, helping Marie get better and raising my little girl to be the most fierce person I will ever know.

When my phone rings and the number shows Aleksei Dobrev, my hackles rise. I pick up and don't greet him. He can tell me right away what's wrong, I don't have time for pleasantries like my brother.

"Nico, can you hear me?" he asks.

"Yes, Dobrev, loud and clear. What do you want?"

He tsks but continues. "I called Andrea but he's not answering. I left him a message. I know where Barychev is."

Barychev is Misha's second in command, second best to the kingpin himself. He was the one who abducted Alana Moretti last year and orchestrated the exchange between her and her bodyguard, Igor, who happened to be Misha's brother. I know Lana and Julian will want to make

him pay for stealing someone they love from them, but the bastard is as elusive as Misha himself so we need to act fast.

“Send me the location.”

“Nico, he’s meeting with the Amsterdam Bratva in a secluded location in the Cotswolds. You’ll need reinforcement. I’m coming with you. We don’t have time to wait for Andrea to wake his ass up or stop fucking his wife.”

“Watch your fucking mouth.” My voice is a promise of pain but Aleksei is unfazed and hangs up. A chime rings, and the location loads onto my car’s dashboard. I veer and change routes. I’m just an hour away.

Barychev could have met the European Bratva leaders anywhere but he chose to do it on our territory, nagging us, taunting us with his presence. Red is all that fills my vision as vivid images of what I’ll do to him enter my brain and refuse to leave. The all too familiar blood lust and promise of violence boils inside me. I crack my neck to the right then left and take calming breaths through my nose. When I check my speed barometer, I’m way over the limit and take my foot off the gas. No way I’m getting pulled over when hunting has just begun.

I have no idea how many people I’m about to face but I trust Dobrev to do that work for me. I’m usually the one you call to exact justice, not the strategist. There’s nothing that irritates me more than waiting and planning. I snort to myself as it reminds me how good I am at following orders, in and out of the bedroom. I never made the connection until then.

Picking up my phone, I dial Marie’s number but before the call can connect, the screen turns black. I’m frozen in place, dread a living breathing creature inside my chest demanding attention. A honk blares next to me and I bring both hands back to the steering wheel and my eyes on the road, veering before I collide with the car next to me.

Fuck.

“Fuck, fuck, fuck!” I yell into the cab of my car, punctuating each expletive with a punch to the wheel. Not that it fucking helps.

I dart towards the glove compartment but it’s empty. She took my charger when I dropped her off a few days ago. I have no way of contacting her. I have no way to tell her I’ll be there soon.

Not caring about anything but dealing with this bullshit anymore, I speed off towards my target in silence. The air is charged with my

darkening thoughts and I suffocate under the weight of my own recklessness. That's how my father got killed.

This is history repeating itself. If Marie hurts herself because she couldn't reach me when she needed... I try and fail not to think about that. About how similar the ending could be. About how I'm the one who opened the door of our home ten years ago to let in a man I thought was my father's second in command, his most trusted ally. My parents were not home, but I knew the man. He knew me. The vivid memory of his sly smile as he entered, clasped my shoulder and moved towards my father's office sends a chill down my spine. I'm driving but I'm sent back then. He was in there less than five minutes before I pushed the ajar door fully open and asked him to leave since my father wouldn't be back for another few hours.

"You're right, kid. No need for me to wait here while your parents come home. I'll see them tomorrow for dinner, eh?" He had said. It was not a question despite the intonation of his voice. I guided him through the house. As a goodbye, he patronisingly slapped my cheek. Three times. "Sleep tight." I should have known something was wrong by the giddy way he had said that. But I hadn't been as observant of other's behaviours back then. I was still grappling with what was 'normal' or suspicious, what was left unsaid when someone spoke and why did people never said what they really meant with their words, but betrayed themselves with their bodies.

That night, as we all slept soundly, a fire started in my father's office. The house was consumed quickly, a beam breaking over my mother's body, snapping her spine and leaving her without the use of her legs. My father and I carried her out but he inhaled too much smoke and died at the hospital. He wasn't even injured. He died and I lived though we were both in and out of the house at the same time. Andrea met us at the hospital. Too late.

With his skills for cybersecurity and my need for revenge, it wasn't hard to track the man who did it. The way I made him bleed and hurt for five days straight, cutting each piece of his body carefully so he would stay alive, drugging him with stimulants so he couldn't pass out or rest, sleeping myself only one hour at a time because I was so consumed with rage, is one of my fondest memories. He was my first painting.

I reminisce and oscillate between blinding white hot rage and calculated cold all the way until I reach what looks like an abandoned farmhouse. After parking two miles away, far enough to not draw any attention and

hidden from the main road, I change into the black clothing I always keep in my trunk and take the pre-prepared backpack from there. It contains a few of my favourite tools and a painter's suit, my soft cashmere balaclava—the only one on the market that doesn't irritate my skin and makes me want to claw it raw—and my trusted gun and its silencer.

I have no way of knowing where Dobrev and his teams are. I can't wait to deal with the vermin who think they can keep me away from my girls but I can't get in there without any reconnaissance. I walk the perimeter of the farmhouse on silent feet. It takes me barely twenty minutes to find Dobrev, his new ally Dante Ventura and—unsurprisingly since she follows her brother everywhere—Irina, hidden in the bushes with three of their men.

"If it were anyone else but me, you'd be fucking dead," I say and they all whirlwind, guns pointed at my chest. I roll my eyes. "Fucking amateurs."

"You called the Capaldi dog?" Irina squeaks but I ignore her. She doesn't matter to me, and insults have always glided on my skin like wind. The only opinions that matter to me are from the people I love.

"Be nice," Ventura tells Irina and she glares at him, which makes him grin like a lunatic. I'm not about to burden myself with understanding their interaction.

"I need your phone," I tell Aleksei and hold my hand expectantly.

"We left all devices but this in the cars."

He holds out an earpiece to me and I put it on, clicking my tongue. We need to get going with this operation because every minute I'm away from Marie without her knowing why I'm not answering my damn phone is a minute that could bring her closer to the edge. My recklessness could cost me yet another person I love and I refuse to let that happen. I won't survive it.

"What's the status?" I ask. It sounds like a bark even to my ears but I don't have time to give a shit or be polite.

"Barychev and four of his best men. Amsterdam's pakhan, his second in command and two of their soldiers."

"Seven to their eight, I'd say it's reckoning day," Dante jokes and Irina hisses at him.

The next half hour is a blur, the element of surprise a considerable advantage.



We storm the farmhouse, two of our enemies immediately down from our bullets. Irina takes down two more men, one with a bullet straight to the head and the Amsterdam packman with a knife directly jerked into his eye. It's savage and blood sprays on her alabaster face.

"Fuck, she's hot," Dante says loud enough for everyone to hear and I grimace. I don't need to know his lustful thoughts. But even I can admire Irina's skills. Not that much of an air-head after all. Giulia and her might have more in common than my sister-in-law thinks, but I won't tell her that. I value my tongue too much.

Bullets wheeze around us and force us to take cover, but Aleksei's sniper skills are not match for Barychev's last two standing men. I advance on him where he crouches behind a makeshift barricade. Before I can get to him, the bastard stands and shoots directly at me. My body bows back with the force of the impact, my right shoulder immediately on fire. Something sticky and warm flows on my front and when I look down, I see that it's my own blood.

Fuelled by rage so hot it burns through the pain, I stand and press my hand from my valid arm on top of where the bullet grazed the side of my shoulder. I ignore the wetness of the wound and take the knife from its holster at my thigh. Determined steps get me in front of a crouched Barychev, who uselessly presses the trigger, his gun empty and his eyes flaming with fear. I slash the knife across his face and he yelps in pain.

"Tie him up," I order no one specifically, and one of Dobrev's men execute my command in seconds. I'm barely aware of the dead bodies around us, blood pouring on the floor like the perfect ink for my next canvas.

"Sit down," Irina barks but I don't even look at her, keeping my gaze fixed on my prey. With a heavy press on my shoulders, I'm seated and alcohol is poured on my shoulder, bringing my attention to Aleksei and Irina, working in tandem around me.

"Don't touch me," I bark and Dobrev removes his hand immediately, holding them up in surrender.

"Well, I'll need to touch you to stitch you up, you moron," Irina says as hands me a piece of wood and pours alcohol on her hands. "Bite this."

"I'm not putting this in my mouth," I tell her.

"Your loss," she says and it's the only warning I get before a needle pierces my skin and Irina ties a couple of stitches around the wound, sealing

it shut.

Fire holds me captive, radiating from my shoulder, where I can feel Irina's touch, all the way to my chest and legs. I hate it but direct it to Barychev as a reminder of why I'm here. I refuse to pass out even as white edges my vision and stars dance around me. I've known pain before. This is just a short halt until I can get back to my girls. I keep my gaze trained on my enemy. He's the reason I'm here. He's the reason I'm away from Marie and Ember. He's the reason I'm in pain. And he'll pay for it ten fold.

Irina steps back a few moments later. The breath I take tastes cold and fills me with renewed energy. Painkillers are shoved down my throat, followed by a burning clear liquid that I cough half out. "No alcohol," I sputter and spit. The makeshift bandage on my shoulder feels wrong, scratching the unblemished skin around the wound.

"You're still bleeding, take a break, *amico*," Dante says but I ignore him.

Standing, adrenaline making me feel invincible, I walk to Barychev, tied and gagged on a chair in the middle of the room we're all in, his allies dead at our feet.

"You know what I should be doing right now?" I ask him. It's rhetorical but he shakes his head nonetheless, a mix of fear and arrogance flickering in his beady eyes. It hasn't registered that he will die in pain yet. That's what always happens and I usually don't delay the inevitable but now, I feel unhinged, unleashed, untethered. "Fucking a baby into my woman until everyone knows she's mine and I'm hers. But instead, I'm stuck here with you."

An unhinged laughter escapes my throat and my victim shudders, closing their eyes as if I'm an illusion, a nightmare that won't be there when he opens them up again. Too bad I am very real and ready to exact my revenge. "You're keeping me away so, *you*, my friend, are going to suffer. Now, tell me where Misha Petrov hides and I'll consider making it shorter."

I take hold of his jaw and carve a hole in both cheeks, sticking the useless pieces of his skin into his throat. Eventually, he swallows then throws up all over himself. I jump back just in time and put on the painter's suit in a frenzy. My movements are jerky and uncoordinated but I don't care. I also don't care that I have an audience. I stuck the piece of wood Irina wanted me to bite into right through the two holes of Barychev's

cheeks. It opens his mouth just enough for me to grab hold of his tongue with pliers I had in my backpack.

“We need Petrov’s location, idiot,” I hear Irina yell in the background.

Hot rage pours through my body feeling my need for vengeance and pain. I’m breathing hard but removes the pliers from Barychev’s mouth, focusing once more on my goal.

With the only two knives I had in my backpack, I carve and slice and dissect, pausing enough to repeat my questions. I don’t have any of the stimulants I’d need for Barychev to stay awake and present long enough so I use all the intimidating techniques in my arsenal to make him cave. And I don’t have to force the terrifying way I must look, crazed and dressed for slaughter. I flay half the skin of his face before threatening to go to a place no man want to be threatened with. Barychev’s eyes roll into their sockets.

“*Amicio*, slow down. He’s gonna fucking croak before we get what we need.” Dante’s approaching in my periphery and I turn round, bloody knives in hand, tapping the butt of the handles against my legs frenetically. *One, two, three. One, two, three.*

“Shut up! Shut up! Shut up!”

Marie needs me. I need to make that man pay for keeping me away from her. My breaths come out laboured, sweat dripping down my back inside the plastic of the suit, and I know it’s blood I feel lazily dripping down my forearm almost to my wrist. I shake my head and close my eyes but I don’t see a way out. I turn back to Barychev.

What he sees in me has him white as a sheet. He caves and whispers a coordinate. As well as a prayer for death. Though I’m not ready to give it.

“*Fratello*.” My brother’s voice filters through my haze and I turn. Impeccably dressed in a burgundy suit, his hair in a bun, he looks so out of place but he doesn’t care walking through all the blood splattered around me. I’m about to turn back to my victim when he lands a hand on my shoulder and I hiss in pain.

“What happened to you?” he asks, lifting his hand up again, concern filtering through his words.

“Bullet wound. Irina stitched me up,” I answer and Andrea glances at her with a deep frown before refocusing on me again. I’m heaving, ready to end Barychev with a slow, painful death, succumbing to my meltdown, but my brother’s words stop me.

“Marie’s not good, *fratellino*. You need to get your shit together and come back to West Hill. Now.”

Like a magic word, I snap out of whatever trance I was in. Barychev’s imploring eyes connect with mine. He mouths “please” and I nod, walking away. My brother’s gun echoes around us but I’m halfway out of there, pawing at the plastic suit desperately. I drive back to my home, my brother hot on my heels. I hope I’m on time.

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## MARIE

IL SANGUE NON È ACQUA



**M**y phone rings with an incoming call as soon as I arrive home after my afternoon of socialising with Giulia and Catalina. As much as I love them both, sometimes I wish I knew how to drive so I could make my escape sooner. I took up crochet and like a little old lady, I'm excited to come back to what I've been knitting, occupying my hands as I wait for Nico.

I almost groan at the image it creates in my head. I'm twenty-years-old and all I'm dreaming about is curling under a blanket, knitting while I wait for my boyfriend to be home. Feminist icons must die a little all over the world but that's what makes me warm and fuzzy. It's either that or the BDSM mastery guide book I'm reading on my phone like a thief in the night. After our night at Absolution, the book was left on the side table and I sneaked a picture while Nico wasn't looking. I suspect Damian left it there for me. I shouldn't feel secretive about it, Nico wouldn't judge me, but I like that it's something I'm doing for him as a sort of surprise.

The part of my brain that hates me reminds me that I will be useless when Nico finally realises what a burden I am and kicks me out. He might even take Ember from me. He's very attached to her and wants what's best for her. We both know it isn't me.

With that gloomy frame of mind, I pick up the call, greeted by my mother's gentle voice. "Happy birthday, *picculina*," she says and I swear

there's tears forming at the corner of her crinkled eyes even though I can't see her. "You've been avoiding me."

Shit, how did time escape me so much that I didn't realise today's October 23rd? It's gonna be my first birthday by myself. My first birthday without her. My full-of-life, too-naughty-for-her-own-good sister.

With the haven of peace that Nico offers, I've pushed thoughts of my family and of my grief in the deep recesses of my mind. But now, they rear up their ugly heads like monsters under my bed, ready to tear me to shreds. Every time, my mother's sweet voice, my father's kind eyes or my sisters' advice—most of the time unsolicited—came to mind, shame and the intense need to drive myself into a state of total oblivion took over. So I've stopped completely. My coping mechanism isn't healthy by any means but I don't know how else to stop myself from drinking.

Just thinking about drinking makes me want to raid Giulia and Andrea's cellar. Especially today. Unfortunately I can't text the only person who can help me because my phone is currently occupied.

"I haven't been avoiding you, Mama," I lie, putting her on speaker and propping the phone up so I can switch on the camera and take the winter jacket off of Ember. She's been so fussy lately, whining every time I pick her up, crying at night while she used to be so quiet. I sometimes wonder if now that she feels more secure with the people surrounding her, she's using that little voice of hers to finally have her needs met.

"You have, *picculina*, but that's okay. Giulia told me you're doing fine."

"You called Giulia?" I ask with outrage.

She didn't mention it. Once again, my own flesh and blood thought I was better not knowing things that concern me. I fist the little jacket and clench my teeth before I release an annoyed breath and try to shake the distrust building through my veins. It's always the same bullshit with the Morettis. I'm too young, too naive, too soft. Whatever they say about me that makes them decide for me like I'm not my own person, capable of making my own decisions and choosing for myself. Nico would never do that to me. "You know what? It doesn't matter. Thank you for the wishes but I gotta go."

"I miss you, Marie. I miss Ember. It's your birthday and Lisa isn't here. And you're not here. I was wondering when you're coming back."

Her voice breaks and I freeze for a second before I place Ember on the rug in front of me with her toys and pick up the phone in my hand again.

Settling with my legs underneath me on the couch, I look at my daughter, the weight of failing at being a good mother and a good daughter weighing me down until I'm crushed under all the expectations.

"I'm sorry, Mama, but I don't know. I like it here."

"*Picculina*... Ember needs family around her."

I don't tell her that she does. She *is* surrounded by family. Nico acts like a father to her, Andrea is smitten with her, Catalina is as good a grandmother as I know my mother would love to be, and Giulia might not like children in general, but she likes Ember enough to ask to be the one holding her whenever we're together. She showers her with little attentions, and hugs and gifts. But my mother is right as well. Ember needs stability and community. Can the Capaldi provide as well as my family did?

"I don't know," I repeat, my head dropping down. I'm thrown back to being a lost teenage girl who doesn't know what to do.

"Come back before Christmas, *picculina*. *Mammona* isn't getting any younger and she deserves to know Ember."

My chin wobbles and I nod. I know she doesn't mean it as a ploy to get me there. She isn't manipulating me into doing her bidding, but it still feels wrong to leave.

After that tense exchange, we barely talk. My mother asks asinine questions about what I've been doing and I don't have a good enough answer for her. "Rest" doesn't seem like a good reason to stay away from my family for months. It reminds me that I'm nowhere near understanding what I want to do with my life. Despite contemplating being a stay-at-home mum, it's unreasonable. Lana wouldn't approve. My parents wouldn't approve.

I don't know what Lisa would think about that. Since all she wanted was to become a mother, maybe she'd be the only one encouraging me. Fresh tears blur my vision and Ember immediately wails from her place on the rug, sensitive to my emotions and throwing a little coloured block she was just playing with. She's better at expressing herself than I am. I pick her up and rock her body against mine, shushing her and caressing her little head. It makes her bawl even harder, a mirror to my grief. Can she feel the void Lisa left behind as acutely as I can?

Am I making her cry by projecting my own pain? I sober at the thought that I might be giving my innocent little daughter all the hurt I contain in my own broken heart. I read an article about generational trauma the other

day and I know for a fact, I'm fucked up and not setting her up for the perfect life I want for her. Swallowing my tears and burrowing the shame deeper into my entrails, I calm her down but not without difficulty, and hang up with my mother.

When she's bathed, changed and sleeping in her cot, I finally text Nico.

ME

So, turns out, it's my birthday today. It makes me want to drown in whiskey. Are you home soon?

BITING MY NAILS, I put on a movie and wait for his response but after half an hour, it still doesn't come. The message hasn't even been delivered.

I sit up straight and pause the film. The call to Giulia goes straight to voicemail. Fuck, she told me she was going to London tonight for a meeting. I try Andrea next, but he's not picking up either.

My breathing picks up. Worst case scenarios turn my vision into nightmares. Variations of Nico bleeding on the floor, his wide dead eyes looking through me without seeing me, flash behind my eyelids. Open or closed, all I see is his death. My throat dries until it's hard to swallow. If only I could calm the fire inside with that tormenting liquid my body craves. Water won't help, I don't even reach for a glass above the sink.

My body sinks to the floor and I pull my legs into me, back against the kitchen counter. The rocking back and forth movement doesn't help. I'm spiralling. My ears are straining to hear Ember's cries or Nico's keys inside the door fob. But all that filters through are gunshots that aren't here, hitting the same spot where his healed wounds are. This time, they didn't miss. This time, he doesn't wake up. Blood pours from the wounds into a puddle underneath him. The dark crimson spreads wider.

Wider.

Wider.

"Marie," a voice says close to me but it could be on the other side of the property for how far it seems. "Marie," the voice grows louder. Someone shakes my shoulders and I look up, as if through a daze. Red billowing hair and eyes as green as mine filled with concern and fear. I reach to touch Giulia's face who gets on her knees in front of me.

"Where is Nico?" my voice is raw, the sound coming out croaked.



“I’ve tried to call you but you weren’t picking up.” She ignores my question, frantically checking me for injury. “What happened?”

“Where is he, Giulia?”

I’m bracing for the sentence. I’ve been here before, I know how much it will hurt. I think this time, it might kill me. But I need to know all the same.

“He’s in the Cotswolds with the Dobrevs. They caught Misha’s second in command and they needed his expertise.”

Relief is short-lived. He’s alive.

And he didn’t call me.

He didn’t tell me where he was going or that he wouldn’t come home to me and Ember. Like I knew he would, he’s trying to escape me.

“His phone died, Marie. But he’s okay. He’ll be here soon.”

“What?”

“His phone died. He tried to get a hold of you but I guess the mission didn’t go as planned. I’m not sure what happened down there. Andrea left with the helicopter and went to pick him up.”

Her words are making sense but the meaning isn’t registering. My tired brain wants its usual relief. I drop my head back and let go, hoping she can help me like Nico did. I can’t do this one on my own. I can’t keep fighting the demons inside me.

“I’m an alcoholic, Giulia. And right now, I’m fighting against raiding your house for my fix. I just hallucinated for probably an hour or two until you found me.” My voice cracks on the last words.

I tentatively gaze up. Giulia’s face isn’t hardened like I thought it would. And her first words are not to ask if I’m fit to take care of Ember or if I hurt her. That’s what I would ask if I were her. Because I can’t be trusted any longer. How long was I imagining Nico’s death? I don’t think I heard her cry and I can’t now but it’s only a matter of time before I either pass out from drinking—because I *will* find a way to drink—or have another whatever-the-fuck-that-was episode.

“What do you need, Mimi?” she asks softly. The little nickname the only two people I love more than my own life used for me is a balm I didn’t expect.

“I can’t wait for Nico to be back. I need you to drive me to this address.”

I pick up my phone and show her the pinned location on the map.

Her eyes widened and her brow creases. “Are you sure? What about Ember?”

I don’t answer and type instead. The phone she’s holding in her hand chimes with an email. In it, she will find the temporary custody agreement I had Andrea’s lawyer, Luca deRossi, draft for me. As her godparents, Giulia and Andrea will have custody of Ember if Nico can’t take care of her. But I know he will.

“Marie,” she breathes my name and my throat clogs with too many repressed emotions. I’m at my breaking point, seeing Lisa in Giulia’s features. My body starts to tremble and she hugs me tight to her chest. “Come on, take whatever you need. I’ll drive you. Just so you know, Nico isn’t going to be happy about this. Are you sure you want to blindside him like this?”

I clasp my hands on her forearms, urgent and frantic.

“I need to do this for *me*. And for Ember. Tell me you understand, Gigi.”

Her forehead drops to mine. “Il sangue non è acqua.”

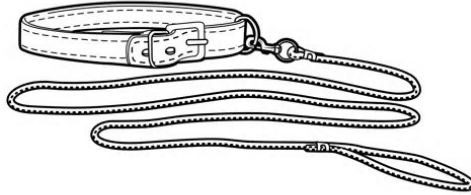
*Blood is thicker than water.*

I know she means it as a vow. I repeat it, just for her. She nods and helps me up. We pick up a sleeping Ember and an hour later, I check myself into the Nightingale Rehab Centre.

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## NICO

THEY'RE DESTINED TO LEAVE ME, AND I, TO FAIL THEM



“Marie,” I yell her name as I push the door to my cabin open.  
It’s eerily silent. Empty. Void of her.

But the information isn’t registering in my brain.

The door of her bedroom rebounds against the wall when I enter. Even though we never go to what used to be my bedroom, I collapse against the wooden door. Still no traces of her. The bathroom is quiet and still. I stomp to my workshop, my cotton tee-shirt clinging to my skin where sweat gathers under the fabric. The fresh wound at my shoulder oozes blood and thumps with the erratic rhythm of my heart.

Dread fills my veins faster than any drug, but I forge on.

The lock and chains to the barn are undisturbed but denial is a possessive force. I take the key from my pocket and slide the door open. Switching on all the lights, the mirrors in the workroom reflect my fear right back at me. And nothing else.

“Nico,” a voice calls behind me. I recognise it but I don’t turn, lost to the demons taking hold of my rational thoughts. My fingers erratically tap on my legs. My tongue flicks my piercing back and forth but my usual self-soothing tactics aren’t fucking working.

“Nico,” the voice calls out again, louder this time.

Giulia stands at the threshold of the room, a little bundle in her arms. I stalk to her but she takes a step back, her hand in front of her and Andrea appearing at her side like he could protect her if I really wanted to hurt her

and take what's mine. I ball my fists to the point of pain, the indent of my nails welling blood on their way inside my skin.

"Give me my daughter," I order my sister-in-law in a voice I don't recognise.

"You need to calm down first."

"Don't tell me to calm down when Marie's gone! Give me my daughter." I enunciate each word as if that will sway her but she's the fierce protector, nothing like the soft woman she can be with me. I can't even admire it as unease creeps up my skin and a pathetic sound escapes my lips. "Please, give her to me."

"Nico." My name sounds like it hurts. "I can't do that right now," Giulia says.

"Do you think I would hurt her?"

"No, of course not. But I want to tell you where Marie is and when I do, I don't know how you'll react. Ember is my responsibility and my priority right now."

I bring my hands to my short hair and pull at the roots, closing my eyes and trying to ignore the call for blood that has my temples throbbing. "What does that mean?"

"It means Marie gave me custody of Ember for the time being. While she recovers. I need you to do what you have to do to come down from this state you're in. Then I can tell you where she is, and give you Ember."

It's reasonable. Logical. I know it is but I still can't process her words. All I want is red to consume everything around me. I need pain. Inflicting it and all over my skin.

"Leave," I finally say.

They both hesitate but after a minute, they turn their back on me, closing the door to the workroom. In the absence of a prey to skin and mutilate, I take a blank canvas. On the palette I mix shades of red and white. Then I take a knife in my tool display and slash my arm. Crimson bleeds on my skin and I shiver at the sensation. But I don't try to quell the blood from flowing.

And I paint. With my bare hands.

I've never used colour before but the red soothes me. The texture under my fingers is squishy and foreign. I hate every second of it, the wetness on my hands and the burning chemical scent in my nose mixed with the copper of blood. It's a punishment I can take for being so careless.

I fill three canvases with images of Marie. The lines are rough, the edges coarse. Textures create valleys of paint where I usually leave it all flat. The three dimensional paintings make me sick but the images I create give me purpose. It's all messed up in my head and I yell into the void of the room as I continue my ritual-punishment.

When I look up again, the sun is rising outside. I've been here for five hours, without sleep or food or water. My body cries for all of it, but I refuse to give in. Sustenance is wasted on me. I failed her like I failed my father. This time by my absence. She left because she knew I couldn't do what I promised. And she lied. Told me all I wanted to hear and left anyway.

No matter what I do, the people I love most will always end up suffering at my hands.

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## JULIAN

“THIS FAMILY MAKES ME WANT TO MURDER PEOPLE”

My skin buzzes with an excitement I haven’t felt for... fuck—a long time. It was late last night when Andrea Capaldi rang Lana’s phone to tell her Barychev died, Misha Petrov’s location as his last words.

Daydreams of blood, retribution and violence flash through my open eyes as Lana, my brother Lisandru, and I fly over the Channel. We’re set to land in twenty minutes in a private airport North of West Hill, and I’m almost squirming in my seat. Logically, I know there won’t be much for me to do but strategise with everyone when we arrive, but hopefully, I can go on a hunt with Nico and drain my dark energy before the main event happens. I’ve never seen him at work but his reputation as the literal angel of Death in the UK precedes him, and I need the outlet.

I ignore my brother and my best friend, whispering sweet nothings to each other in their seats in front of me. In the past fifteen months since my husband was taken from me, I’ve had a lot of practice. Because these two assholes always have their tongues down each other’s throat, for fuck’s sake. Not caring that some of us have blue balls and don’t particularly enjoy their disgusting PDA.

“You two are gross, you know that?” I interject because I can’t help myself.

“Fuck you, Jules, we’re just talking about what’s next,” Lana retorts but the tip of her ears are turning red. *Liar*. Lisandru’s smirk confirms it, and I roll my eyes.

I've always been a bit of a shit-stirrer. It's more fun to rile people up than to butter them up with what they want to hear. However, since I lost Igor, all my worst habits have become pure vice. The worst part is no one says shit because they pity me. They don't know what to say to make me feel better.

They can't, anyway.

Igor, my boyfriend since I turned eighteen, the only man I've ever loved, the one I married in secret almost two summers ago—and Lana's bodyguard—is gone and nothing anyone says can change that. Worse part is, he knows I'm looking for him and is pushing me away, sending us the heads of any informer we send towards where he's being sighted.

A head in a box. What a cliché. If he thinks that's gonna deter me. I huff to myself at the thought. I don't give a fuck how many men I send to their death if it means he'll come back to me.

The seatbelt sign turns on in the cabin and we all click them in place, the descent making my ears pop. On the tarmac, Andrea and Giulia welcome us, Nico not far behind and looking more grim than he ever did before.

"What happened to you?" I probe with a frown.

"Fuck you," he answers gruffly before turnings on his heels and disappearing inside his Aston Martin Valhalla.

"I thought you Italians were supposed to be warm and welcoming, Capaldi."

My joke falls flat and I watch Andrea and Giulia exchange an uneasy look. They seem to be having a silent conversation and the longing that's carving my heart out of my chest threatens to send me to my knees.

"Shut up, you little shit." Giulia hugs me tight, reminding me of a time when Lana, her and I were inseparable, the three musketeers of Kalliste. Concern is etched on her beautiful face, the dark circles under her eyes so unlike her. Giulia's always well rested and ready to take on the world. I don't know what's going on but even as self-centred as I am and focused on my goal, the heaviness surrounding the Capaldis is hard to miss.

"Come on, we have to act quickly," Andrea says and we enter his sedan, before he drives us through snowy forest and country roads.



I WHISTLE as we cross the threshold to Giulia and Andrea's house. The rustic exterior is a damn lie because the interior is all warm wood and sharp furnitures, contrasting perfectly to give it a modern cottage atmosphere that perfectly balances luxury and cosiness.

"You didn't lie when you said his home was made for cottage sluts like you," I tell Giulia and Andrea growls behind me, not too happy with me calling his wife a slut. Her words, not mine, though. She laughs easily, a hand on her husband's shoulder and he settles immediately. Can *one* interaction in this godforsaken family not end with the reminder that my husband is missing?

*Jesus Christ.*

We follow them towards what must be their office, the soft rug and dark wood panels on the wall giving the room an aura of importance. It's very different from my utilitarian studio in the city centre of Sant Armellu, where everything is beige. The colourful throw pillows are at odds with the rest of the house but they scream '*Giulia*' so much. They've made a perfect home. Something I won't ever have again if we don't annihilate Misha Petrov and his whole operation.

I clap my hands before rubbing them together. "So. When do we fuck Misha's brains out?" I grimace. "Wrong choice of words. When do we kill the bastard?"

Andrea starts a lengthy explanation of how Misha's been cooped up in Moscow, paranoid about an assassination attempt, not only from us but in his own ranks. He's sent his most trusted advisors all throughout Europe to have the local Bratvas pledge allegiance to him, but it hasn't been as well received as he thought. The Dobrev-Ventura alliance has helped with getting more support from the Russian-Italians in Italy, the U.K. and Croatia, but we're still up against the rest of them. And it's a fuck ton of them.

"Dobrev's gonna marry the daughter of the French arm of the mafia so we can count them in as well," Giulia says, and Nico scoffs to himself like he knows something we don't. I ignore the grumpy asshole who looks like



he could kill with only one look and address my best friend. Lana has always been my rock. I should say “our” rock because she holds the weight of our entire Empire on her shoulders and carries it with grace, too.

“Now is the time when you lay out your plan, sis’.” She hates it when I call her that and immediately clicks her tongue, which makes me grin even wider. We’re practically brother and sister with how close we grew up. We might not share blood, but we share everything else. Including custody of her idiot husband, who happens to be my half-brother.

Right now, he sits next to her, a silent vigilante ready to guard her. I know he still beats himself up for her ordeal last year. No one blames him but he’s been even more protective with Lana ever since.

“When are Dobrev and Ventura gonna be here?” Lana ignores me and asks Andrea.

“I haven’t called them yet. It’s up to you. As much as Petrov is bad for business and his organisation needs to be dismantled, this is personal for you.” He turns his whiskey eyes to mine. Damn, he’s intense. “Both of you.”

Before we can continue, a baby cries in the distance and Lana sits up straighter, her brow furrowing. We all turn to the noise, but Nico’s already leaving the room like his ass is on fire.

“What’s Ember doing here?” Lana asks Giulia, an edge to her voice that would breed fear in the heart of grown men. I know her too well. That’s her threatening voice. It’s cold and calculating. Her eyes have hardened and she follows after Nico.

The entire party moves towards the living room where a woman in a wheelchair holds a bottle out to Nico who takes it, before he sits down and feeds Ember. The woman’s dark bob and severe features contrasting with warm honey eyes is the portrait of Andrea. It isn’t hard to deduce who she is, then she introduces herself as Catalina Capaldi. I dip my head respectfully and shake her outstretched hand. “Ignore me,” she starts. “I’m sure you have more important business to tend to.”

“Giulia, what is this? Where is Marie?” Lana asks, more frantic this time.

“Marie isn’t here,” Nico says without looking up. His piercing eyes are set on Ember and he holds her tight to his chest.

“Where, Nico?” Lana repeats, her tone hostile but he ignores her, absorbed by his task.

The energy around the room swerves and changes to cold and unrecognisable. There's nothing gentle and familial about the way Andrea stands next to his brother and mother, or how Giulia orients her body in front of them like she's picking their side. I let my eyes move from them to Lana and Lisandru. Her fists are clenched and he's holding her shoulders, but not in support, almost as if holding her back, his jaw tight, teeth grinding.

"Babe—" Giulia starts but Lana holds up a hand. These two are even closer than Lana and I have been, tied by blood and something uniquely theirs. They have a kinship, a bond that can never break. Yet, it's like I watch in slow motion the moment a fissure appears.

"Don't fucking lie to me, G."

"Marie's in rehab."

My eyes flick back to Giulia with surprise. I never thought that's a sentence I would hear.

"What? Since when?" Lana explodes, and fear takes hold because this little family reunion could go nuclear very quickly if Giulia doesn't answer properly.

"Since last night," she answers and has the good sense of looking stricken. "She needed help."

"And you didn't think to call me, then?" Lana yells and it startles Ember who starts to cry in Nico's arms. He rocks her softly, murmuring words I can't hear and kissing her little head. "I need to take care of my niece, and you need to tell me where she is." Lana stampedes toward them but both Andrea and Giulia step in front of her. Lana recoils and gasps.

The fissure cracks wider in the silent room, only punctuated by the infant's cries.

"What are you doing? If Marie is in rehab, Ember needs to be with her family. And I need to go see my sister."

"She is with family, Lana," Giulia says.

"You..."

"What? I don't count? Marie came here after Lisa's death and stayed, because she felt safe. How many times have you tried to call her?"

"Don't you fucking dare say shit like this, G," I tell her because I've had about enough of people trying to make Lana feel guilty for taking care of everyone around her and still coming short. That woman is holding an Empire by the strength of her teeth, a rock for her mother who cries herself

to sleep every night grieving her dead daughter and a missing one, while doing everything in her power to make women feel safe everywhere and finding my husband so we can bring him back to us. All the while dealing with her own PTSD and nightmares. “Lana’s here for everyone and you fucking know it.”

“Oh yeah?” Giulia scoffs, then turns to Lana. “Did you know your sister was an alcoholic? Since she was sixteen?”

I shake my head. That can’t be right. Sweet Marie wouldn’t do that. She’s surrounded by family. Loved, cherished, protected. Lana’s mouth hangs agape. When my eyes collide with my brother’s, he shakes his head subtly and I take a step back, letting what needs to happen next be, without interfering.

“I know you’re dealing with a lot, babe. Trust me, I know. More than you realise.” Giulia’s voice wavers at that and I have to wonder what she’s been through to share that kind of kinship with Lana. She approaches and clasps Lana’s hands in hers. “But Marie wasn’t well. And she trusted me, Andrea and Nico to take care of Ember, whether you like it or not. I won’t let her down, now. I hope you understand.”

“No, I don’t *fucking* understand,” Lana exclaims, her ire pouring out of her. “First, my own sister hides the fact that her twin has cancer and might die. And she fucking did! And now, she’s an alcoholic and let my niece in the care of...”

Giulia doesn’t let her finish and I’m grateful for it, because she’s not thinking straight. Pain will make you say shit you regret. I don’t want that pain on her.

“Shut up, Lana. Don’t finish that fucking sentence. We’re her family. Just because she isn’t my sister in blood doesn’t mean I love her any less. And Ember, she’s not yours. She’s Marie’s, who’s an adult and trusted us to care for her.”

Lana’s shoulders deflate. Her throat bobs, unshed tears brimming under her eyelashes, and her head shakes with disbelief. “I need to see her,” she says but it comes out uncertain. I hate to see her like that.

“She can’t have visitors for the first three weeks,” Catalina says, diplomatic and caring. “And, Lana. I don’t know you, so you’ll excuse me for saying this. I’m not sure if you should be her first visitor when she can receive people for the first time. She’s been through a lot.”

My friend simply nods, head bowed in defeat. “Can I ask why *you*?” I’m not sure if she’s asking Giulia but it’s Nico who answers.

“She’s safe with us. I’m hers,” he declares and the veil lifts. “And she’s mine.”

Lana nods again, a soft tip of her lips that doesn’t reach her eyes. “And Ember?”

“She’s mine, too,” Nico answers easily.

Lana’s lips purse and her chin wobble. Turning heels, she disappears the same way she came in. “I’ll talk to her,” Lisandru says before leaving with a dip of his head towards the Capaldi family.

I feel like an intruder and make my way out, but Giulia stops me with a hand on my forearm. “I’m sorry, Jules. I did what I think is best for Marie and Ember.”

“You’re a dick, you know,” I sigh.

“What?”

“I want to hate you right now. Take her side. But you have to be all chivalrous and selfless and shit. You piss me off, bitch.”

She threads her arms around my neck and I hold her to me, the hug settling the unease inside me. “Nico’s a good man. He almost died trying to save me”, she whispers in my ear.

I frown at that. “Save you from what?”

“That’s not important. They’re really good together. And he loves Ember.”

“Yeah, I can see that. He has the protective broody alpha act down,” I joke but it’s the truth. He’s not so different from Marie come to think of it. She’d much rather be sitting in silence than surrounded by the rowdy crowd we can be. They fit. “Lana’s gonna hate herself for not seeing Marie’s pain, you know that, right?”

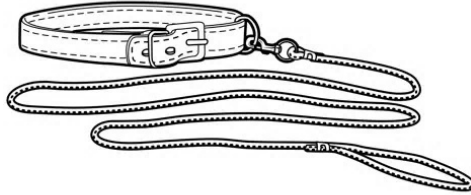
Giulia sighs and I echo the sentiment. “It’s something they have to work on together. I protected her like she asked me to, Jules. I would have done the same for you. I did the same for Lana when she needed it.”

I nod and join Lana and Lisandru into the town car. As we drive in silence to our hotel in West Hill, I simply clasp Lana’s shoulders in a silent show of support. I don’t miss the way she swipes at her face and sniffs all the way through.

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## NICO

LOVE AND DOUBT



My hands are growing wet as I wait in the visitor's parlour of Nightingale Rehab Centre. I wipe them on top of my jeans-clad thighs before I tap my fingers in its usual rhythm of three. My tongue won't stop swiping at my piercing, even if I try to control myself. I'm too wired to do anything but be at the mercy of my swirling emotions right now.

Marie's therapist told us on the phone a few days ago that she couldn't have too many visitors at once, which broke my mum's heart a little, I think, and with her sister waiting in the town car, that left only me. Lana came back when the three weeks were up and hasn't left West Hill in the past four days, waiting for Marie to be well enough to have visitors. I grinded my teeth when Giulia sacrificed her visit for Lana, simply texting Dr Linberg, Marie's therapist, to ask if that wouldn't be too much for Marie. Her response was that it was actually a positive outcome, which I don't fucking understand.

She might be Marie's sister but she's been oblivious to her suffering and her first instinct was to take Ember away. I won't forget that any time soon. Even if I'm mad at Marie for abandoning me, even if I want to irrationally yell at her even though she did something for herself for the first time, I'll always protect her.

Ember coos at me from her carry cot, playing with the hanging toys. I lean down and toy with the plastic animals, their clinking sounds making

her laugh. With that sound, it's like the nervous energy running through me dissipates and I smile at my daughter.

I never imagined myself a father. But I believe it's only because I hadn't met Ember. I was born to be her dad. The knowledge is deeply seated into my bones. I'm always protective of the ones I love, but with Ember, I'm feral, a caged beast. If anyone thinks they can take her from me, I'll carve their heart out of their chest with my bare hands and I won't care about the mess of entrails and blood I make.

Just as red starts to fill my vision, the sweetest voice brings me back to the present moment. "Hi, Nico."

I stand and in three measured steps that probably look like I'm in control when I'm nothing but, I close the distance between Marie and I. Her cheek is soft against the back of my fingers.

"You left," I tell her.

The green pools hold me captive as they fill up with fresh tears that fall against my skin.

The next second, my lips land on Marie's and she pulls on my teeshirt, clasping the fabric desperately. I close my eyes and let myself fall deeper into her. The taste of her tongue fills my mouth and I can't help but cling to her, wrapping my body around hers, her chest to mine, hands roaming. I'm desperate to be inside her, not only physically but metaphorically, as much as she's into me, inside my blood, carved into my heart. I need to be under her skin.

*Did she think about me as much as I thought about her? Did sleep evade her like it did me because I couldn't hold her soft body against mine?*

When I pull away, I frame her face and lose myself into her deep green eyes. They're so much brighter than they were only a month ago. Whatever she is going through here, it's for the best. It shows in the way she stands, in how perfectly pink her cheeks are, her bashful smile and biting of her lower lip that tells me exactly where her mind has gone.

Whistles sound behind us and other patients make lewd gestures. The way Marie giggles clue me in on the teasing and that they must be her friends or companions. "You made friends," I comment dryly. I think I'm jealous. I don't know them and they make me uncomfortable. This is something new again when it comes to her and it makes me want to be hers even more. I swallow it and observe as Marie shrugs.

“Turns out, I’m not the only one who felt unseen and chose alcohol as a way to make themselves feel better,” she says brightly.

“Don’t do that.”

“Do what?” Her laugh dies and I feel like an asshole but she needs to know there’s nothing wrong with her and she is loved exactly the way that she is.

“The self-deprecation shit.” I take her hand in mine and thread our fingers together before giving it the back of it a kiss. I pick up Ember and sit her on my lap. Immediately, Marie relaxes and plays with her, almost fearful to take her in her arms. “I adore you exactly as you are, Marie. And Ember does, too. Don’t you, Bibi?”

“Baba.”

We both gasp at Ember’s first word, or babbling or whatever the fuck that was. Our gaze collide and my cheeks hurt from smiling so wide. Fireworks shoot up my spine and my heart rate kicks up in my chest. I haven’t done anything but it feels much more monumental. Any resentment loses its grasp on my brain as I watch Marie interact with her daughter.

“Say that again, Bibi. Can you say ‘baba’?” Marie asks and Ember repeats the word, over and over, laughing and clapping her little hands.

“Andrea has been trying to have her say ‘zio’ for weeks now,” I tell Marie.

“Well.” She straightens up and caresses my cheek in a tender move. “‘Baba’ is actually close to ‘babbu’, which means ‘father’ in Kalliste. I wouldn’t be surprised if Giulia tried to teach her that while I was away.”

I don’t need for my daughter’s first word to be *baba* or *babbu* to know that I’m her father but it’s touching nonetheless and definitely something Giulia would do. She’s never fully forgiven herself for what happened to me earlier this year. I press a hand to the bullet wound at my chest, the phantom pain throbbing with the emotion rising inside my ribcage. Ever since Marie and Ember entered my life, there’s been a lot of that where it used to be all dead and quiet as winter night. Can’t say I mind.

Our laughter dies down and I clear my throat, unsure how to approach this.

“You lied to me, Marie.”

She drops her gaze and it makes me feel uneasy. That’s not how it should be between us but there’s no other way for me to broach the subject than be brutal about it. “I’m proud of you for doing what you needed, but

you didn't talk to me. I thought I was important to you," I say and for the first time in my life, my throat clogs with something I don't recognise. Like the emotions are going to take over.

Marie turns her front to me and lands a hand on my thigh, running three circles in one way and three the other, until my shoulders drop slightly.

"I'm so sorry, baby." Her voice cracks. "I was spiralling, and thought I was gonna be a danger to Ember. I needed to come here and take care of my disease. I... I've been so used to being disregarded. I thought it was better this way."

"After everything I've done for you, I thought you knew how much I love you. What I would do for you. Why didn't you tell me?"

I place my hand on top of hers to stop her motion and lift her chin up with the other. There's so much pain in there and I know she's my mirror. "I just need you to be okay," I whisper. "That's all that matters to me."

"Once I'm better, I will prove to you everyday how much I love you, too, Nico Capaldi."

The words land inside me. Soothing. Tempting. But I'm not sure I can believe her.

She leans forward to kiss my lips and I let her but I don't deepen the kiss. Instead, I change the topic, uncomfortable with not knowing how to heal from the pain she caused me yet.

"I'm not the only visitor you'll have today," I tell her and she quirks a brow.

"Is Gigi here?"

"No. Giulia isn't coming." Before I have time to regret letting her sister into her life when she is vulnerable, I tell her why. "Lana is."

Marie's head snaps up. "What?" Then, she recoils slightly and I wince. Definitely not my best move but I'm out of my depth, not for the first time. Marie has the right to make choices and decisions for herself and I would hate myself if I were to prevent her from being the leader of her own life and own healing. "What does that mean?"

"When you admitted yourself here, I was... doing my job. We got to Misha Petrov's second and found out where he was hiding. So we called Lana. She found out you were here that night and knew you'd be able to have visitors now so she flew again a few days ago, waiting for you."

She sighs, her back hitting the chair. She looks older all of a sudden and I hate this for her. "You don't have to see her if you don't want to." I clasp



her thigh with my tattooed hand. I don't think I'm doing this for her. Maybe it's for me. To see the evidence of who I am to her. Because what if after she speaks to her sister, she leaves, this time permanently? What if she takes Ember with her?

Marie's soft hand lands on mine. She starts to tap on top of it. Three. A pause. Three. A pause. Calming me in my favoured way. When I peer up, she has a distant look, like she's lost to her thoughts. Then, she must come to a decision. She squares her shoulders. Her eyes are harsher as she declares, "I want to see her. It's time. I don't want this to fester inside me any longer."

After another kiss that should have lasted longer, and a warm embrace with Ember squished between us, I tell her I'll be back tomorrow and get her sister, praying to a God I don't believe in that I made the right choice, and that the feeling of betrayal I have inside won't become its own monster.

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# MARIE

TO HEAL FROM THE PAST



My throat clogs as I watch Nico's back shift on his way out. I know I'll see him tomorrow. After the initial phase, I can now have visitors every day, and I'm hopeful that I can go back home within the next two weeks. But I miss Nico and Ember viscerally. They're both embedded in my soul and I realised, while stuck here, that I can't live without them. I don't ever want to be separated from them for so long.

I pick at the skin around my cuticles while I wait for Lana to appear. If she's here, she knows about me, about my struggles and that brings a new wave of shame to take host inside my chest. I'm working hard with Dr Linberg on that part of my mental illness, but recognising I was ill in the first place already took so much, I can only take baby steps towards the rest of the recovery process.

"Marie?" she asks, uncertain.

When I lift my eyes to take her in, the image I had of my sister shatters. Instead of a goddess with her head held high, dark locks of brown hair curling around her beautiful face, is an ordinary woman with gaunt cheeks and grey under her green eyes, betraying a lack of sleep and deep sorrow. Even her pristine signature white suit has been replaced with jeans and a black cashmere turtle neck that makes her look ordinary.

I run to her and she opens her arms, welcoming me. I don't let go despite the *umph* on impact, and clutch her to my chest. Her hand clasps the back of my head. "I'm so sorry," she whispers into my hair over and over.

“I’m so, so sorry, Marie. I should have seen. I should have been there for you.”

I want to shake my head, tell her that’s okay, but I can’t anymore. Because I did hope that she would see, I did hope that she would save me like she saved everyone around her. That’s part of the problem. I hoped for someone to see me, even as I hid, including my older sister, and I perceived her failures as failure towards me, as proof that I was unloveable and invisible.

She smells faintly of the sea breeze on the maritime pines in Kalliste, and I don’t let go for minutes. We stay standing, caught into each other’s embrace, my cheeks leaving tear stains on her dark sweater. When she pulls away, her eyes are red and puffy, her own cheeks wet with pain.

Hand linked together, I take her towards another corner of the room, a little nook hidden from view where I feel we’ll have more privacy. Overlooking the garden, it’s my favourite spot in the facility. I don’t know what that says about us that I want to share it with her.

“Thank you for coming, Lana.” She opens her mouth to speak but I cut her off. “Before you say anything and keep beating yourself up, I need to speak. And I need you to hear what I have to say. Will you do that for me?”

She nods and it gives me courage. I hold her eyes captive as I continue. “I am sorry. I’m sorry I held you and everyone in our family responsible for my own toxic coping mechanism.”

Her hand tenses where we’re linked. “It’s not your fault. You were just a child,” she says.

“I was. And I still hated you for not fighting your first marriage. I think I thought that after a few months, you’d be back with us. Angele was already married and mostly gone. You were gone and I knew you were suffering, but I felt abandoned. Lisa was always up to some shit, chasing boys and not caring if they lived or died. And I just... existed in between. Mum and Dad were having all these meetings and they kept me away, inventing more and more excuses. I only wanted to be part of the family, you know?”

“We just wanted to protect you.” Her voice wobbles as she speaks and it’s the first time I see my sister for what she is. A woman with her flaws. An equal. I always had in mind that she was a God. With her shoulders hunched over and regret written all across her face, she looks so fragile.

“I didn’t need protection, Lana. I needed acceptance. My mind took the protection you thought was best for me for rejection and that turned quickly into self-loathing.”

A deep sigh escapes my lips. “In hindsight, it’s easy to see how mistaken I was,” I add.

“No. If I had been more present for you, especially after I returned to Kalliste, you wouldn’t be here.”

“You know what the French say? *‘Avec des si, on mettrait Paris en bouteille’*. With ifs, we could put Paris in a bottle.” She regards me like I’ve lost my mind and I scoff. “There’s a French girl here and she taught me this saying, it sounds fancy. All of that to say that we don’t know. Besides, I started drinking when you left for Mallorca. When you came back, the habit was... a bigger issue than I realised. There’s only so many diners and parties and occasions when I could drink, it was easily accessible, and I hid it well.”

Silence descends upon us and we both watch snowflakes fall in the garden. It’s so peaceful here. Not necessarily here at The Nightingale, but here in this quiet part of the West Hill suburbs. I’m only an hour away from Nico’s house and I know somewhere close must bloom hundreds of Scottish bluebells come early spring. I’m longing to see the change of the seasons here.

As much as I love Kalliste and its beautiful landscape made of sea cliffs and snowy mountains, the island is small and chaotic at times. The green leaves of trees aren’t as deep green as they are here with the humid air pretty much year round. We have months of drought that turns the coast into a desert-looking scenery. And strangely enough, I don’t miss the shimmer of the sea. What I do miss are amber eyes looking at me like I can do no wrong. Though they did hold a lot more pain when he was here earlier and the thought sobers me.

“Are you thinking about him?” Lana’s silky voice permeates through my thoughts, and I nod.

“I didn’t think it was possible to love someone as much as I love Lisa, you know,” I tell her. “Sometimes, I fear that I’ll wake up one day and he’ll be gone just like she is, but that makes me hold onto him even harder.”

It’s the first time I’ve mentioned my sister’s name to someone other than my therapist and speaking it aloud almost makes her appear in front of me. It revives the memories I have of her that I tried to hide in the deepest

corners of my heart while I was here. I thought if I did, it would preserve them but it had the opposite effect.

“Do you remember the summer we turned fifteen? Lisa and I stole Dad’s boat and went out to the hidden caves in the North?” Mirth pulls at my lips, the memory so vivid I remember how windy it was that day and can almost feel it in my hair. Lisa’s manic laughs ring in my ears.

“How could I forget? You were grounded for a year!”

“More like two months. Dad could never say no to Lisa’s pleading.”

“She was a master manipulator,” Lana says fondly and I have to agree. She got everything she ever wanted with a smile and a smart mouth. My chest constricts thinking of all that she wanted to accomplish, who she wanted to be. She won’t ever be able to live her dreams, but I get to instead.

“I’m glad you’re still here,” Lana says, taking me off the cliff of self-loathing without knowing. Or maybe she knows, but it warms me from the inside out anyway.

“I often wonder how I got here. Years wasted hating myself, blaming you and everyone else,” I muse. I’m working through all these thoughts with Dr Linberg but I’m often on repeat on the topic. It’s hard to get out of vicious circles of thoughts despite the therapy and the supportive group of people inside the rehab centre and outside.

Lana turns to me fully and grabs my other hand, urgency spreading from her body towards mine. “I know you said it’s not my fault but I am truly sorry, Marie. I wish you will let me be in your life and show you how much I love you, and how much you are wanted in the family.”

“Does that mean you’ll include me in the family decisions?”

“Of course.”

She doesn’t hesitate and that somehow lifts a weight off my shoulders. After years of thinking I needed to fight for a scrap of attention, even if some day will be harder than others, this little proof of love and acceptance from the people I thought shun me away is everything. I can’t wait to tell Dr Linberg all about it.

“I’ll miss you, Mimi,” Lana says and I glance her way again.

“You know?” I ask. We haven’t talked about my plans but I won’t come back to Kalliste.

“I suspect,” she simply answers with an indulgent smile. “If you love him. If you’re happy, that’s all I want for you.”

“I’ll miss you, too,” I tell her. “It’s only a three hour flight.”

When she stands and hugs me to her, the embrace is different than the first. It's less about unsaid words and open, festering wounds. I close my eyes and breathe her in, ready to turn the page on that resentment and take it day by day with her and my parents. "Lisa would be so proud of you," she whispers against my ears then kisses my cheeks and leaves.

Fresh tears coat my cheeks but I don't wipe them away.

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## MARIE

FAMILY DINNERS ARE FOR FOOD AND TEARS



“How do you feel about tonight, Marie?” Dr Linberg asks from her seat in front of me in her warm office. Weeks ago, I’d have answered something basic I thought everyone wanted to hear. “Good”, “Happy,” even though none of these answers were remotely true. I thought by hiding myself, I was protecting myself from being rejected for not being okay. In my mind, it was a necessary lie to make myself small and make sure I wasn’t a burden to anyone I’ve ever loved. I’m learning I don’t need to do any of that. But it’s a process.

I ponder the question of my psychiatrist, whose frameless glasses are perilously falling down her aquiline nose. She waits with kind blue eyes, never pressuring me despite how long I take.

“I’m anxious. I know the family dinner is a safe space for me but they enjoy wine and I know they’ll probably make sure there’s none on the table, but it feels like they have to make adjustments. For me.”

Dr Linberg hums softly. I can almost hear the question underneath. *And don’t you think you deserve the adjustments made for you?* “I do think it’s a good thing if they do and it will make me feel seen, even though I’m also ashamed that they have to.”

A shiver runs up my spine and I shake my shoulders to dislodge the unwanted sensation. Thinking of alcoholism like a disease and something that hinders me rather than something I chose and that was “mine” has helped me heal tremendously. I’m only on the first step of my program and

will have to stay within the facility for another three weeks but tonight will be the first time I go out since I admitted myself.

After my sister's visit three weeks ago, I called an emergency meeting with Dr Linberg, and we decided I needed to be here longer, take it slow and focus on healing rather than "getting out". Reframing that mindset has helped me feel less guilty towards Ember and I know Nico, Giulia and Andrea are taking amazing care of her. I see her everyday and miss being her care-taker but the long process is helping. I'm confident I can take care of her now.

When Nico told me that Lana, Julian and Lisandru were coming over this weekend to finalise the plan to go after Misha Petrov, I wanted to surprise them. My therapist thinks tonight is a great idea, under certain conditions. Nico is picking me up and bringing me back before 11 pm. Worse than Cinderella but I don't mind. The routine I've created here has also helped with sleeping. I dream of Lisa every single night and wake up in tears.

Without the cover of alcohol, it's like I miss her so deep the marrow of my bones call out for her. But I miss Ember even more. And Nico. How infallible he has been, taking everything in stride, showing up here even when I couldn't receive visitors. I know he's in pain and needs me to reassure him that none of my decisions were because of him or what he did or did not do. I want to be his rock as much as he has been for me.

The ghost of my sister lingers above me but behind the grey shroud of her presence is so much life. And I want to be part of that, I want to be part of *them* more than I want to join Lisa.

"I still feel so weak sometimes," I muse.

"In regards to alcohol or something else?"

"I could relapse, that's for sure. But mostly, like I'm not good enough for my daughter and for Nico. He has suffered so much and I believe I'm adding to it instead of helping enrich his life."

"Have you talked to him about how you feel?" Dr Linberg asks and it makes me cringe. We did talk but it wasn't exactly what I wanted to say.

We wrap up our session with a promise to talk to Nico and get the reassurance I obviously need directly from the source. I paint my eyes with black eye liner and use a pink gloss on my lips, feeling pretty in the mirror for the first time in a long time. The light in the bathroom of my room is



harsh but my cheeks have natural colours, my skin clear and bright. I twirl like a school girl as I put on my midnight blue dress.

Knuckles on the open door of my room draw my eyes to the man standing there.

Nico looks painfully beautiful in a black cashmere sweater and his dark jeans over his black leather boots. Only the tattoos on his knuckles are visible and I take my time taking him in. I know I saw him just a few hours ago, but somehow this moment means something to me. Something different.

“Hi, *luna mia*.”

“Hi,” I answer shyly before I close the distance and kiss his lips in a chaste touch. “I miss you.”

With his characteristic deftness and ease, Nico slides his fingers into my hair on both sides of my head and presses me against the open door. His mouth on mine sends my head into a spin, our tongues tangling and breaths mingling. He’s everything I want.

A nurse clears her throat behind us and we step away from each other, eyes never leaving the other, lost to our moment.

On the ride to Andrea’s, Nico’s hand is firmly pressed on my thigh and the butterflies in my stomach start to riot. It’s not like I forgot how heady being with him is, how intoxicating, but maybe I did a little bit. I let myself fall against the passenger seat, watching him drive with ease, his forearm flexing as he holds the steering wheel. The butterflies move down and I blush, looking over at the road again.

We park outside Andrea and Giulia’s house and make our way in quickly to avoid the rain shower falling down.

“Nico, you’re late,” Catalina says from somewhere in the kitchen.

I enter the warm room. “That’s my fault, Catalina.”

Six pairs of eyes turn to me and self-consciousness rears its ugly head. Nico knew about tonight but if the rest of them didn’t, maybe there’s alcohol on the table and it will trigger me. Maybe they don’t want me here. Maybe I’m interrupting an important meeting or forcing them to delay decisions when it comes to going after Misha Petrov.

“*Carina*,” Catalina exclaims and wheels herself to me, then opens her arms wide for me. With tears threatening to butcher my make-up, I lean into her embrace and let her soothe me with her sweet motherly love. “We miss you so much, baby. I’m so happy to see you.”

When I straighten up, my teeth grind against each other with how hard I have to reign in my emotions. It's annoying that I can't seem to do anything but cry. Being here for family dinner is a gift.

Andrea hugs me. "It's good to see you, Mimi," he murmurs into my hair and the nickname I used to hate turns gentle and precious in the mouths of the people who love me so much they would wait for me.

"Thank God, you're here. Your sister is unbearable. Keep me, please," Julian jokes as he hugs me but my sister pushes him over to take his place. "Shut up, asshole. I'm not unbearable. And don't hog my sister."

Lisandru is the last to greet me with a short embrace. We've never been close so it's warming me from the inside out even more. "I'm glad to see you, Marie," he says with a nod then takes his silent place next to Lana again.

Giulia, who was standing close to the dinner table, approaches with Ember propped on her hip. My nose tickles again as I reach for her and take her into my arms. "Hi, Bibi," I breathe into her hair and hug her to my chest, against my heart who mostly beats for her. I saw her this afternoon but it's hitting me right now how grown she is already. I've always heard that babies change fast at this age but it never registered until now. If I don't get my shit together, I could miss so much more of it. "I'm sorry. I'm so sorry, *u mu sole*," I tell her. "I'm gonna be a better mum, I promise."

I'm conscious that every ear in the room is listening to me promising a better life to my daughter but I couldn't care less.

Strong arms wrap around me from behind. Nico's hands clasp my elbows and hold me close to his body, my back against his front, his lips at my temple. "We love you, and we'll wait for you," he whispers into my ear so low I barely hear him. My breath itches.

"I swear to you all, once I get my husband back, you're gonna regret the days you made me watch you all fall in love," Julian complains and breaks the moment. Everyone follows him and takes a seat around the massive oak table dressed like a feast at the centre of the living room.

When I move to take my place, Nico stops me by stepping in front of me, blocking my view of the rest of our party. His amber eyes shine with an intensity I'm all too familiar with and adore.

"I mean it, *luna mia*. I'll wait for you. Just please don't leave."

I gulp and nod, incapable of forming words that will soothe him, and also aware that all ears are on us. My love and promises are meant for him

only. The paper in my bag burns a hole in it but I don't think now is the perfect moment to show it to him. Maybe later when he drops me off.

Dinner is spent talking about every unserious topic under the sun. How Lana, Julian and Lisandru hate the rain and would never be able to live in West Hill or anywhere above the latitude of Marseille. How Catalina has been preparing a huge benefit gala with the Hospital Board and we Capaldi all have to attend next month. The fact that she includes me in the Capaldi side of the family with a wink is both a relief and a strange novelty. It's as though by distancing myself from the Moretti name this way, I feel closer to it. I don't put too much thought behind it and focus on the people around the table.

The evening is light and I enjoy every second of it. There's no wine to be found on the table and I'm not sure if it's a conscious choice on their part. I appreciate it all the same, a slight blush on my cheeks as I take a sip of my soda.

I drop Ember on Nico's lap to go to the bathroom and when I come back to the table, I watch as Lana stares at them with an unreadable expression.

"You're good with her," she tells Nico, who doesn't lift his gaze as he answers.

"Of course. She's mine." He kisses Ember's head then feeds her a little bit of mashed carrots he set on the side for her. She giggles at him and my heart somersaults again.

As much as I'm enjoying the conversation, seeing Nico claim my daughter for everyone to see does something to me. I need him alone and I need to show him what he means to me. And that's a private affair.

"Nico, I'm pretty tired, would you mind driving me back a little early?" I ask.

He doesn't react, not even a flinch, nodding and getting up without another word. Of course he knows I'm lying, as we planned to have some time just for the two of us. I'm unsure he's gonna like the surprise I have for him and the uncertainty has my hands shaking.

After more embraces and leaky eyes, we say our goodbyes. Giulia promises to come over to the clinic with Ember tomorrow and everyday after so I can see my daughter. As fun as this was, and healing as well, my mind and body are tired and ready to crash. I didn't think healing would take out so much of my strength.

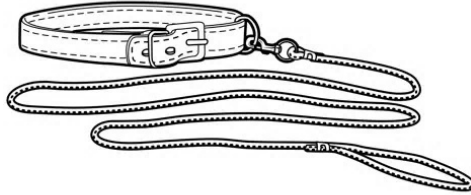
But first, I get Nico alone.

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## NICO

HEALING AND SEX GO HAND IN HAND



“Drive me to your house, please,” Marie says once she’s seated on the passenger side of my car. But she says it like a question, and she says ‘your house’, not ‘our house’. All the resentment I’ve been bottling up bubbles to the surface and I grind my teeth not to lash out and let the disappointment and hurt I feel wash over her. She doesn’t need that shit and I’m good at ignoring my emotions.

I nod once and we drive in silence. The tension is palpable, but I don’t try to diffuse it this time.

“Nico...” Marie starts but I park in front of my house and leave the vehicle to open her door for her. Leading her home with a hand on her lower back because I can’t stand not to touch her, I’m reminded how I left the house in her absence when I push the door to reveal the living room. Exactly as she left it. The crochet needles are abandoned on the couch with black yarn, all the cabinets doors and drawers in the kitchen are still open. I’ve taken to sleeping on the floor of my workshop because I can’t stand to come home to silence, or on the floor of Ember’s bedroom at Andrea and Giulia’s. I don’t feel worthy of a bed for not helping Marie more.

She gulps audibly, her face stricken like she’s ashamed.

“I haven’t been inside in a while,” I tell her. I don’t say that it’s not her fault because my emotions are a mess and if she didn’t simply leave but talked to me, maybe I wouldn’t feel so out of control.

“Since the day I admitted myself at Nightingale?” she asks softly and I nod. “Oh, Nico. I’m so sorry. Please have a seat.”

I follow her command, a Pavlovian reflex. Once again, I look up at her as she remains standing, my favourite viewpoint. My heart does a somersault but I tamper it down, clasping my fists together until my knuckles turn white. She rummages in her black leather handbag while I simply observe her. She’s as breathtaking as ever in a long blue dress that accentuates her curves, paired with the black boots she loves.

We fit so well. How can she not see that?

“This is for you,” she says as she hands me a few sheets of paper. A first glance shows that she signed each page. My curiosity is picked. I should have read the title first. Even being seated doesn’t prevent my eyes from going wide with shock. I look up at her, a soft and shy smile graces her pretty face.

“What does this mean?”

She chuckles but it sounds wrong, like she’s nervous. “Well, I want you to be Ember’s father in truth.”

“I am,” I counter vehemently.

“Of course, you are, baby.” My stomach drops to my feet at the familiar nickname but hope has no place between us. This must be a sick joke. “You are her father, and if you sign this, you’ll be recognised as such in a court of law. No one will be able to take her from you, or tell you that you aren’t her dad. DeRossi made sure everything’s iron-clad.”

My eyes drop back down to the document resting on my knees. I read it once. Then again. Then a third time. Marie has signed this.

“Please say something,” Marie murmurs.

“But you left.”

“Baby, I never left *you*.” She drops to her knees in front of me, touching my thighs gently as if she’s scared I’ll reject her. With a hand under my chin, she raises my face to meet her gaze once more. “I’m so sorry I hurt you when I admitted myself into rehab. I needed to be strong for Ember. And for you. I had such a bad panic attack when you were in the Cotswolds. I knew I needed help.”

“Am I not enough?” I ask and it’s full of pain. I thought I was giving her what she needed. A sense of control and someone to talk to when she was feeling on the verge of drinking again. Everyone around me has been hurt because of my choices. First my father, then my mother. Giulia almost died

because I couldn't protect her. I almost died, too, though I'd rather it'd be me than her or Marie or anyone else I care about. But I can't keep making decisions for the people I love on my own. I can't be trusted.

"You are enough," Marie says and gets up on her knees, crawling in between my legs and framing my face with her hand, urgency lacing her voice. "I needed a doctor's help, a therapist, many in fact. All so that I could come back to you and Ember. Please, let me prove it to you. I'll do anything to show you how much I love you and that everything I did was to be a better person to be at your side."

Her forehead drops to mine. I breathe her in but she smells all wrong, chemical soap instead of the fresh lemon one I have in my bathroom that I've loved lathering on her skin. I need her here again, in my space. "I need you to make me bleed," I tell her.

"Nico, I know how much I've already hurt you."

I shake my head. "Replace it with the pain I love. With the one I need. Please, Miss Marie." I hear what she says about needing help I couldn't provide but there's only one way for me to process pain and to absolve myself of my shortcomings. I need her to replace all this mental chatter that I can't discern right and wrong from, with the cathartic lashes of the whip. She hesitates again so I beg some more. "I need it."

She swallows hard, but nods.

"Get up, and strip," she orders as she stands.

The energy between us shifts with those two words. I eagerly obey and undress when she commands it. Marie gasps when she sees the fresh scars. She glides her hand on my left forearm, turning it in all angles, then moving up to my shoulder with tears in her deep green eyes. I hate them. I never want to see her cry ever again. "What is this?" she asks with alarm.

"The shoulder is courtesy of one of Petrov's men, and he's dead. The arm... I used my blood to paint," I tell her truthfully.

"What the fuck!" Her thunderous green eyes turn dark and she holds my chin almost painfully. "Only *I* am allowed to make you bleed, is that clear?"

"Yes, Miss Marie." Arousal shoots up my spine and my cock bobs against my stomach at seeing her so irate. I'm hoping her anger will make the blows on my body harsher. The exhaustion after a session is what I crave as I imagine her whipping me until blood wells on my back.

"Such an obedient little pet," she praises as she prowls around me, her fingers trailing goosebumps where she touches my shoulders and chest.

“Kneel. And don’t move.”

I kneel on the rug, the soft cotton familiar on my skin, helping me drop already into a submissive state. I close my eyes and take a deep inhale to quench the anticipation coursing through me. This is better than the blade I’ve taken to my arms in hopes of leeching the pain away. The sound of her footsteps ebbs away before it comes back. Marie lifts my chin with the blunt leathery head of a flogger. “Is this what you want?”

“Yes, Miss Marie.”

Understanding and kindness blends on her beautiful face. She needs this as much as I do, the reminder of her control. She nods and disappears behind me. “What’s your safe word?”

“Fire.”

“Good. Mine is ‘purple’. Now bow your head down, baby. And start counting.”

The first lash across my shoulders has me hissing through my teeth and arching as frissons skate across my skin. “One.”

At the second one, I let out a groan. “Louder,” Marie orders. “And don’t forget to count.”

She keeps a rhythm, creating a criss-cross of marks on my back. The longer we go, the more fuzzy my head grows. At twenty, I’m floating between pain and pleasure, sweat making my skin damp. I know Marie would need way more to actually break the skin but the perspective of giving her all I have sends a jolt of happiness through my system.

I can’t resist squeezing my cock, the edges of my vision blurring. “You can touch yourself but do not come, Nico. That cum belongs to me,” Marie’s sweet voice sifts through the haze, a mental caress I obey without thought. “You did so good, baby,” she says as she caresses my cheek. “Give me a colour.”

“Green.”

She hums, satisfied with herself, and I watch as she pulls her dress over her head, leaving her on full display for me. “Were you naked under that dress the whole evening?” I grunt and she giggles.

“I was. Maybe I was hoping I could lure you into the bathroom and have you lick my pussy in between the main course and dessert.”

Fuck. I’d have done it. I’d do it right now but I remain still, perfectly poised for her next command.



Marie disappears from view for a second but my ears strain so much to hear what she's up to that I don't miss the glide of the knife taken out of its butcher block. I start to pant, my eyes rolling back even though she hasn't used the knife yet. When she uses the sharp edge to lift my chin, I hiss and she smirks. A small flick of her wrist has a drop of blood sliding down the column of my throat in the most erotic and tantalising slow glide.

"Don't move," Marie whispers and I hold my breath.

The heavy butcher knife glints in her hands. Walking Death has never looked so enticing, so fucking delicious I want to take a bite of it, of her. With a shallow hold, Marie brings the knife down to my collarbone, barely pressing but she doesn't need to. Her pupils blow wide as blood wells from the cut, her lips parting before she licks the blood away. Her shallow breaths have her breasts move with every intake. She's a masterpiece.

Marie slides the knife to the other side and down to the bullet scar, creating red lines like a map of her love for me. I clench my fists, cock hard and throbbing, but all I am is at her mercy. Blood don't pour out this time and I'm grateful to avoid the feeling of liquid on my skin, but it does taint the blade.

I watch, riveted, my own lips parted in disbelief as she brings the knife up and licks the blade. We moan in unison. I almost come on the spot.

She doesn't speak but moves to the kitchen and drops the knife in the sink, then taps her thigh and walks towards our bedroom. I crawl after her, my eyes on her peachy ass. When she glances behind her shoulders, she smoulders at me and I swear her pupils blow even wider.

"Lay down on the bed for me, baby."

I do as I'm told, the chafing of the sheets uncomfortable at my back, rivulets of blood on my chest. I love it. It's another way to stay within the scene, to stay out of my head as I focus on not coming from the permanent sensation of stinging discomfort.

Marie crawls on top of me, her hair on both sides of her face, falling like dark curtains of silk and grazing the sensitive skin of my legs and lower belly. Her tongue dips down to lick my stomach and chest where she cuts me and I whimper. Then, she straddles me.

"Please, fuck me, Miss Marie. I've missed you so much. I need your tight cunt to squeeze my cock until you're full of me."

For the first time since we started tonight, her lips crash on mine and her taste overwhelms my senses. She's everywhere. I reach up to tangle my

fists into her hair, holding her to me like she'd disappear if I don't. She whimpers softly into my mouth, letting go of our scene for a second while we feed off each other's need. Melting into me and settling the weight of her body on mine, Marie lets herself be mine. That's how it feels. There's no pretend or persona, no scene or established dynamic as we consume each other. In a rush, our mouths still locked, our bodies pressed together, Marie lifts herself and guides my erection into her wet heat. She sinks down and we moan in unison.

Like a man possessed, I flip us over and get on top of her, in between her opened thighs. The flesh under my hands is soft and I grip it hard, afraid to let go.

"Let me breed you, *luna mia*. Please, please, please. Take my cum until you grow my child. I'll do anything," I say in between ravenous kisses.

"I'm not on the pill anymore," Marie breathes and my cock pulses in response.

"Oh *fuck*. Are you telling me you're gonna have my baby?"

"It was fucking up with the meds they're giving me." She looks at me sheepishly and bites her lip. "Are you gonna fuck me like you mean it, baby?"

"Fuck yes."

I swing her legs over my shoulders, and press gentle kisses on her calves, before my thrusts get deeper. "You." *Thrust*. "Are." *Thrust*. "Mine." *Thrust*.

"Yes. Yes, I'm yours," Marie chants as I fuck her into the mattress. "Fuck me harder, baby. You know I can take it," she says as a reminder of who's in charge.

I'm possessed, letting instincts rule me as I pound into her harder in long, deep strokes. Marie throws her head back, arching into me until she comes all over my cock, squeezing her inner walls around me. It's heaven, and hell, because I don't want this to end. But I wouldn't be able to stop the orgasm coming at me like a fret train, even after years of discipline. She takes me with her, and I moan into her neck as I collapse on top of her and let go, jets of cum filling her like I promised.

"That's it," Marie murmurs into my ear as she glides her nails at my scalp and my swollen back. "Give it to me."

When I come down from my high, I stay pressed against her chest, inside her until I feel myself soften. I kiss her perfect body from the column

of her neck down to her tits, soft stomach and mound until I'm in between her thick thighs. The mix of our release sticks to her legs and I use two fingers to bring it back into her pussy, drawing a sudden gasp from her pretty mouth. I get my lips closer, addicted to the taste of us.

"No." She stops me with her sharp tongue. "If you want this pussy, beg for it."

A slow smile spread over my face. I'm delighted to have my vicious little Marie back. I hover over her, kissing every inch of her skin. "Please." Kiss. "Miss Marie." Kiss. "I've been—" Lick. "Such." Kiss. "A good boy." I suck on her neck the way she likes and she lets out a long moan. "Please, *luna mia*. Let me drown in your pussy while you taste like me."

Licking her lips slowly, I dive in to give her all of me, our mouths moulding into the other like she was made for me. I tangle my hands in her hair, unable to resist gliding the soft strands through my fingers.

After what seems like seconds and hours all the same, like time itself warped to move around us, she sits up and I wait on my haunches. "Lay down, and let me ride your face, then."

I position myself, my heart kicking against my chest like it wants to leave my body as she hovers over me. Fuck, this might be my new favourite view. Marie takes hold of the head board and her pussy descends on my mouth but it's not enough. "Don't hover, *luna mia*. Smother me with it."

With force, I take hold of her thighs and bring her full body weight onto my face, my tongue connecting with her clit and making her sigh. It only takes a few passes of my tongue before she rides me in earnest. I can't even move, holding myself for her to take her pleasure. My name and prayers fill the space around us, my hands roaming her legs and ass until I grow bold and pinch her nipples. Marie arches her back on top of me, forcing more of her body onto my face. I leave my tongue flat and stiff so it flicks up and down from entrance to clit. Over and over, she rolls her hips, until she comes on top of me, drenching my face with a mix of our cum.

My eyes never leave her face, contorted in ecstasy. She's so beautiful when she lets go, when she trusts me.

She lifts off my body and collapses next to me, immediately seeking the comfort of my arms. I wipe my mouth with the back of my hand and kiss her again. This one is softer, a satiated kind of kiss that only happens when exhaustion settles into the bones. When she pulls away, she gives a little contented sigh and closes her eyes, nestling into the crook of my neck.

I check the clock on her nightstand. 9.30 pm. We have to leave soon if we want to make it on time for her curfew. I don't want to give her bad habits when she's at Nightingale for that very reason in the first place. I also don't want to risk any setback or maybe punishment. I don't think it would be the style of the Institution but Marie's therapist trusted me to keep her on a rhythm. If she wants to come back to me and Ember as soon as possible, we have to shower and get going.

Fuck, Ember's now about to officially become my daughter. The papers are waiting for me in the living room and once I sign and file them, she'll be mine. I want her mother as mine, too, in the eyes of the law and full with my kids for years to come.

A soft snore disturbs my happy thoughts and I chuckle.

"*Luna mia*," I call with no answer. "*Luna mia*, we have to go back to the Centre."

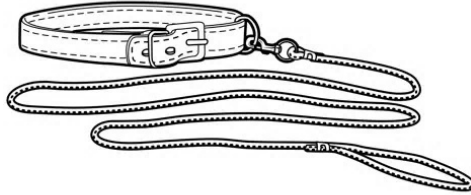
With expletives I didn't know her capable of, she sits up and stands on wobbly legs, heading towards the bathroom. I follow and pray I won't want to fall to my knees to eat her out again. I fail.

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## NICO

ARCU DI SERA, TEMPU DI SPERA



“No, wait,” Marie says as she clasps her hand in mine.

Laying on the chair, eyes wide with fear, Marie’s gaze oscillate between me and the needle poised above her collarbone. I look over to the artist I flew here on Kalliste, all the way from West Hill because she’s the only one I trust enough to tattoo and pierce me, Mia, and gesture with a shake of my head to go and give us privacy. She doesn’t comment and tells us to call her when we’re ready.

The soft burgundy silk blouse she wears over her black jeans is open and loose over her shoulders, her creamy skin begging to be kissed in reassurance but as much as I want to worship her every chance I get, Mia is close by and Marie’s ragged breathing only belongs to my ears.

“Want to tell me what’s going through your mind, *luna mia*?”

“What if it hurts?” she asks, but it’s not the exact words that want to come out of her mouth. It’s been six months since she came back to me after her six weeks stay at The Nightingale and I’ve spent all that time observing her like a hawk so I’m always attuned to her needs and most minute thoughts. Her hesitation has nothing to do with the tattoo itself but what today is.

I remain silent and let her say the words she really wants to voice. “What if I regret it?”

“Do you think you will regret putting a permanent marker on your skin of the person you loved most?” I ask with a slight tilt of my head.

“No,” she mutters, then takes a fortifying breath. “I didn’t think it would make me so emotional.”

I squeeze her hand before bringing it to my lips, kissing her knuckles. Today’s Ember’s first birthday. It’s also the day she lost Lisa. I eye the design she chose.

It’s in Lisa’s handwriting. Marie found it in her abandoned journal when she scoured Lisa’s old bedroom when we landed, a week ago. The words are exactly what I’d imagine Lisa’s motto would have been. I didn’t know her well, too taken by Marie to notice her twin, but they fit her.

***Arcu di sera, tempu di spera.***

A rainbow in the evening is a hope of good weather.

Marie lets go of my hand and caresses the stencil reverently. It’s dried on her skin and could almost pass for the tattoo itself if it wasn’t blue.

“What if there’s bad weather again?” Marie asks without looking at me. She won’t ever be a bright and joyful person. No matter how much therapy she does and how good she’s doing since she got out of rehab, she’s a melancholic woman. I believe that’s why she loves where we live so much more than here, where the sun shines bright most of the year. She likes the gloom and the grey. She reads tragedies and horrors over romance. She likes to cry over the pain of others and spends hours writing in her journal.

But now she doesn’t hide her struggles and she smiles more freely. Like right now. Her lips tip up at the corner, her youthful face going soft with it. It’s a contented smile, not one that overtakes her whole face. It’s shy and tentative, like it could go at any moment. Grief continues to follow her even as time tries to erase it, but she isn’t trying to numb it anymore. And that’s the bravest she can be.

“You know I’ll always carry an umbrella, *luna mia*.”

After sterilising the tools again, Mia starts.

“I love it,” Marie says when the artist is done and she gets to see herself in the mirror. “It’s gonna look so good in that off-the-shoulder dress I bought for the ceremony.”

Looking down at my watch, I inform her that we have to go now if we want to be on time for that particular event. It takes us only a short ride back to the Moretti’s mansion, a change of clothes, then we drive to the cemetery with the whole family in tow.

Lana and Lisandru are already there when we arrive. Her older sister Angèle and her husband are absent. That relationship is harder to mend.

Marie's parents, Colomba and Pietro, arrive with Ember in her stroller. They insisted on looking over their grand-daughter this morning. I think they both want to show Marie how much they support her and her decisions. Fashionably late, Giulia and Andrea join us to complete our small gathering. We walk in silence between the rows of white mausoleums, shining brightly under the July sun. The Mediterranean Sea in the distance gives a cerulean background to the pristine white chalk walls holding the dead for centuries.

At the very edge of the cliff, we arrive in front of headstones planted directly on the floor and settle around Lisa's. Marie explained to me that Lisa was a free spirit and would have hated knowing she was laying "on top of the crusty old bones of Moretti ancestors." In a box rather than free to roam the cemetery as a spirit if she so wished.

Out of tradition more than belief, a priest is here and starts a short homely about life and death, love and loss, grief and the power of hope.

When he's gone, Marie walks to Lana and checks if Ember needs anything in her trolley. My daughter's little head is covered by the cutest white hat and the smallest sunglasses ever made, babbling and trying to eat her foot. I remove it from her mouth and hand her her pacifier instead. She takes it greedily before her attention is stolen away by her other foot.

Lisandru's men, who followed closely behind, bring us a cooler and foldable chairs that we arrange around the grave before taking their post to silently watch over us again.

"What is this?" Lana asks.

Marie clasps her hands in front of her. "I wanted us to take a moment to honor Lisa's life. We've talked and thought a lot about her death over the past year. But none of us have talked about how much life she held, how vivacious she was. About her dreams, her memories..." Her voice cracks and I take a step behind her, steadying her with my hands on her upper arms. "She deserves to be celebrated for her life, for the joy she brought us, not for the pain. So, I brought lemonade, and I'd like each of you to share a memory you have of her. A happy one."

She opens the cooler at her feet and takes the bottle of lemonade and the plastic glasses, serving and handing one to each guest. Silence stretches for a while until Lana speaks.

"When I came back to Kalliste after Eduardo died—"

"You mean after you killed him," Giulia quips and everyone laughs.

“Allegedly,” Lana continues. “Anyway, after that, Lisa was the first one to tell me she was happy he died so he wouldn’t be able to hurt me anymore. She was just sixteen and she had no clue what I lived through but she was fierce. And she probably would have ended up being the one to kill him in the end.”

“When she was five, she coloured the walls of your father’s office with a red inked pen,” Colomba says with a shake of her head, drying the misty corners of her eyes. “She said it was because it must have been his favourite colour since he was often covered in it when he came home from work.”

Pietro grumbles that he was always careful about coming home clean. Not enough apparently.

The next hour is spent sharing stories about Lisa, from insignificant mischiefs to her rebellious teenage years. The atmosphere is light, despite the undercurrent of sadness and yearning. Tears are shed by all the Morettis without exception, including Ember yelling for her meal, oblivious to anything but her tiny body’s needs.

The transition back to the house is a little jarring, with joy and gifts pushing aside any lingering grief. There’s no place for it as Ember’s birthday party turns into a feast under the capable hands of Mammona. The old woman embraces me shortly and despite my aversion for touch, I let her. From her seat at the table, she commands her staff, unable to stand for long periods of time anymore.

After today, I’ll be ready to live as a recluse for weeks, but my daughter’s laughter and smiles keep me rooted within the chaotic celebration. With her first bite of cake off of Giulia’s spoon, Ember’s eyes go round and she takes hold of her auntie’s wrist to stuff her mouth with more sugary treat.

I glance at Marie, whose eyes are already on me, soft with love and something new into them that burns brighter. I can’t wait to be back home and give Ember a sibling.



**MARIE**

RAINBOW



*Mimi, my dear sister, the true love of my life.*

*I hope I get to give you this at some point, or better yet, tell you all the reasons I love you endlessly. But if I don't, it means I'm not here anymore.*

*I'm so sorry Mimi. I'm sorry I made you lie to everyone.*

*If I can't give you this letter, well. I'm sorry I left. I'm sorry you have to grieve for me.*

*I'm sorry you have to raise Ember. But I also know you will be the best mother anyone could ever imagine.*

*Out of the two of us, you were always the best version.*

*Steady, secure, I know you were hurting some times, too.*

*But you held on, I know you did it for me. You gave me space to be wild, the safe haven to return to after chaotic days.*

*You will be an excellent mother. I couldn't have chosen someone better to be Ember's mamma. I'm also sorry I lied to you. I made arrangements in secrets so if anything happens to me, Ember will go to you. You're the one I trust most. As much as I love every sister and mamma and babbu of course, I love you most. You're my soulmate, half of me. The best part of me.*

*I hope you can forgive me. And forgive yourself.*

*Take care of Ember.*

*I love you.*

*Arcu di sera, tempu di spera.*

**O**n the plane back home, I clutch Lisa's letter to my chest, repeating the words I now know by heart. Fresh tears glide on my cheeks but I don't swipe them away. My therapist told me that we all grieve differently and that it's okay to re-read this letter. She drew the line at once a day, but in exchange, I get to keep the letter tucked into my wallet.

The first time I discovered it, it put me in a dark place. I cried myself to sleep in Nico's arms. I shared the letter with my family and it did the same to them. But now, I also draw strength from it. On her death bed, Lisa trusted me, she believed in me. And wherever she is now, I know she's watching with a smile.

"Thank God for silence," Nico exclaims in an uncharacteristic show of false exasperation as we enter our house after ten days on Kalliste with my family. I know how much they can overwhelm him, but he seemed more at ease this time. I couldn't keep my eyes off him during Ember's birthday party. How he observed and smiled and simply took it all in.

I took the gift I have for him with me but there wasn't any moment I could have given it to him. In the end, it felt wrong to do it under the sun of Kalliste and not the comfort of our home. That's simply not who we are.

That evening, after putting Ember to sleep, Nico comes back to the living room looking so edible, I can't wait any longer. He wears his classic dark sweats and a white tee that accentuates his lean muscles and black ink. The barbells on his nipples always show through the fabric and I'd be a liar if I said it leaves me indifferent. I love them and I love the reactions I get out of his body when I tug on them.

"Kneel," I tell him immediately, eager and needy. He doesn't hesitate and kneels at my feet, glancing up with adoration and lust mixing into a heady combo. "I have something for you."

"Is it a new toy, Miss Marie?"

"No, it's not a new toy, and just Marie will do, for now."

His brow dips but he nods and I take the small square box from the pocket of my suit jacket I didn't discard yet. I open it to reveal a thin chain of platinum ending on a platinum lock, the key attached to it. For now.

Nico's mouth drops open, shock written across his face, before he sets his jaw and swallows thickly. He looks up at me, eyes brimming with a light mist. "May I?"

"Of course."

He takes the collar from the box with such care, and it sends me back to the first time he held Ember. He's soft with it, gliding his fingers along the chain before he rests the lock onto his open palm, caressing it with a light touch.

"Marie." The way he breathes my name undoes me and I land on my knees in front of him.

"I was dead when you found me, Nico. Living death, and I know that's what you saw in me. I don't know who I would be if you hadn't found me and offered me shelter, in your home and in your heart. You made me want to be a better person for myself and for my daughter. You gave me the courage to do something for myself first. I'm so grateful and so in love with you, Nico Capaldi. And I would be honoured to own you, fully. Body and soul. Now and forever."

His deep honey eyes land on me, the full force of his attention as intoxicating as the first time.

"You already own me, Marie. I'll wear your collar with pride. You are everything I want in a partner. You've never been afraid of me. You're patient. Kind. Devoted. You taught me what it's like to love, and you gave me a daughter. I'm forever yours."

Then, he's on me. His lips crash onto mine, fingers threading through my hair, the other hand that clasps the necklace is fisted behind my back and draws me closer. I'm not sure I own him at that moment, and I fully let go of any control. I delve my tongue into his mouth and he opens for me, letting me guide where we take this passion. I want to burrow so deep underneath his skin there won't be a moment I'm not with him.

I consume his lips with mine, mould my body to his, grip his shirt so he can't escape. Though he would never try. He tastes like hope and my solace. I breathe him in with every nip and lick, never letting up until I have to come up for air, panting.

"Let me own you," I breathe and he hands me the warm jewellery.

My throat dries as I open the lock. The gentle click sends a shiver up my spine and when I look up at Nico, I know he felt it too. Gliding the metal around his throat, I adjust it so the lock falls perfectly under the hollow of his throat, just above the place where he inked my name. Before I close it into place, I take a few seconds to luxuriate in the view.

Nico is still kneeling dutifully, obedient and pliable, my collar about to close around his throat, never to be open again. The 'r' of my name peaks from underneath the collar of his tee-shirt and the entire picture is so alluring, so enticing, I grow slick in my panties. "You look so perfect," I tell him.

"Please own me, Marie."

With these three words and my name on his tongue like a sin waiting to be committed, I lock the collar and we shudder at the sound. A slow smile spreads across his lips and I can't stop mine, my cheeks hurting from the happiness. Laughter bubbles in my throat and I let it out before I collapse into his waiting arms. Nico holds me tight, kissing my hair and neck, anywhere he can reach without letting go of me.

"What do we do with the key?" I ask.

Nico doesn't answer but lets me go, standing and holding his hand for the key. I give it to him, curious what he will do. He opens the sliding door to the patio and strides across it, flinging his arm in the air and throwing the key further than my eye can track. It lands somewhere in the field of Scottish Bluebells and with it being so small, I'm sure we won't find it any time soon.

I join him on the wooden deck and link my arms across his stomach, resting my face on his back. My eyes close and I breathe in the smells of the

summer in the forest. Pine and fresh dirt. My favourite.

Home.

“I love you,” I tell him.

Nico turns in my arms and shuffles with his pockets, then kisses my forehead, before dropping down... To only one knee this time.

“And I love you,” he says as he holds a black velvet box.

I slap my mouth shut with both hands to stifle my gasp when he opens it and I take in the beautiful ring inside. On a band of gold stands a stunning marquise cut smoky black diamond. It's simple and elegant. I'm speechless as Nico glides the ring onto my finger.

“Be mine, Marie Capaldi.”

Words escape me and I nod, letting him swoop me bridal style and carry me to our bed where we spend our first night as future husband and wife.

As we fall asleep in each other's arms, he absentmindedly caresses the tattoo on my collarbone while my hand rests on the bullet wound at his chest. With him at my side, I'll weather any storm. He's my rainbow.

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## TEN YEARS LATER

MARIE

“Mum! Leo and Gabe stole my phone,” I hear Ember yell from the other side of the exhibition hall, but I ignore her.

“You better fuck your cum into me faster, baby, or we’re gonna have a war on our hands.”

I pull my husband to me by the collar for a dirty kiss. He whimpers into my mouth and I get closer and closer to my peak. Every time he moans like he can’t get enough, he unravels me.

Now, my black silk dress is pulled over my hips as Nico drives into me with forceful thrusts, holding me up with his strong hands under my ass. He fucks me into the wall of the cleaning closet with fervour, never letting up despite how close to opening time we are.

“Are you gonna take my cum, Miss Marie? Are you gonna be dripping while I give a pretty speech about you as my muse?”

“Yes. God, yes. I want it,” I say. I’m mindless with lust, dark desire coursing through my bloodstream and making me let go more. I bite his lip until he bleeds and licks the copper taste with greed. “I want you to think of nothing else but how your wife is leaking your cum down her thighs while you stand there with your pretty cock in its cage, making it so painful you wince.”

“Fuck.”

Nico swears and his rhythm picks up even more as he drives into me and we come together, mouths fused to block out our sounds of pleasure.

This never gets old.

Nico drops me and my legs shake but I straighten up and let my dress fall back around me in a pool of soft fabric that accentuates my round belly. The very reason why we're fucking like teenagers instead of giving the room the final touches for Nico's art exhibit. Since we found out I'm pregnant with our fourth child, our twin boys have been insufferable and Nico has been insatiable, fucking me every night and multiple times a day if he can. As soon as the kids have their backs turned or are asleep, he's on me, fully embracing his breeding kink. And I can't say I'm complaining when I get so many orgasms.

"Mum!"

Ember's voice echoes right outside the closet and we both freeze before chuckling and exchanging a quick kiss. I lock the golden cage again around his length, right up his black suit—no tie—and fluff my hair. Then, we're out and trying to look as casual as we can.

We make our way to the main room, where our families chatter together and wait. One of the twins, Leo, rushes by and I have enough reflex to catch him and gather him against me.

"Give it back," I say sternly and his shoulders sag. He looks at me and I see how he clutches the phone against him. I raise a brow and he relinquishes his prize before taking off running again, probably finding Gabriele and making a new plan to annoy their sister. Who knew seven year-old boys could be such a pain in my ass? I wouldn't change them for the world but with the baby on its way, I've been more tired and running after my kids isn't how I plan to spend my evening. This second trimester is really kicking my butt. Not at all like it was for the boys. Nico thinks it's because the baby is a girl, but I'm not sure I agree. Once Nico has made his introduction and speech, I'm out of here.

I walk towards Giulia while Nico makes a beeline for his agent.

"Wow," she simply says then shakes her head.

"What?"

"Really, Marie? Here? Let me guess. It was the utility closet."

I blush and she beams before throwing her head back in a maniacal laughter. "Shut up."

"I get it, babe. Andrea did the same thing to me when we arrived thirty minutes ago. That closet is gonna see a lot of couples tonight, I bet you," she says with a salacious grin.

“Ew, I don’t need to know that,” I answer but there’s no heat in it.

“Do you think you’re the only horny people here? Speaking of, I don’t see Lana and Lisandru anywhere,” she muses before winking. “I’m kidding. They just texted that they’re on their way. How’s Nico?”

“He was a little stressed, but he’s okay now.” I bite my lip and Giulia chuckles. “We reviewed his speech twice in the car and probably ten times this week. So, he’s good and in case he’s not, his agent is amazing and will take over.”

We walk around the room as we continue to talk about his art.

I couldn’t be more proud of him. Over the past ten years, Nico had become more restless and even though he still helps with his previous activities sometimes, he’s turned to painting more and more to process his feelings and work through his compulsive thoughts and nightmares.

This exhibit is his second one. After how successful the first was, two years ago, he worked hard to get an agent and secure a bigger gallery, one with a good reputation and located in the heart of London.

People slowly fill in the space and it’s interesting to see the mix of crowds. To say the least. Mobsters and politicians exchange cold glances or cordial handshakes. The Dobrevs and the Venturas have been patrons, amongst others, and keep the peace between rival families with a hand of steel. Art journalists are patiently waiting for my husband and taking notes of the pieces displayed around the space.

We were a little wary of displaying certain pieces given that some are mementos of his ‘contracts’. But we carefully curated the most abstract and the results, mixed with self portraits painted in blood, and black and white of myself. The result is a haunting and disturbing kaleidoscope of pain, sadness and death. Nico isn’t renowned for colour or joyful landscape and I wouldn’t have him any other way. The memorable effect his art has on people is why the gallery’s so full tonight.

I look around the room and Nico’s agent gives me a slight nod. Making my way towards the front, I catch sight of my children, hunched over Ember’s phone in a corner. They’re not fighting or making too much sound so I leave them to it and listen as Nico shares a short explanation on what inspired him to draw these pieces.

“And finally, my wife. My beautiful Marie.” I walk to stand next to him and he takes my hand in his. “She’s always at the centre of my art. She walks close with death, my favourite muse as you all know. I wouldn’t be



the man I am or the artist I am without her. So you'll see many representations of all she is to me. My everything."

Applause rings around us and Nico dips his head, carefully avoiding anyone who wants to speak to him. His agent steps in front of him and answers curious questions for him while we make our way to a quiet corner. Andrea and Lisandru stay close by and I know our family will act as safeguards if anyone approaches. We must stay for another hour at least, but we do it on our terms.

Gabriele and Leo come to our side and hug their dad on each side, followed by Ember. Their little finger leaves traces of fat on their father's suit and I know they found the buffet. At least, they're not fighting anymore. "You draw weird shit, but it's beautiful," Ember tells her dad, and immediately, the twins jump on the occasion.

"We're not allowed to say 'shit', stinky-face," Leo says before sticking out his tongue.

"That's because you're a baby. And don't call me that," Ember replies before crossing her arms over her chest like it will give her a modicum of authority.

"I'll call you whatever I want," her brother teases and before I can separate them, they take off and she chases after them in a flurry of yells and expletives that definitely don't belong in the mouth of an eleven year-old.

I sigh as I watch them disappear into the crowd.

Nico's lips on my brow make me melt against him. I let him hold me and inhale the clean scent of his clothes. Pine and lemon mix and I release a calming breath.

"Let's get home, *luna mia*. I've had enough posturing for tonight."

"But it's your big night," I protest but he shuts me up with a lingering kiss that tastes like a promise.

"Art is only an escape. You're my forever." His hand glides against my stomach, affection, love and devotion shining into his amber irises. "You make me who I am," he says.

I caress his cheek and kiss him gently.

Forever isn't long enough with Nico Capaldi at my side.

THE END.

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## ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

Dear readers who picked up this book and took a chance on me, I cannot thank you enough. You are making my dream come true.

I started writing this story back in July 2024 and it was the hardest thing I've ever written. As I wrote Marie, more of my own memories surrounding alcohol consumption came back, and the shame I had to deal with was excruciating as I tried to give her justice, and give myself grace.

I've given these characters a piece of me, as I usually do with all my main characters, and I'm eternally grateful that they exist not only for me as a catharsis but hopefully for readers who will relate to them and love them as much as I do.

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## ABOUT THE AUTHOR



CJ Lucci is a passionate queer storyteller who writes romance for those who want to explore their desires and reclaim their power through swoon-worthy and morally ambiguous characters.

From darkness to light, CJ loves to offer options for readers to discover what titillate their brain, whether it's queer romance, a new trope you didn't even know you liked, a new kink, or a new take on mafia romance with women at the helm.



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